

Virelia

A history of broken things.

To you, reader, I offer this book without delusion. My world is a fruit of bitter juice. The well-fed will taste nothing in it but a tired chord at the end of a rich meal; but a dying man might chew on its rind and find that its flavor is rich, if an acquired one.

What follows are my records of Virelia as it fell and as it still stands. For eighteen centuries now, our gods have been gone, and left us to stumble through the remains of their creations. We reached for what tools were left in hopes of walking proud once again, and only succeeded in outpacing the catastrophe with one of our own making. The wars that followed eroded what breakage the Sundering had missed. What remains is a continent of isolated holdings, rifts in reality, unstable arcana and leftover humanoids struggling to concoct new meaning from what we've become.

This volume catalogues the regions, races, and factions that survive in the wreckage. Where the account seems unfair, spare me your judgment, for I did my best with what limited resources I had. You're welcome to step into the wilderness and make your own records, should my registers not suffice.



The Shining Age

Before time, Virelia was a place of divine order. There were as many gods as there were domains to maintain, and they directed the natural order by hand, lovingly carving each leaf and grain of sand into its proper shape.

Some relished the mortal races. They took delight in the attention, the adoration, the small intricate stories mortals could not help but conjure. Some saw no real difference between a man and a stone, and preferred tending to other projects: designing new physics, tending to a garden or perfecting a gust of wind to flutter around leaves in a manner that matches their exact taste. This was an era of beauty and miracles, where mountains were raised in symmetrical ranges and rivers softly trickled where they were commanded. The Gods walked the earth and had turned it into their heaven.

As a reflection of the gods' law, the immemorial **Remosan Empire** ruled over the vast majority of the continent. It was an extraordinary period of abundance coupled with immense hubris, when Gyre-Stones were built to regulate the weather, and imperial highways healed themselves over night.

War still happened, but it carried a different sentiment from what the word means now. Soldiers fell in battle and rose again the next morning, dusted off by the local god and sent home with a story to tell. The weapons they used, ones that modern Virelia knows only as legend, were left scattered across the fields after the day's fighting, to be picked up and put away back into the toybox.

There were no Rifts, there was nothing yet that could break, unless someone willed it.

The Sundering

There was no war in heaven. No warning either. One moment the gods were there, and the next they weren't. Eighteen centuries ago, give or take, the shrines went quiet, and the processions arrived at empty altars. Whatever the gods had been to the people who worshipped them, was now gone.

What followed took a little longer to arrive. Systems broke, in different ways, for different reasons we mostly still don't understand. The center of the continent fell inward into what's now called the Mire. Above Lastrago, the sky tore open in an event that came to be called the Mazur. Thirekhet had come down into Molakar to cool the desert into a sanctuary and got perhaps a third of the way through. Neither the ice nor the desert has given ground against the other in eighteen centuries.

Divine magic was the worst of it. It had been a tool, only useful the way a plough is, because something larger was pulling it. With the gods gone it went feral, and the survivors, who did not yet understand it had gone haywire, kept trying to use it. The results were on the scale you'd expect.

The Age of Silence

When the gods vanished, the people in charge of the Remosan Empire set themselves to fixing things, and they were the wrong people for the job. They were the innocent children of the Shining Age. They had never seen a wound that didn't close or a spell that failed. War, to them, was a kind of strenuous theater. Death was a story you told at dinner. The idea that an action could have a consequence which then stayed was not something their education had prepared them for.

And so they reached for the tools. The damage of the Sundering was severe but not yet total. The Imperial Highways still ran from coast to coast and healed themselves overnight. Grain still moved between provinces. The Gyre-Stones still stood across the empire, each holding its patch of the world steady. What was missing was the maintenance the gods had been quietly performing, and the empire's generals and archmages set themselves to replicate it. They had the old records and the leftover instruments, sometimes even vague memories of how these were once used. They had no idea what they were doing. They didn't even have the framework for understanding that their ignorance was dangerous.

The trouble was that they didn't agree on what needed restoring, or how. The Shining Age had as many priesthoods as it had gods, each with its own methods and records, and while the gods were present the differences hadn't mattered. After the Sundering they mattered enormously. Every surviving tradition believed it held the correct approach to a job none of their patrons had ever done alone, and none of them were willing to give an inch to the others.

The Age of Silence lasted longer than anyone expected. The damage scaled with the tools. The gods had left behind an entire apparatus of creation: forges, instruments, weapons, arcane infrastructure built to operate on a divine scale. Mortals now held all of it, understood very little of it, and had no way to test their ideas at anything less than full power. Mages reached for ruinous and experimental schools of magic, and were quick to weaponize them. The results irradiated whole populations and twisted entire villages into the crystalline Varn. Elsewhere the Kelarra Peaks tore loose from the continent and rose into the upper air, and are still there. When human soldiers proved too fragile for terrain that no longer behaved, the imperial bio-forges began producing the Orrak, designed from the start to survive what men could not. As famine and arcane radiation hollowed the labor base, the administration turned to the Graith: given the empire's last clear instructions, set to maintain the infrastructure no living workforce could.

None of it worked. Even the names of the priesthoods and the specifics of their disagreements have not survived. Many of the Soft Zones and Rifts on the modern map are the work of what later ages called the Witch Wars. They are artillery craters from when humanity broke the world trying to force it back into shape. By the end, the empire was still there in name, but it had used itself up. What came next happened because it no longer had the authority to hold the provinces together.

The Fracture Wars

There's no specific date I can point at where The Age of Silence ended. What matters is at some point people ran out of things to try, and Remosa's provinces began, quietly and then far less quietly, to defy their leadership. The first deserters are nameless now. Probably in provinces that no longer exist as distinct places. What most historians cite as the true beginning of the Fracture Wars is Trefgann's Synod of Secession, some two hundred years ago, when the mayors and guild-masters of Remosa's largest province, which also held the empire's former capital, formally slammed their gates against the empire. The Synod was not the first rebellion, but it was the first one that was organized enough to matter.

After Trefgann, the pattern repeated in Haldrith, Rivhalde, and Southfield. The era of grand armies was no longer. Those who replaced them were smaller, meaner, and fought over every last habitable scrap of land.

Remosa did not accept any of this. Three times across the years that followed the empire gathered what it had left and marched on Trefgann, each invasion smaller than the last and each one repulsed. The third was fifty years ago. Failed the way the others had, and at roughly the same border. Whether this counts as the end of the Fracture Wars is a question only the people who weren't doing the fighting bothered to ask. For everyone else, war was weather. No one could remember the world without it, and no one expected it to ever end.



The Fractured Era (The Current Day)

The last failed Remosan invasion of Trefgann was fifty years ago, and the Empire could no longer afford to organize a fourth. That is as close as we have come to peace. No treaty was signed and no borders were formalized, but the grand armies are gone, even though everything they were meant to protect us from is still here.

Rivhalde, Southfield, Haldrith, Trefgann and a handful of other regions hold their own ground, more or less, against the wildlands between. Less in most cases. Rifts still open in market squares on ordinary afternoons. Bandits take the roads the militia cannot afford to patrol. Rogue arcane weather drifts in from unstable areas and occasionally kills a village nobody had the manpower to warn. Trefgann still expects a Fourth March within the lifetime of its current children and trains accordingly. Is this peace? Either way, it is what it is.

Magic. Goddamned magic. The apparatus the Age of Silence left behind has been rotting for most of two millennia, and most people have decided they want nothing to do with what remains of it. They have reasons. A wall that mostly repairs itself is of no comfort when it occasionally throws a brick at your house. A road that mends overnight will, twice a generation, mend itself through a cart and the family in it. The few divine-era objects that still work reliably are guarded by people who understand them far less than they pretend to, and the ones that work unreliably kill more men than they have ever saved.

Religion has shifted from worship to archaeology. A handful of clerics still name their gods, either because their families never stopped praying or because the names survived in scholarship, but no living priesthood carries an unbroken tradition. Most clerics don't bother with the names at all. They channel what is theorized to be Divine Residue, tapping into leftover echoes of the vanished Gods like scavengers. The average person is atheistic, not as a philosophical position but as a practical one. The gods are no more. This is something a child learns early, alongside which neighbors to avoid.

In the absence of an empire, governance has settled into a multitude of pragmatic (and less pragmatic) arrangements: city-states, trade consortiums, industrial guilds, monastic orders, each ruling its own island and answerable to nothing larger than its own survival. Authority is measured in what a ruler can secure for his people: food, safe roads, protection against whatever drifts in from the wild. No one rules further than they can reach. Factions trade because they must, cooperate where their interests align, and guard their borders against rivals and the encroaching wild with equal vigilance. Contracts, coin, and the constant threat of collapse hold local order together. No one is under the illusion that they have built anything that will outlast them.

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The Regions of Virelia

Twelve regions, and not one country between them.

While the land is intact, although bruised, the continent's regions stand mostly alone. The ground between holdings has gone hostile enough that steady trade and diplomacy are more aspiration than practice, and what a caravan brings home from the next region over has often been paid for in more than coin.

Where the land stopped being the immediate problem, often the neighbors picked up the slack. The central regions function anyway, after their own fashion. The edges are a more complicated story, and they each have their fair share of problems. In some places the struggle is justified by resources which cannot be found elsewhere. In some, the locals are bullheaded madmen if you ask me.

The regions are not, for all this, uniformly grim. People marry, build, and quarrel over inheritances in places the empire would have written off as uninhabitable. Whatever the Sundering took, it was not our small communities or the quarrels inside them.



Knotsreach

Ma, Don't use the map Dad bought, it's useless past the ridge. When you reach the split rock, turn left, but only if the left path is still there. If it isn't, sit down and have lunch until you notice it. It usually comes back. After that, walk until the wind feels warm on your neck, then stop. Do not follow the deer trail, even if it looks faster. Just wait there and shout my name. I'll come get you. It's not far, just... tricky.

Letter found in a mud-stained envelope near the border

The Garden of Forking Paths

A lush rugged highland that makes for a great place to lose things, and a terrible one for anything else but. Deep forests, jagged hills, with an alien, uncomfortable beauty to it all. The terrain is shifting, unstable. It is as deadly as it is unreliable. All on account of what the locals have lovingly (?) named Wendy, and everyone else calls by its name: the Wending. Voices of insects fill the area, and anything that can hold a pine needle, does indeed. The trees look just a bit off from a distance, but take a closer look and you'll see them fold inwards violently. Same goes for everything else here. Rivers flow uphill before correcting into loops that lead nowhere. Roads coil back on themselves. Fog swirls unnaturally, and the ground moves under your boots without you noticing. None of the neighboring regions dare cross this place, and navigating it is impossible for the rigid-minded. Survival requires one of two things: a scholarly, almost mathematical grasp of the shifting patterns, or an extremely sharp intuition. Those who rely only on their eyes and strict logic will find themselves walking in circles until they starve.



The Next Best Thing

During the Witch Wars, a large Rift opened in this highland and disgorged something the imperials could not kill. No record of it survives, unfortunately. What did survive is what they did in response. Lacking the means to kill the creature or close the Rift, they settled for something adjacent to competence: to scramble the terrain around it into a labyrinth no hostile force could cross. The spell worked. It also kept working. What was meant to warp the ground around the creature wrapped around the imperials themselves and spread outward, until the whole highland had been folded into its own geometry. A miscalculation, in retrospect. The Rift, if it is still there, sits somewhere near the center, under terrain nobody has managed to reach in eighteen centuries. The locals call the phenomenon Wendy, and maintain that the land is a living thing, resisting any attempt to solve it.

The Wending

Research into the Wending has been all the rage in recent centuries, since, if solved, the region could become a much-needed connective route between Tavernash, Remosa, and Haldrith. I won't entertain the ceaseless babbling of the scientists, but to my understanding, current research suggests it is a mixture of perception distortion and genuine physical displacement. Though nobody has managed to observe it directly, the evidence for the latter lies in how nature adapts to it. The previously described trees and rivers, for a start, and the ground underneath them, which makes no sense if you bothered digging in it.

There's a particular type of lichen here that I grew fond of. It locks down against the rock when the ground around it destabilizes, pulling inward and shifting to a gentle ember color until conditions settle. People use it to navigate, or perhaps better to say, they use it to discern when it's time to stop navigating.

And this pretty much sums up what it's like traveling within Knotsreach a humbling experience which most people would only choose to go through once. One must rely on what's in front of him at the time, and nothing else, and even that can't be taken for granted. People either stick to their lighthouse-like homes, stay on the go with their carriage houses, or try to blend in with the tangle in hopes that they'll remain hidden. Escapees, druids, or an extreme variant of solitudinarians. You can find them all here, meaning, the population is small.

Nature's Arsenal

In contrast to the land's freneticism, most wildlife in Knotsreach shows surprising laziness. They stalk, hibernate, lie in wait, dig in. Anything that lets them sit in place and wait for long periods of time. Birds mostly avoid the place, which has allowed rodents and small insects to proliferate. Maybe that is why they never adapted the same way, and continue to scuttle about aimlessly.

Mimics are extremely common, dressed up as fallen trees or butt-tempting rocks. Following the same principle, kamadans, cloaklers and shambling mounds also use the region as a hunting ground. Displacer Beasts have earned a special mention. They don't hunt in packs anywhere else, but here they've learned to. Lurking in the canopy, using illusion and numbers in equal measure to prey on anything and everything. You can't escape them, and you can't tell which ones are real. Many think it's the worst thing in Knotsreach, and I don't beg to differ.

The prey is less impressive, but still worth mentioning. Everyone has to feed on something, after all. For example, there's a burrowing rodent the locals call a knuckle, about the size of an apple, dark brown, and not particularly bright. They burrow underneath rocks to avoid predators, mainly kamadans. This is theorized to be the reason "rock mimics" have become so abundant. The knuckles haven't caught up yet, and so young mimics feed on them until they reach adulthood, when they can feed on sloth bears and the occasional human.

Beyond Luznica?

There isn't enough to govern, and so nobody bothers to. A refreshing concept, to be honest. Luznica is the only major settlement, though that might count as cheating as it sits on the outskirts of the Wending, and serves as a hub for the type of people who think Knotsreach is fascinating rather than dangerous. Not fascinating enough to live inside it, mind you. That spot is saved for the truly lost. First conceptually, and then quite literally.

I'll be frank, describing whatever goes on in Knotsreachean society is a challenge, since society is doing some heavy lifting in that sentence. I think I'd serve you better by describing a particular native. Take Odilile Neembranch. She's a halfling merchant. People more generous than I would describe her as a "free spirit". I'd say she's a random hermit who wanders randomly from place to place, and will probably die just as randomly. Odilile came to Knotsreach some twenty years ago on a supply run and never left. Time might tell if this is by choice or not. One way or another, she, exhaustingly, describes the region as beautiful without a trace of irony. She hunts whatever comes across her, and trades leftovers for necessities and anything that's pickled. Her carriage is pulled by Papaya, her pet bear, and she seems to have decided that it serves as better company than anyone else she might have to share a road with. She survives off the path while attempting to move from one household's beacon to another's. Trades, and moves on. It could be seen as a sad existence, but she'd wave it away with "it's all about the road" or some other cliché.

Rumors:

But Why Are They Warm: Random objects made of clay have been washing down a river from the deep interior. Smooth, well made. They started appearing three months ago. The scholars in Luznica are thrilled, and want the source investigated.

Evolution: New beacons began appearing in the deep reaches. A known trader followed one and was found half eaten later, no beacon in sight. One more died similarly a week later. Locals are worried. Someone, or something, is exploiting the system.

The Untying: A group of Luznican scholars have come to believe that the shifting pattern can be broken mathematically if it was only slightly expanded eastward. They are attempting to recreate a weaker version of the original spell to expand the Wending and “complete the equation”.

Heartache: A couple that has lived in the region for decades have decided they’ve had enough of each other. They insist one of them must leave, but they keep accidentally returning to the same place. In the meanwhile, the husband lives in a shed in the yard, but they insist this cannot continue. Their daughter is worried for her father’s safety in such an undefended structure.

Gold Rush: A rich Haldrithian merchant wishes to create a “Knotsreach zoo” in Luznica, and looks to hire help to capture native species. Most locals resist, thinking this is either stupidity or a dangerous intrusion of nature. The argument is becoming heated, and sabotage is apparently no longer off the table.



Molakar

"Come on, Lenny. I know you're tired, but even that shell won't protect you from that hail storm. Up-up, boy! We have to reach Ravelstead before the weather changes on us again. You get us there, I get you a carrot. Deal?"

Jek, Strider-Rider, muttering to his mount

The 1800 Years' War

Ah, the ancient sands of Molakar, scarred only by deep crystalline valleys known as Veins. The sand runs the color of old bone and glitters where the grains half-turned to glass, sharp enough to cut through boot leather. By noon the sand can blister skin at a touch. By early morning it has cooled to a brittle crust.

Settlements sit in close proximity to the Veins for both water and work. Most are half-dug into the desert floor, with thick walls to handle the temperature swing and strong winds. The clans work in the four usable hours at either end of the day and shelter through the rest, which is most of life out here. The downtime is used for cards, repair work, arguments about water rations, and some more arguments about anything else really.

Veins are another matter. Two kilometers across at their widest, hundreds of meters deep, their walls fluted ice the color of aquamarine. Every block cut from those walls is worth more than the lives of the men sent to cut it. Meltwater runs down the west faces when the sun catches them, pools on the floor, and freezes back into the wall overnight. Where cold air meets the heat above, the edge throws up a permanent curtain of steam that hides it from anyone standing more than a few paces off.

The boundary between the two is called the Cannonade by the Molakari. A band of unstable air perhaps fifty meters wide where the desert and the Vein argue in hurricanes and gusts. Crossing it on foot in the wrong minute has killed more travelers than bandits and thirst combined. The worst of it can lift an entire caravan and set it down half a kilometer away, usually in pieces.



A God's Job

The records mention a god named Thirekhet, one of "stillness and endlessness," who took the region for his playground and set about turning it into something other than sand. He began at the foundations: Cooling the stone, hardening the groundwater into crystal, probably working outward from wherever he had chosen to stand. He got perhaps a third of the way through before he vanished with the rest. That's the charitable summary. While apparently not endless himself, his work has been. The Veins preserve what falls into them, wreak havoc on the local weather, and stand as proof that an artist's work outlasts the artist.

The Clanholds

Authority in Molakar rests with the Clanholds: ten extended families who between them run the ice trade. Anyone is free to walk out into the desert and try to cut ice, but newcomers typically come back empty-handed or not at all. The clans work the trade through competing methods and are openly hostile toward rival traditions.

Ishkane rely on inherited knowledge: route patterns, Cannonade timing, how to read a Vein wall. Training begins before a child can walk and continues for fifteen years. Crews are small, disciplined, and almost entirely blood. Losses are low but so is the output.

Clans like Toruna run on scale. Larger crews, cheaper equipment, hired labor from outside the family on wages that make the risk worthwhile. Losses run high and occasionally catastrophic, but the volume covers the methods. To the traditionalists, this is a mockery of the craft.

Aylagu and Serimai have risen to prominence in the last two generations, and they have risen loudly. They invest in enchanted gear: cold-resistant armor, cable harnesses, reinforced caravan shells that can take a Cannonade. The cost of a single expedition is tenfold the older methods, and the money is spent with the confidence of a worthwhile investment. Where it comes from is not entirely clear. Their crews extract remains preserved in the depths of the Veins, and the older clans call them grave-robbers. They are also, to the traditionalists, uncultured, vulgar, and incapable of understanding why that would matter.

The Slow Road

Long-distance travel across Molakar happens on the backs of Strider-Tortoises. A strider lost to a Cannonade is a year's setback for its clan. They are heavy, slow, and built for this exact landscape. Their shells hold heat through the cold hours and shed it through the hot ones. Their legs are long enough to keep their bodies three meters above sand that would blister anything standing on it. They move at roughly twelve kilometers a day and refuse to move faster. A caravan's pace is a strider's pace, which is to say the rhythm of Molakari life is slower than anywhere else on the continent.

The Whole Arm

Anything cold-aligned amplifies within hundreds of meters of the Veins. A cooling cantrip meant for a waterskin can frost an arm to the elbow. Fire is the opposite. It does not work at all.

A related phenomenon is the Cold-Touched: Molakari Karex, perhaps one in a generation, born with an immunity to cold. It is theorized the Veins act as a type of Rift, or Rift-adjacent concept, and their effects bleed into the surrounding desert. Some Karex born under that influence carry the cold in them in addition to the *usual* unusual disorders. Even a rumor of one is cause enough for an all-out war between the clans, as has been proven on several past occasions.

Rumors:

The Expanding Vein: A well-mapped Vein has begun to widen. The ice is creeping outward at a meter a day, and the nearest village will be under crystal within the season. The elders believe something has stirred deep in the ice and is trying to finish the god's work.

The Glass Tomb: A sandstorm has scoured a dune and exposed a perfect dome of blue crystal where nothing should be. It has no opening. Those who lay a hand on it report hearing a heartbeat, slow and slowing. The clans cannot agree whether to break it open or bury it again before the rumor spreads.

The Empty Vein: An Ishkane crew returned from a Vein they had been working for three generations to find it cleaned out, the stable seams gone, and Aylagu sled-tracks leading away. Aylagu denies the route was theirs. The Ishkane have called for arbitration in Ravelstead. Both clans are also quietly preparing for the arbitration to fail.



Southfield

"Brennan's ox, again! You can't tell me that crackpot raised such a beauty. Everyone knows he's at it with his sheep! You know I fucking heard him sneeze in the middle of the street the other day? The man is a savage."

Overheard at Flatford's annual fair

Far from the Madding Crowd

Southfield is a simple-minded region, one of hardy people, traditionalists, farmers mostly. Good potatoes, mediocre poetry, and old people glaring at strangers. The weather is windy, on the cold side throughout most of the year, and fits the gloomy atmosphere that lurks throughout the region. The cottages are built low and thick. The sheep outnumber the people, and probably have more to say too.

For most of its post-Sundering history, Southfield was home to a region-wide rift that made noise leech on vitality. The exact nature of the phenomenon was never entirely understood, but the evidence was unquestionable. Where there was noise, life dwindled. Crops died. Stillborns were more common. Cattle got sick. The rift has been waning for roughly a century, and in the last fifty years was declared to no longer affect the land at all. Despite this, the locals mostly maintain the habits they developed during that period. Southfield is exceptionally quiet. Whether out of tradition or trauma depends on who you ask.



Death Whispered a Lullaby

The rift arrived within the first century after the Sundering. By the time anyone understood what was happening, it was already too late. At first people thought the region was cursed. Imagine realizing years later that all of this suffering, death and famine were preventable. Once the pattern was understood, the adaptation was fast and total. Festivals stopped. Forges allowed to work only under an active Silence spell. Tools dampened with wool, and livestock was culled to breeds that made less noise. The architecture changed within a generation: walls thickened, doors got heavier, roofs were lined with whatever would muffle the rain. People latched onto anything they could in an attempt to fight the rift. The communities that adapted survived. The ones that couldn't are no more.

Sign language emerged as the region's main form of communication: a vocabulary of gestures borrowed from shepherds and dock-hands, expanded over generations into something precise enough for day-to-day conversations. Written slates replaced negotiation in public spaces. Within a few generations the silence stopped being a response to danger and became the ordinary texture of daily life.

The rift began to fade roughly a century ago. The first generation to notice treated the signs as luck. The second renewed research of the anomaly. Then about fifty years ago, a council of village elders formally declared the rift is no more. The fact that it is so is not enough to convince most Southfielders that things can now change.

All Quiet on the Southern Front

When Southfield was considered cursed, the empire was quick to write the region off. They didn't have the means to aid it while the fracture wars were taking place, and they were worried the rumors of a dying region would become ones about a dying empire. Nobody wants to be in the same room with a plague victim, after all. With the empire gone, so went most commoners. Only the stubborn and the poor remained. Decades later, when the rift was discovered and adapted to, the locals grew fearful of the empire's return, and so they contacted the Compact.

Seeing an agricultural region with no imperial oversight and a population too small to resist, the Compact was quick to accept. They sent administrators, auditors, and soldiers, and quickly integrated themselves into Southfield's political system. The administrators filed reports that grew shorter each quarter. The region, despite its potential, was poor. Hard headed farmers and local oddities stemming from the rift required more adaptation than the Compact could muster. Within a decade, they cut their losses and signed a protection agreement: Southfield pays a yearly tax. The Compact claims the region on paper. In exchange, the Compact does nothing at all, which is precisely what Southfield has always wanted from the people in charge of it. The arrangement keeps the Lienhunters out and the imperial banners from coming back. It is, by Southfield's standards, the most successful negotiation in the region's history.

Farmers' Market

Each village runs itself, and the conventions vary enough between them that a farmer from the interior would find the coastal settlements odd. Once a year, the villages send representatives to a general council, held at a rotating location, where the agenda covers road maintenance, the Compact's tax allocation, and whatever local problems have grown large enough to require outside opinion. The rest of the year, the villages have no obligation to each other and mostly act like it. This works until it doesn't and then works again after everyone has had time to cool down. I think the strongest law that holds Southfield together is probably just inertia.

This is, incidentally, one of the reasons the Compact's integration failed as thoroughly as it did. They arrived expecting a political structure to slot into and found a region that runs on local oddities and has no centre to govern from. An administrator can issue a decree. The question is who, exactly, would carry it out.

Those Who Remain

The exodus during the cursed years gutted the region, and it never fully recovered. Humans make up most of it. Dwarves are the next largest group, and the culture suits them: quiet, practical, and uninterested in performance. A scattering of Orraks settled after the Fracture Wars, mostly ones with no ties to Remosa worth preserving. Beyond that, not much. Myrrkin avoid the place entirely, for obvious reasons, and Halflings are not far behind them. The region is too conservative and too gloomy to attract visitors, and too quiet to keep them.

Rumors:

Have You Ever Seen The Rain: An onion farmer is worried that the rainfall this fall won't be enough. He needs someone to clear out a group of bandits who settled by the nearby lake so he can divert the water. Rudely enough, the bandits are singing drunk songs at night, and he is convinced the noise is souring his crop.

The Taxman: The Compact's annual tax collector has arrived three months early, accompanied by a surveyor and six Lienhunters. He claims the Protection Agreement entitles the Compact to a "periodic review of territorial assets." The nearest village council is looking for hired muscle to escort the delegation through the region and ensure they leave on schedule. The Compact surveyor is quietly mapping things that have nothing to do with taxes.

The Harvest of the Living: Three weeks ago, a merchant was found dead on the Quiet Road between Netclam and Glaskatch. What unsettled the locals is not just the killing, but the fact that it was loud. Travelers kilometers away reported hearing screaming that lasted for hours. The nearest village council is looking to find whoever is responsible and deal with them. A second body was found just last week.

Myrskov

"There's a crow outside my house that's been doing Tansya's voice for a month. Wakes me at dawn telling me I'm late. She finds it hilarious."

Bram Jensik, resin-tapper at Brackwater Hold

The Overlapping Land

Spruce, hemlock, cedar, fir... Point is it's mostly just trees, slow rivers, and standing fog. Unremarkable if not for the fact that some time after the Sundering, the realm of Myrr collided with this part of Virelia and bent the local area's behavior in passing. Unfortunately, the collision destroyed most of Myrr, and continues to do so. As for Myrskov, it has been subject to a quality which I can only describe as "intertwining". It is hard to detach the concept from the spiritual mumbo jumbo that wraps the whole thing, but I'll do my best. Things in Myrskov seem to aspire to become a part of their surroundings. A village dog might pick up on local human habits. Speech, even. Riverside pebbles "sweat", and a newly dug road quickly dissolves into the surrounding forest. People call this peculiar configuration "home" despite it all, which has to amount to something.

Settling In

The forest is healthy, in its way. Game is plentiful, the soil is rich, and the winters are no worse than Haldrith's. One might be tempted to think that building a life in here will be easy. They couldn't be more mistaken. Build somewhere with no history, no "presence", and you'll quickly find that it's harder to form complete sentences and everything you've built slowly dissolves into the forest. The more common tactic is to expand what's already out there. It's a struggle, but you'd have a higher chance than in fighting the forest head-on. Unless you're either up to the task, or willing to give in completely, of course.

For those who managed to stick around, awaits a glorious life full of goats, gardening, trapping, foraging and the occasional encounter of something truly bizarre. Spend a day in one of these villages and the intertwining becomes obvious. A village always looks like they're sharing a gene pool. The vegetables look like they're from the same garden, no matter where you've picked them. There's a dull uniformity to the whole mess. Tranquil, "natural", or a tad too intimate. I suppose you can think of it as both.

The one genuine export that allows the whole thing to last is Barkmail. Strips taken from Hemlocks grown along the mountain border toward Kellarra, where the wood picks up the stone's properties. Dried over weeks, the result is a material lighter than wood and harder to split than oak. Armorers buy the bulk for shields, utensils and furniture. The premium grades go to coopers in Tavernash, who age their wine in Barkmail casks and charge accordingly.

The Collision

Before the Sundering, Myrskov was a forest. Trees, fog, the usual. What happened next is a matter of theory. The prevailing one holds that the gods had been keeping the rules of Virelia cleanly separate from those of every neighboring realm, and that when they left, that separation became blurry. Virelia's rules and Myrr's began to overlap. Where they overlapped hardest, here, the two tore open against each other. The Myrrkin themselves do not agree on what exactly happened and who, if anyone, should be held responsible. My only opinion on the matter is that the scholars who defend this theory use the word "membrane" a great deal.

Myrr was a place that responded to the people living in it. Atmosphere followed mood, emotion took shape in color and fauna. It was simply how the place ran, and everything in it had grown up working with it. Plants drew on the shared experience like Virelian plants draw on sunlight. The Myrrkin flourished through it without noticing it was there. Fish in water, so to speak.

Virelia is built differently. Things here are what they are regardless of who is looking, mostly, anyway. When the two collided, Virelia's rigidity began bleeding into Myrr and has been killing it ever since. What leaked the other way is what Myrskov is living with. Myrr, however, cannot become Virelia. Its ecology, its air, its ground, all of it was built around a shared experience. Where the Virelian rules reach, Myrr stops working. Forests collapse, rivers go still, whole valleys empty out. The Myrrkin who reach Myrskov are leaving a home that is rapidly being made uninhabitable.

Remosa attempted to hold the region during the Fracture Wars and gave up within a decade. Walls may keep out the forest but not its effects, and a garrison that loses men to the woods faster than it can recruit them is not a garrison for long.

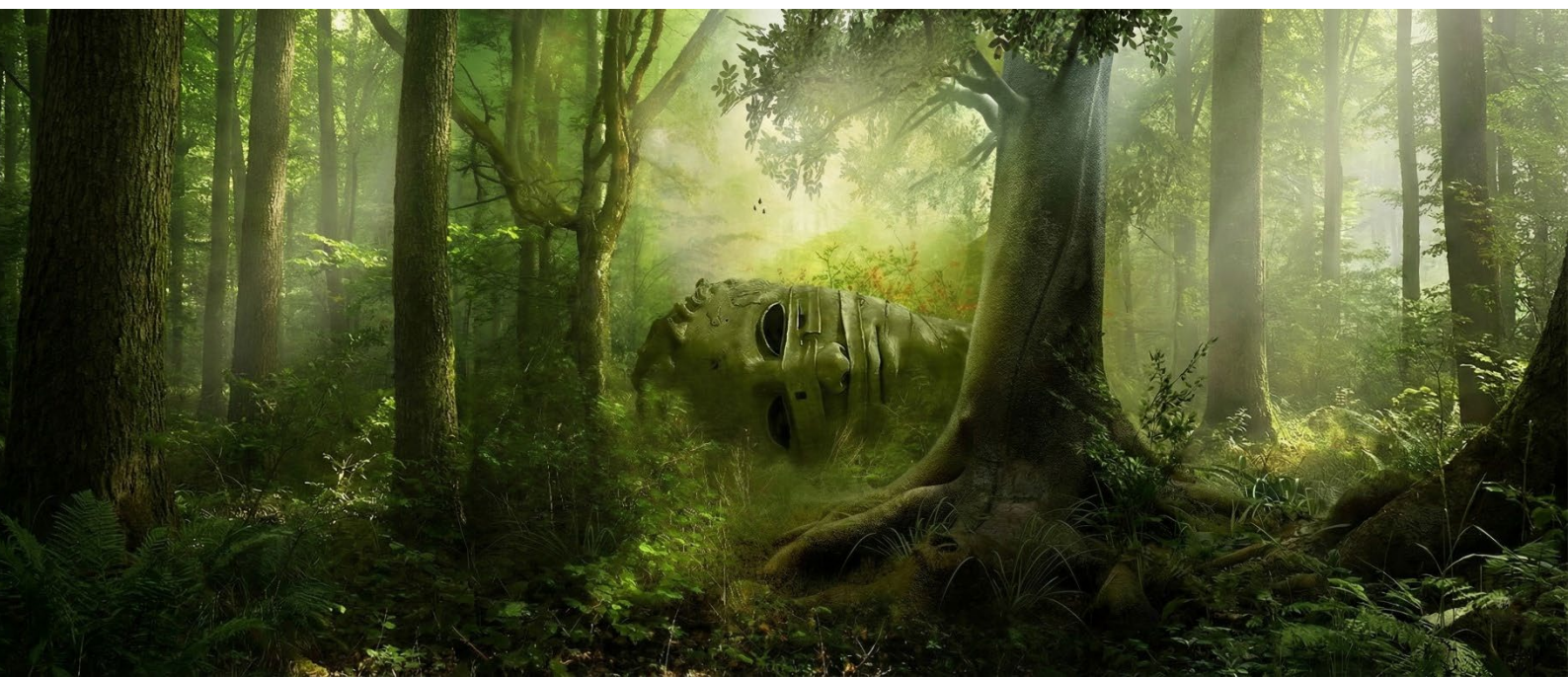


A Druid's Job

Myrskov is governed by what is essentially an old argument between two groups. At least one of which is insufferable, but I'll let you be the judge. The Druids consider themselves ambassadors of the forest, and are treated as such by the local communities, partly out of respect and partly because nobody else can do what they do. When a grove starts pulling too hard on a nearby settlement, when the roots start threading through foundations and the walls begin sweating sap, a Druid is the one you want. Even though their methods are opaque and their priorities are obvious. A Druid circle relocating a family because some shrub needs the space is the sort of thing that happens here with a regularity that has earned the ridicule of the rest of the continent. They also mediate disputes between villages, which in Myrskov tend to involve questions that would make no sense anywhere else.

The Listeners are the other half of the arrangement, and the half more likely to take the stubborn villager's side. They're traditionalists who walk the Chime Routes, old paths hung with iron bells and bone wind chimes that have been soaking in the forest long enough to register its shifts. Reading them is a practiced skill, passed down by apprenticeship, one Listener picking a child and spending a decade until the child replaces the teacher and the cycle of exploitation continues. They carry news, small trade goods, warnings about which paths have gone sour. Stay off their routes long enough and the forest starts thinking you're a part of it. Past a certain point the Druids stop calling it a rescue and weapons are drawn. Ferals are dangerous, erratic. Think a pack of wolves with bows and well-planned traps. Which is why the villagers welcome the Listeners with open arms, and pay the organization the closest thing the region has to a tax. The Halcyons, naturally, think the whole operation is quaint. Their runners pass through Myrskov on continental routes and deliver mail faster than any Listener could. The Listeners tolerate the Halcyons the way a farmer tolerates a neighbor's dog that keeps barking in the night. As in, not really.

Some would say the Druids are out of touch, and they'd have a point. Some would think the Listeners are sentimental, and they'd have a point. When it's urgent they work together, usually badly. The rest of the time they argue, and I suspect the region would collapse without either the cooperation or the arguing.



Meet The Neighbors

The fey have been multiplying here since the collision. By this point they're everywhere in Myrskov, the little buggers. Mimicking your voice back at you with the wrong emphasis, moving your tools when you're asleep, drawing faces on rocks. Children grow up knowing the rules: don't accept, don't follow, don't argue. Some do anyway. Their king, Chopp, holds court next to an oak tree that serves as a consultant. The Listeners maintain a working relationship with him, mostly because he controls which stretches of forest the fey leave alone and which ones they make unbearable. He is also the main reason the Remosan invasion of Myrskov some 210 years ago failed as catastrophically as it did. The empire committed four legions and had spent significant resources to build Brackwater Hold as a permanent garrison at the region's center. Chopp didn't appreciate it, and so the campaign, later known as the Overgrown War, began.

Supply lines collapsed within the first year. Wagons arrived carrying the wrong cargo, no cargo, or pinecones packed neatly where food should have been. Soldiers on long patrols stopped coming back. The ones who did were changed, unable to remember their rank or why they'd come. Severe insomnia spread through the army and did not lift. Men who hadn't slept in weeks stopped distinguishing their own thoughts from the sounds of the forest. The Druids and the forest did their share, no doubt. An angry druid in his natural habitat is a sight to behold. "And the roots feasted on blood", as the local poem goes. But it was the fey who showed the civilized world how cruel a joke can be. The laughter from the foliage never stopped, not once, for three years. The empire threw four legions at the forest. What came out was perhaps a quarter of that, and much of it had stopped being useful as soldiers. The empire withdrew, quietly, without a real fight ever taking place. Chopp seems to have forgotten about the whole ordeal since.

Rumors:

The Tamer: A Rivhaldean researcher named Bratos set up camp outside Brackwater with three ferals in chains. He claims they can be rehabilitated, that the intertwining can be reversed with controlled reintroduction, and that his work will save lives. Several families have recognized one of them as a trapper who went missing last spring, and the word "slavery" has started making the rounds. The families want him arrested, tried, and removed. The problem, as it always is in Myrskov, is that there is nobody to do the arresting, no court to hold a trial, and no precedent for any of it. The Druids have declined to get involved. The Listeners are split.

Kidnapped: A Listener named Edea took a child from Othrelmark four months ago. By tradition, this is how it works, and the village accepts it as part of the arrangement. Othrelmark doesn't. The family says the child was taken without consent, and had stopped paying its levy. The Listeners have never had to enforce collection before, and the argument over whether they should, or even can, has opened a rift in the organization.

Lastrago

"Everything is wet. My boots are molding while I wear them. The paper in my ledger is turning to mush. I have to oil my sword three times a day or it rusts in the scabbard. I hate this place. The cinnamon, though..."

Sheylok Genn, merchant

When It Rains

Mold and mosquitoes. Thus declared whatever god created Lastrago as it is. Thick canopy, above it tower the Barktrail and the cities, all carried on stilts. And further up, the Mazurat, "Sky rivers". All this glory, filled to the brim with mold and mosquitoes. A jungle of mad prophets calculating the elements day and night, and their flock, which happens to produce some of the best spices a tongue could come across. Such is Lastrago, with its roaring thunder and its somber rain.

Interestingly, if you buy into the Tavernashi claim that Kenosis is a philosophy and nothing else, Lastrago is probably the only place where religion has gained a foothold in Virelia. The Mazurat are their masters, and they can be oh so cruel. An unprepared village can get wiped off the map in a single tempest. Ferocious waves of rain, and winds strong enough to break bone. I'd pray too.

Their only line of defense are their priests, the Mazuren. Part meteorologists and part oracles. They decide where a village is built, when a harvest is abandoned, which stretch of the Barktrail is safe to walk this season. After which the spice farms follow: cinnamon, ginger, vanilla, medicinal herbs. Grown quickly and to colossal heights. All respectfully sit where the Mazuren allow and await their turn to be harvested. Meanwhile the people sit on their pillows at their ridiculously small tables, drinking hot tea and eating the local spiced abominations they call food.



A Ripple in the Pond

We know the people of Shining Age Lastrago really liked the unpleasant part of the alphabet, all these "Tz" and "Ch" sounds. Unfortunately, they didn't leave us enough of it to work out their language. What pieces remain lie in the names of some settlements that survive to this day. Then, following the Sundering, came the Mazurat. That much we know for sure. Apparently river-shaped storms are enough of a thing for everyone to write about in all the languages that were available at the time. I've read conflicting records of the event itself, the "Mazur". The Mazuren myth is especially vivid. "Sacred water from the tears of the gods who were forced away". I will spare you the details of the myth, point is it's probably bollocks. The foreign accounts are more useful. If we filter the noise, they repeat roughly the same thing: the sky cracked, water poured, and since then it's all mold and mosquitoes.

After a long period of chaos, comes a Karex named Pakara with glowing eyes who's good at predicting the weather, and so a new religion is formed. One must wonder if we were always so unexacting towards the divine. Anyway, they built their first temple in Azwighen, and given enough time, temples always turn into bureaucracy. The Mazuren established their rule in the next few centuries. They built the (very impressive) Barktrail, the cities as they stand today, and a culture that quite literally worships the weather. Lucky for them, they weren't tested on much more than that. The Fracture Wars never got here. Trefgann separates them from Remosa's reach, and they've prospered for it.

Downstream

Imagine a deep, turbulent river, sweeping up anything in its path in an unrefined demonstration of power. Now, take that same river, and lift it off the ground. Constantly on the move, raining from above, twisting and curling like a snake on a warpath. Imagine this, and you get a single Mazurat. Lastrago has about ten at any given time, each with its own kill count and name. On a calm day you can watch one crawl across the horizon trailing rain like a hem. On a bad day one drops.

The Lastragans call it a cascade. The word undersells it. A cascade strips canopy, soil, and anything built on either down to bare rock. A recount I came across goes: "Kichavvo had called for the evacuation two days prior. He said we were lucky to have one so early. I've waited a week for things to quiet down before I came back, hoping to grab some of my things from the ruins. There was nothing. The entire village, gone. Trees snapped at the base, roots in the air, as if the Mazurat has made a deliberate choice to leave absolutely nothing behind. Seventeen people who refused to leave are still buried there, under the mud."

The canopy then closes over the cascade site within weeks. The water the Mazurat carries is heavy with minerals and compounds nobody has been able to identify or replicate. Where it hits, the soil turns obscenely fertile. Cinnamon bark grows as thick as a loaf of bread. Vanilla reaches the canopy in a single season. The spice farmers know this, and follow the cascades with complete disregard to whatever

might have been there prior. They plant in the still-wet soil before the mud has settled, harvest what they can before the forest reclaims it, and move on. The whole economy runs on the aftermath of disasters the Mazuren spend their lives trying to predict. Somewhat ironic, to have a nation officially organized around cleaning up after their modern gods' mess.

Upstream

The Barktrail is a massive road on pylons of petrified wood and cut stone, rising above the canopy and connecting Azwighen to Tinzarit and out to Imellah. Apparently a devoted public with access to mathematics can accomplish quite the feats. Probably better not to let the modern Remosan bureaucrats know that. It was routed through stretches historically safe from the Mazurat, and built to survive one anyway. The two cities at either end follow the same logic: steep roofs, runoff funneled into aqueducts that roar beneath the walkways during storms. Everything angled, braced, channeled. A coordinated machine for surviving a waterfall. The farming villages, as always, weren't quite so lucky. They build lighter, because a Mazuren can declare their home abandoned the moment the skies demand it.

The Mazuren rule is too ramified to summarize in a single paragraph, or an entire book for that matter. What I will say is that it relies on two pillars. The first are the Storm-Marked. Karex, taken from their families young, strapped to the temple spires for the next breaking cascade. Most die up there. The survivors gain some sort of insight into the storms, and then it's a childhood of meteorology lessons followed by a life of tasting water and calculating charts. The highest of honors in Lastragan society. A priest whose reading later fails is offered the same spire again. Or there's exile. The Mazuren call it the Second Drowning. Fittingly, as most don't survive.

The second are the archives. Both Azwighen and Tinzarit keep branching catacombs filled with rows of stone pools, each holding water from a recorded cascade. Priests take a sample and "taste" the conditions that produced it, cross-referencing against their current charts. Basically wine tasting with no alcohol nor fun. The priesthood employs collectors for this. Reckless fanatics who run toward the Mazurat with a pot in their hand while everyone else runs the other way. Foolish, stupid, simple-minded, indispensable idiots.

The Locals

Lastragan "traders" mostly sit on their ass next to a pile of cinnamon and wait for the people who want it to come to them, which they reliably do. Caravans make the trip because cascade-grown spices grow nowhere else, and the Mazuren know this well enough to set terms nobody refuses. The temples allocate the cascade sites, approve the harvest, take their cut, and bless whatever's left for export. Religion and commerce are the same apparatus here, as is the case anywhere else, really. The elves figured this out centuries ago and wanted no part of it. Their villages in the deep canopy predate the Mazuren, and they've kept to themselves since. The Mazuren let them because pretending they don't exist is easier than searching, and

no priest wants to deal with an outsider that might disagree with his methods. A sensible arrangement, all things considered. Rare for Virelia.

The two temples don't always agree, and the Lastragans made this the local equivalent for entertainment. When Azwighen and Tinzarit issue contradicting forecasts for the same territory, the priests argue in front of the affected villages. Samples are tasted, charts compared, and the farmers who will stake their harvest or their lives on the result sit and choose the more convincing priest. Two seasons ago a village split between the readings. Seven people died on Tinzarit's side. The surviving priests are still arguing methodology, which tells you everything about the priorities of everyone involved.

Rumors:

Little April Shower: A cascade stripped an ancient pylon foundation bare, exposing inscriptions in a script nobody can read. A dwarf mason copied them before the pylon was rebuilt. A Rivhaldean scholar who saw the rubbings claims they're coordinates. To what is anyone's guess.

The Conquest of Bread: A Molakari trade caravan is stuck in Azwighen. The Mazuren have closed the Barktrail's southern stretch for the season. The Molakari insist it's a ploy to extort a bribe. The Mazuren insist it's necessary. Meanwhile the cargo insists that it is spoiling.

The Messenger: An elf village that hasn't contacted Azwighen in decades has sent a runner asking for help. They won't say with what. The Mazuren aren't interested, and the runner was left to wait at the gate.

Voices From The Deep: A farmer's child fell through the canopy and was missing for three days. She came back speaking words nobody recognizes and insisting there are people living beneath the tree line.



Tintbent

Entry 204: The Turncoat Vine (*Vitis Contravius*) *A parasitic creeper characterized by aggressive Contrast. To maximize energy absorption, the vine's pigment shifts instantly to the exact inverse of the ambient light. If the sky burns Red, the vine turns Teal. If the sun shifts Yellow, the vine snaps to Indigo. Makes for fine tea!*

Field Warning: *Do not traverse dense patches during rapid light-storms. The strobing clash between sky and ground destroys depth perception and induces severe vertigo. Harvest only in total magical darkness. Excerpt from *Flora of the Broken Spectrum*, Vol IV.*

A Sight for Sore Eyes

Imagine waking from a summer nap at high noon. Eyes unfocused, drenched in sweat, the world is a bleary haze of drawn-out colors and painfully bright sun. Add a pinch of nausea, and you'd have a rough idea of what it's like stepping into Tintbent for the first time. "Tintbent", such an obtuse name. But what can you expect from a population of farming cave dwellers. The peninsula is riddled with caves. Old, water-carved. Communes have spent centuries refining and connecting them. People who have chosen to live where they're clearly unwanted, all for the sake of either laziness or greed. Only to find out life in Tintbent isn't the rumored "two hours a day" kind of work nor especially profitable. Most leave, others stick with a local crew and learn the hard way. They spend most of their time underground processing food, fishing, cultivating fungi, and sleeping. Not necessarily in that order. Occasionally they surface to work their excuses for a field. I'd call it an uphill battle, but people here have surrendered completely to the ecosystem. They can only farm on its terms, and go for a walk when they're allowed to.

Deeper in, even the notion of a walk becomes optimistic. Light bends around solid objects and puts everything a few meters from where it sits. The surges come harder and more often, and will blister exposed skin in minutes. Despite that, nature is abundant here. But more on that later, as it seems we've run out of page.



Solaris

Imperial archives from the Shining Age describe Shekrat as a perfectionist, which I find hard to believe given what the peninsula looks like now. The records call it a constructed paradise: light painted in shapes for the viewer's pleasure, colors gently arranged in palettes, buildings of pure light that changed with the hour. The usual divine excess. How much of this is empty flattery to what used to be a living god at the time is anyone's guess. What survives in the peninsula today suggests a deranged pixie over a meticulous artist.

One way or another, Shekrat vanished with the rest. The first generation probably only noticed the colors were slightly wrong. Our only surviving document is from the third, and it mentions the buildings of light collapsing violently and blinding everyone around them. It is also, maddeningly, mostly concerned with a property dispute between two minor priesthoods. Anyway, we can assume what followed.

The region was built around Shekrat's infrastructure, and as his systems failed, people fled to soft zones through trial and error in what was probably a fatal learning curve. The few who made it burrowed, or built in beige and grey. Either way, they quickly learned the ropes. Death by error does that to people. These rare communes that survive till this day have been on their own longer than most regions have been independent. A few of them sit on old Shekrat-era infrastructure that still works, at least partly. Camouflages the houses, calms the light, that sort of thing. The ones that have these live a bit easier, and protect them dearly for it.

Science Fair

A traveler stepping into Tintbent walks through moss that shifts from gold to violet over an afternoon. Growth follows spectral surges rather than seasons, and the lingering light feeds the peninsula well past sunset, pumping far more energy than most plants can absorb. Broad-leafed species cover themselves in thick waxy coats and curl inward before a surge hits, often before you know one is coming. The rest push out what they can't use as visible glow, as if to make sure night brings no relief.

On the outer ring, herd animals shimmer in sync, nearly invisible until they scatter. Aggressive territorial males and venomous species are painted grey, flat brown, white. Dull against the shimmer, and learned to avoid quickly. Predators blend into the visual chaos and rely on body heat instead.

Further in is where only real fools are found. Fading pigments. Vestigial eyes. Creatures that don't react when you pass but tense at the sound of your footsteps. By the time the deep zones begin, sight has left the picture entirely. The fauna is pale, often eyeless. Every step announces you to things that hunt by tremor and scent. No more color games, no panache. These are left for the plants alone to play. What greets a traveler in the deep interior is a dense, loud forest, filled with echolocation screeches and bright colors that nothing alive can see. Beautiful, if eerie, or so I'm told.

The Raven Paradox

Describing the communes is a bit like describing good poetry books. They are rare, and each one kind of plays by its own rules. Most upper land settlements go grey: matte walls, no windows, sealed entrances. Children here learn to gather before they learn to read, assuming they learn to read at all. They also put Haldrith to shame when it comes to practical invention, though don't dare try to tell that to a guilds-man. Mithras uses mirrors to angle controlled light into cave mouths, and uses it underground for growing and crafting. The neighboring "settlements" think they're one bad surge from a mass funeral. While the average Mithrasi probably thinks the grey communes are squatting in holes out of cowardice.

As if they don't have enough local trouble to handle, they also have imported one in the form of the Speculars. They arrive on pilgrimage believing the anomaly is sacred, buy anything reflective, carve shrines into rock, and hold rituals during surges that locals consider somewhere between reckless and obscene. Some communes tolerate them for the money but most, understandably, want them gone.

I'd say it's all an impressive proof of mankind's resilience, but sadly, the communes are slowly going extinct. A tunnel collapses, a commune leader dies, or a stabilizer gives out... the reasons are varied. The reasons don't matter, since nobody alive can found new ones. The barrier is too high and the peninsula has never been in the business of welcoming strangers. What survives is old, insular, and stubborn. I'd say it can't last, but they've been outlasting that prediction for longer than I've been alive, so what do I know.

Below

The relief of stepping underground is immediate. The light stops, the headache fades, and the temperature stabilizes. Most communes are small, fewer than a village worth of people sharing a network of carved and natural chambers, occasionally connected by underground rivers. The peninsula only has about three settlements large enough to be called that. The rest are crews of a few dozen, spread across rough living spaces: sleeping alcoves, fungi gardens in the damp sections, fish pools fed by diverted river channels. They usually work by light cantrip or in near darkness. Places like Mithras have their mirrors, or whatever other solution they came up with. Everyone knows everyone. There's no privacy and no strangers. It takes getting used to. Most visitors never do.

Past the inhabited sections the caves continue, unmaintained. Flooded passages, collapsed tunnels, gas pockets in the lower reaches. Occasionally a commune breaks through into spaces that were inhabited before, usually by creatures that don't appreciate visitors. One more entry on the long list of reasons for Tintbent's declining population.

Rumors:

A Light At The End of The Tunnel: A Specular cell has set up near a commune. They bring supplies and pay well for wax and bioluminescent stock. They're also carving mirrors into the bedrock, and the commune's elder wants them out. Some of the commune's traders don't. The Speculars claim they're close to proving the anomaly is an opening, and that closing it would permanently fix the region.

The Blind Man: Livestock is turning up dead in the deep zones between two communes. Then a trader who should have known better. The kills are clean, precise, not animal work. A search party has found someone living out there, blind and half-mad, navigating by sound, and he refuses to leave. Someone has to deal with him.

Exodus: A commune's Shekrat-era stabilizer is failing, and the zone it held calm for centuries is drifting hard. They need help to get to the nearby settlement across sixty kilometers of hard territory with children and livestock. And the neighbors are not, by any account, pleased with the idea.

Unearthed: A major surge strips the soil in the deep zones and exposes Shekrat-era architecture on the surface, partially intact. Three communes, a Specular cell, and a trader caravan are all converging on it for different reasons. A fight seems unavoidable.



Kelarra Peaks

You know, I dropped a wrench yesterday. I watched it fall for a full minute before it disappeared into the clouds below. The air is so thin up here that you have to breathe slowly, deliberately, or you pass out. It forces you to be calm. I think that's what I needed. Please stop sending letters asking when I'm coming down. I'm not. Tell Ma I'm safe.

Letter from Kael, Novice at the Halos temple

The Three Altitudes

Kelarra is a region built in three altitudes. At the bottom is the grounded range. Mountains, valleys, foothills, the hazardous road that runs east toward Ezgarin and Remosa, and the city of Stoneveil at the hinge of it. Most Kelarrans live here and never go higher. To an outsider, this is what Kelarra looks like: a hard, thinly populated mountain country with one proper city and a great many problems.

Above it lie the summits. There are few settlements here, mostly just waystations, Halcyon outposts, and the people who make their living guiding others up. Most who pass through here do so twice and as quickly as possible.

And lastly, above the mountains are the peaks which granted the region its name. The floating archipelago, several hundred islands of stone hanging in the upper air, reached by glider from the launch ledges and connected to one another by a vocabulary of bridges, cable runs, and airways that only the proficient or the ignorant would dare cross. The peaks are what foreigners mean when they say Kelarra. The grounded range is what Kelarrans mean, but nobody asks them anyway.



The Trouble With Gravity

There were probably mountains here before the Witch Wars, though nothing on the present scale. The fragments that survive suggest a modest highland range with goatherds, a few mining villages and not much else. What it was called unfortunately did not survive the passage of time.

We're unsure of the exact events that occurred, but the agreed-upon shape of it, among the few scholars who care, is this: Emari, an imperial mage, cast a spell in an attempt to make the region more fertile. The spell had touched something in the bedrock that should have been left alone, and the bedrock answered by lifting. The man got his farmland. By the end of that year the old range was gone. In its place stood mountains of impossible height, still rising, with the upper portions already separating from the lower as the folds settled into extreme equilibrium. Whatever villages, wildlife and garrisons that were there went up along with the ground.

What kept the rise from continuing forever are the Stillpoints. Without them the peaks would have continued rising into the uninhabitable thin air centuries ago, and the question of Kelarra's absurd civilization would not matter. Dozens of them are scattered across the upper reaches, unmistakably divine-era work, holding each anchor point against the slow upward pull the locals call the Drift. Most islands don't sit on a Stillpoint of their own. They are tethered to one by cable, or by long line and patient labor, or only by the periodic willingness of someone to glide out and haul them back. Nobody built them after the Sundering and nobody alive understands the principle they operate on. They are also, fortunately, not very demanding. The Engineers who maintain them oil the gears, tighten the screws and shoo out the occasional bird. The maintenance work is mostly housekeeping.

The Drift wreaks havoc in the grounded range too. Gravity runs sideways for two miles at the Inverted Pass. A sphere of water hangs above the empty bed of Hollow Lake. At least one idiot breaks a limb every year by falling from the floating water. Smaller anomalies, too many to list, dot the foothills. Places where the lifting did something locally strange. Locals route around them, and outsiders quickly learn to.

A Concept of Proof

Kelarra has been ruled for the last forty-two years by Vulluin, "the Steward," an elven monk, and a cunning bastard. Governing from his court in Stoneveil through his appointed right-hand man Wermund. The Steward is the title of Kelarra's leader, whereby the holder is understood to advance the ideals of his own abbey for the duration of his tenure. Vulluin arrived in the peaks some sixty years ago, joined the temple of White Garden, and managed to garner a following large enough to lead the region's largest abbey, and then Kelarra itself. A bit too quick of a rise if you ask me, but the Kelarrans certainly don't. Within a year of his investiture he declared the Measure: a yearly combat tournament, open only to masters of established abbeys, the winner of which leads Kelarra until he is defeated as well. He has won every Measure since. Most Kelarrans take this as proof of his wisdom rather than as the design of a tournament that has never produced a different result. Stoneveil and the lower peaks live under his rule directly. The upper peaks are governed by the Steward in name and by no one in truth. The Stillpoints are maintained with supplies the Stoneveil provides to the upper peaks to avoid catastrophe, and that is the extent of the relationship either party has any interest in developing. Wermund handles the practical work: disputes, contracts, infrastructure, tax... anything too mundane for Vulluin's wise-monk persona. He is the third governor of Vulluin's tenure and is generally considered competent. He serves at his master's pleasure, after all.

Altitude Sickness

The Drift's effects intensify with altitude. On the ground they are uncommon and localized, exceptions in a landscape that mostly behaves. In the peaks the proportions reverse. Sound occasionally carries too far and arrives slightly out of order, so a conversation on the next peak can be overheard a beat after it ends or, less often, a beat before it begins. Echoes are common at the upper altitudes: visual mirages of people or events that got mixed up in time. The locals have mostly gotten used to it. Occasionally someone gets confused and dies, but it's only one more cause of death out of many others in the frontier.

Castles in the Air

Stoneveil and the grounded villages build in stone with some wooden parts here and there. The peaks build with whatever the climb permits them to bring up, which is mostly timber, canvas, and resin, with metal reserved for foundations and the occasional critical structure. The upper bands strip even further. Buildings are framed minimally and many hang below the rock rather than sitting on it, doing double duty as living space and counter-weight. Almost every upper-peak home has a launch porch, and entering one often means landing on it.

I Chose the Sky

Most people who come to Kelarra expect a spiritual experience. What they get is Stoneveil, a mountain city full of people who have watched a thousand of them arrive with the same expression and are, at this point, mainly interested in how much they're willing to spend. The monks are no better, surprise surprise. A seeker arrives expecting a wise man on a rock and finds three competing monks who want to know if he can cook a meal and hold a staff.

Underneath all of that, the city continues its mundane existence. The born Kelarrans stock the stalls, complain about newcomers peeing in their gardens, and will happily tell you the city was a better place before the abbeys turned it into a staging ground. Not that it stops anyone from coming. As if to demonstrate we all lack direction in equal measure, Stoneveil has drawn people of every race and kind. All looking for a secret ingredient that they've decided is missing from their lives. The Varn I'll give a pass. They say the peaks are quiet, above the ambient arcana that spreads across the surface. Lacking crystals myself, I am compelled to accept their reasoning.

Higher up, the population thins to almost nothing, and what's left isn't interested in explaining itself. The settlements around the Stillpoints house a few dozen people who came for reasons they consider settled. Some wanted out. Some were put out. I don't have much to report on them because they don't have much to say, which, coming from a continent of people who won't shut up about their reasons for being wherever they are, is almost refreshing. When one of them dies the news drifts down eventually, and Stoneveil notes it the way you'd note a change in the weather.

Rumors:

An Easy Fix: During a storm, the secondary cable of Oakhaven Peak snapped. The island is now listing heavily to the side, and the settlement's Stillpoint is overheating. The town needs a team to traverse the underside of the island and manually re-engage the emergency clamps before the whole town flips upside down.

The Drifting Monastery: A remote monastery, known for its extreme discipline, has gone silent. Upon checking, it has risen higher, into the altitude where the air is too thin to breathe. The locals are worried for the monks' lives.

The Salvage Run: The master of a minor lower-peak abbey needs someone to travel to a remote village and retrieve a student who left the abbey a year ago, supposedly the strongest practitioner the abbey has produced in a generation. The master wants him back in time to enter this year's Measure. The student does not want to come back. The master has not said why the student left, and the village he's hiding in has its own reasons for protecting him.

Tavernash

"I have a rock here from Haldrith. Look at it. Jagged. Sharp. Unbalanced. Hold it. Feels good, doesn't it? It's yours for 50 silver. Just don't let your father see you holding that."

Franz Greenhaven, smuggler, talking to an absolved child

Nothing Ever Happens

Most would describe Tavernash as a dull, flat rock on top of the ocean, filled with people who are just as dull and flat. The wind is always soft, the sea barely moves, try laughing too hard and it will be swallowed by the peninsula's overbearing effect. It's their sacred Gyre Stone, of course. A piece of imperial machinery at the peninsula's center, holding the world at an arm's length. Without it, Tavernash would be underwater, to little effect for the rest of the world. Aretzu centers this effect, which tapers off the further you go. The coastal villages get a softer version, just enough to keep the weather quiet. By land, Tavernash connects to the continent only through Knotsreach, which is to say not at all. Most arrivals come by ship through Vranek Bay. The Stone's calm extends a few kilometers out, making the voyage a short, yet exhausting journey filled with rowing. Exports are wine aged in Barkmail casks, kelp from the coast, and the occasional pilgrim back from the Ringwood. Imports are few, and whatever does arrive is taxed and inspected at the docks with a thoroughness that would embarrass the Greywater Compact. They don't want to sully their precious land with the ugliness outside, after all.



The Doll's House

There are conflicting records regarding pre-Sundering Tavernash. Some claim Nareth, the god who ruled it, was a god of calm. He's described as shy, curious and introspective. One especially disturbing piece claims he was actually no more than a child, whose monarchic kingdom served merely as theatrical entertainment. He enjoyed watching the mortals celebrate their ceremonies and scheme their way up and down the ladder of nobility. Either way, the Gyre-Stone was built to keep the wider world from interrupting his kingdom. After Nareth vanished, the priests who maintained it put it to the court plainly: hand over the throne, or the peninsula drowns. The Tavren have been in power since, powerful and exceptionally long lived. The records of how they got there have vanished from every Tavernashi archive. Imperial ones, unfortunately for them, have not. Sacred continuity, the locals call it, and best not to try to tell them otherwise.

The Varieties of Religious Experience

The Kenosis, "The Great Emptying", teaches that emotion is a vice that binds the soul to the suffering of the material world. To be holy is to let the world pass through you, to exist beyond it. In order to achieve this state, the nobility drinks "The Sacrament of Nareth", ceremonial tea brewed from Ringwood sap which dissolves anxiety, ambition, and rage. It's also quite vile. They call themselves the "Absolved". They're calculated, slow to speak and move with the type of grace only one with no weight on his shoulders could carry.

Then of course, there are the commoners. The "Laden". Too busy for enlightenment and too necessary to be offered any. Fishermen, Kelp farmers, winemakers and any other profession that brings use to society. They bear their role with pride, convinced their rulers sacrifice their humanity for a sacred spiritual duty. Whether the Absolved experience this as sacrifice is a question the Laden have learned not to ask.

Hallowed Be Thy Name

Valerian VI governs from Aretzu, if governing is the word for it. He takes his Sacrament, maintains the Stone, and signs what his advisors put in front of him, in roughly that order of importance. The kingdom runs the way it ran the last three centuries, and will probably continue to until the day when it's Valerian VII's turn to walk the lakes in sequence, each with its own ceremony. Dawn, Vigil, Signet, Oath, Ascension, Feast, Crown, and lastly, Sword. Unfortunate that spine isn't one.

Order is kept by the Tranquils, monks armed with tuning-fork staves who police discord. A brawl, a breakdown, a bad reaction to the Sacrament, all met with swift sedation and isolation. The fishing villages handle their own disputes. If it doesn't reach Aretzu, it isn't anyone's problem.

Sorites Paradox

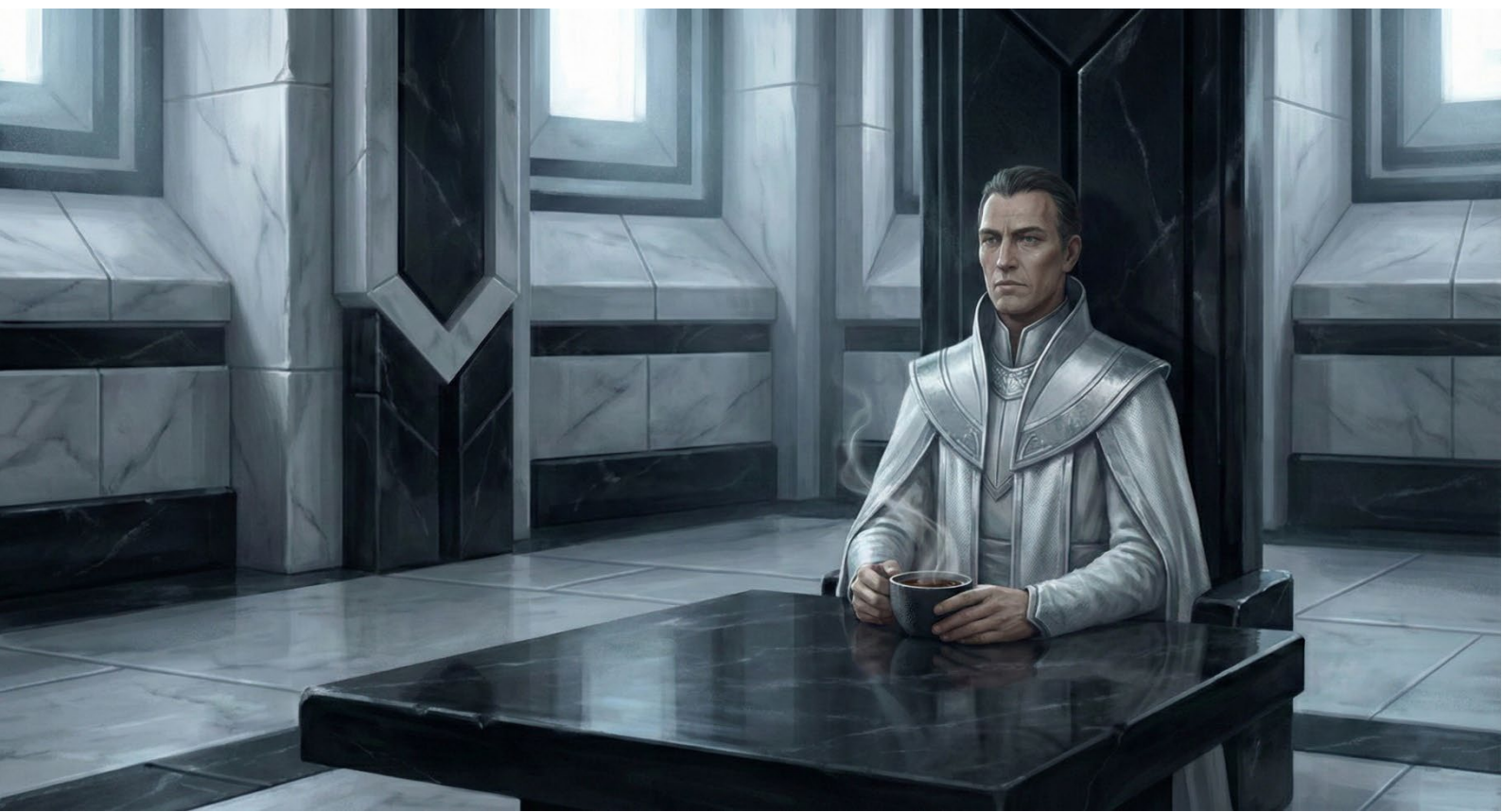
The Nareth Ringwood sits at the peninsula's southern tip, past the Stone's reach. The trees absorb sound, and the deeper you walk, the more you leave behind. The sap the Absolved drink comes from here, and the trees are far more effective in their raw form. At the center of the perfectly round forest sits Silence, a stable Rift. Pilgrims come from across the continent to whisper their worst memories into the woods. Silence takes what's offered, and returns sweet nothingness. They exit leaving a piece of themselves behind. Fragmentists, as they are, flock to the place. The crown considers them heretics, and the Tranquils handle the matter with the most enthusiasm the kingdom has ever shown for anything.

Rumors:

The Defect: An Absolved noblewoman is looking for someone who can get her off the peninsula. She's been tapering off the Sacrament in secret and the feelings are coming back.

The Sap of life: A smuggler in the fishing villages is exporting a concentrated, black version of the Nareth Sacrament. It causes total memory erasure, and leaves a trail of empty people behind.

The Southern Coast: Laden fishermen are going missing near the Ringwood. The villages pooled what they could afford to hire outsiders. The missing fishermen are alive, sitting in the wood, unable to remember why they walked in.



Haldrith

I have reviewed your report regarding the bedrock density in Sector 4. You claim the stone is too hard to drill on schedule. Let me remind you where you stand, and what your contractual obligation is. I do not care if you have to melt the granite or break every drill-bit in your inventory. We have a contract with the Karagrunds to open that tunnel by the solstice. Fix the gradient, Brotmoc, your excuses and geological conditions are of no interest to me.

Memorandum: Site 4 Delay, Mokash Hammerhand, Foreman of the Iron Guild

The Industrial Grind

I hate Haldrith, I admit. Considered leaving these pages blank, but the gap in the table of contents would bother me more than the writing. And so here I am, writing about a bunch of bigoted dwarves, all numbed by a millennium of alternating between the land's chilly evening fog and the heat of their metalworks. I'm sure they wouldn't even appreciate it. A tall person, daring to describe their ill-mannered crime-ridden crumbling excuse of a society.

They are capable of beauty, mind you. I have seen it. The ancient dwarven monuments of the Age of Silence, still standing in Remosa, waiting for a sculptor who will never come. Fallmere, fine polished rock, salted to gleam against Lake Remathis. All of it, slowly replaced by short-sighted greed one only expects to meet in legends. They scrapped the old Quartz townhall to rebuild it in metal and stone. They're on the seventh version now. The 6th's windows had a 0.6cm angle, you see. It's all run like a dick-swinging competition between guilds with more power than wisdom, and more aspirations than caution. A group of criminals, politicians and criminal politicians. And, as per usual, the people underneath get to answer to all of them in equal measure.

These days they mine, they forge, they file, they drink, they fuck, they sleep, and then they do it all again for the sake of it. I'm convinced none of them could tell you what they work towards, unless you count the end of their shift or a contract's expiration date. Craftsmen demoted to statesmen. What a sad sight.



The Iron Stairs

Pre-Sundering Haldrith was the domain of Vrothnak, who was the creator of many of Remosa's built wonders: the Imperial Path, Tharlin's Crossing, Brenmath, the fountain of leaves... Quite the portfolio. He was rather modest when it comes to his own lodgings, though, judging by the few ancient Remosan remnants that can still be found around Haldrith. Scattered, half-buried ruins. That's about it. There is no written evidence for this, but my own intuition is that Vrothnak was a creator first and foremost. He liked building things and hated maintaining them. That would explain why so many of Remosa's wonders were self-repairing. I think he was the type to go to his workshop, create art that goes beyond the abilities of men, only to go back home to a house that is essentially four walls and a bed. You know the type: bad temper, no social skills. This would explain why all his marvels remain outside Haldrith's borders, the loose dwarven monarchic system that he apparently cared nothing for, and why everything worthwhile in Haldrith was either built after his time, or clearly not by him. A tad too convenient an explanation, but I'll take it. Anyway, away he goes, and the dwarven duchies were left to their own devices.

So there they were, a collection of duchies loyal to the Remosan Empire. No leadership, no legitimacy. It's a wonder they survived for so long, but I'm getting ahead of myself. The dukes had soldiers and titles, but had slowly grown weaker and more despised while the empire bled itself dry in Trefgann. The taxes kept arriving for a public that spent most of its time caring for somebody else's interests, all while the guilds had the mines, the forges, the working force, and a bubbling hatred of the nobility, with their empty ceremonies and pathetic idleness.

What followed, naturally, was a long, decentralized war of strikes, sabotage, backstabbing and valley-by-valley fighting that went on for the better part of a century. Different guilds backed different factions. Some dukes held on for decades. Others folded within a season. You'd have to ask an expert on the matter for a clearer picture, as this mess of a historical period is quite honestly too much for me to make sense of.

The turning point, to my understanding, was House Brawneye. A major duchy that sided with the guilds early, armed their workers, and tipped the balance. They gave legitimacy to the rebellion, and shifted public opinion to the guilds' favor. The official account holds that after power switched hands to the guilds, House Brawneye voluntarily dismantled its title to allow the new system to take root. Some historical records suggest "voluntarily" is doing a great deal of work in that sentence. The Brawneyes were stripped, scattered, and a decent portion of the family were assassinated. Voluntarily, I'm sure.

The guilds had won, and celebrated by spending the next few decades infighting. Then, at long last, they realized fighting passive-aggressively is cheaper, and the Nonagon was established. A dignified climb from subjugation to self-rule, they'll tell you. Over a great pile of corpses, I'll add.

A Balanced Diet

Only a Haldrithian would look at a fresh, perfect cod and say "I should grind that into mush and serve it alongside oatmeal and some diced veal." At least they named the dish "Foggy Sunset" so you know you're in for an experience. And unless the owner has something to prove, then it's probably also served with diluted beer, if you're a tall person, that is. You then get to bump your head against the ceiling on your way to the toilet which will not have a light since nobody ever considered the idea of a person with no darkvision. Truly, a tourist experience for the ages. And all of it is built in metal and stone, chilled against the fog and the harsh winds that roam between the hills. Luckily, the scorn for pleasantries doesn't go as far as hearths.

If you plan on visiting despite all this, let me tell you about contracts. They talk about them constantly. Who lost one, whose guild underbid whose, whose got renewed at worse terms. Over drinks, over work, over a fistfight, which, I should mention, tend to go harder than anywhere else on the continent. The guilds are to blame for most of it, and I'll get to them later. But my point is that Haldrithian guilds, and by extension, their people, are a bit like that annoying teenager who's determined to paint a penis over every wall in town. Or in this case, their guild sigils. Whoever paints the most sigils, fights the most rivals, produces the most horseshoes... For them the honor. And so it goes. Shift ends, tavern opens, shift begins.

Building To Break Apart

It started with the Hoof-Hatter. A gnomish invention that produces a horseshoe in under ten minutes. The Black Hands protested at first, but it would seem Hjorn was quickly convinced by the trend in numbers. Pride is the armor of the penniless, as they say. The other guilds quickly followed, and after them a myriad of other devices. That was 38 years ago, and at the time the thing was treated as a clever curiosity to show off at council meetings. Now most simple stuff that comes out of Haldrithian forges has never been hammered by hand. The whole arrangement was always going to land somewhere like this. The Nonagon system runs on production numbers, not the quality of craft, and certainly not artistic merit. Whoever produces the most at the cheapest price wins the contract, and contracts are Haldrith's official coin.

It's almost poetic, even more so for how futile the whole thing is. The craftsmen, proud, skillful. Traditionalists looking to honor a practice that predates speech. Standing against their own creations, which some gnomish ingenuity has grown beyond their creators. The whole thing sent the region into a spiral in recent decades. At first it was the Karagrunds who pushed against it, with eruptions of violence unusual even by Haldrith's standards. Then Yrnar stepped away from the fight, to much dismay from his fellow guildsmen. Now there are no clear sides to it all. All I can say for sure is that something is going to give. And here I thought that the dwarves and rock gnomes played together so well. Shame.

The Nonagon

Governance in Haldrith is handled by the Nonagon, a council of nine guilds that have clawed their way to the top. Or so the story goes, anyway. Their authority is the only law in the region, and while supposedly they can be replaced, five of the founding nine haven't changed hands once in that time.

Interesting characters, the lot. Take Pebbleclink, for example. He took a developing field, enchantments, and spent a decade and a half building a system around it from scratch. He then proceeded to navigate himself into a council seat against every prejudice the dwarves could throw at him. The Myrrkin finally got his acknowledgment when the leadership of his preceding guild vanished one day. The Nonagon nodded, documents were signed, and there you have it. Haldrith in a nutshell. Thelinde is another one. An elf, no less. Used to run a brothel, and turned it into an empire. She's outlived every chair who's tried to remove her, which at this point has amounted to quite the body count. A cunning vixen, built herself from scratch only to sit next to "Bregast the Younger." Fourth of his line. Each one drinks more and is more unhinged than the last. I guess sovereignty comes in many forms.

Anyway, three of the seats have changed several times since the Nonagon was founded 190 years ago. The rest hold on by doing what the system rewards, which is making yourself both too dangerous and too useful to remove. Chairs die in their sleep with some regularity. Rising guilds get gutted overnight, and as long as nobody is caught, nobody bats an eye. Poison is common enough that any chair worth the title won't eat something that hasn't been prepared under watch. There's a whole culture of duels and public contests where craftsmen pit their work against each other for standing. The thinking, if you can call it that, is that if you survived all of this, you probably deserve the seat. Guild chairs are respected, extremely so. And should one forget that, they'll be quick to remind him why.

I'll try to explain how the domains work, since the system is unique to Haldrith alone as far as I'm aware. Each guild serves a function. Tunhall runs your drink. Hjornast delivers your grain. The Black Hands forged the lock on your door. Hammerheads maintain the street outside it. In any given building, three or four guilds have a claim to a part of the owner's pocket, and the place only works because all of them provide for it. The theory is mutual dependency. The practice is that if Hjornast has a problem with you, your supply cart arrives late, or not at all. Nothing in Haldrith happens without passing through someone else's domain, and they all keep count. Meticulously so.

The Haldrithians will tell you this ensures that power is earned rather than given. Most would describe it as foolish and ineffective, but the Haldrithians take deep pride in their flawed system, which "keeps the gears running while the machine is being tuned." I'd argue the machine has been "tuned" for 190 years and counting, but what do I know. I'm tall.

<u>Guild</u>	<u>Seated</u>	<u>Domain</u>	<u>Current Chair</u>
Karagrund Guild	At founding	Mining, sculpture	Yrnar Karagrund
Tunhall Guild	At founding	Brewing, alchemy, inns	Bregast the Younger the Fourth
The Black Hands	At founding	Metalwork, heavy industry, enchantment	Hjorn Stennar
Hjornast Wagons	At founding	Warehouses, supply chains, conveyance, food	Tella Hjornast
Hammerheads	At founding	Roads, sewers, civil maintenance	Tobrik Vennik
Mokval's Legion	140 years ago	City watch, road wardens	Vrennar Halsmark
Thelinde's Hearth	140 years ago	Mediation, recruitment, child-care, sex work	Thelinde
The Open Eye	70 years ago	Espionage, Intelligence Law, archives	Master Vennister
The Index	5 years ago	Arcane regulation, enchantment licensing	Pebbleclink Warbler Candlewax Dust Rice



What Falls Through

Haldrith has this bizarre unofficial system where a craftsman who wrecks a competitor's workshop is a criminal if he's caught and an entrepreneur if he isn't. A mining guild that bullies a smaller outfit off a claim is breaking the rules right up until nobody files a complaint. You get the gist. Say you run an inn. You answer to Tunhall for the drink and the permits, Hjornast Wagons for the food (and some more permits), and the Hammerheads when the roof leaks (and some more permits). Each of them will lean on you to edge out the others. Favor Tunhall's supplier over Hjornast's preferred vendor and your next delivery is short. Fix your own door instead of calling the Hammerheads and see how long it takes for an inspector to find a code violation. And this is all within the Nonagon. Below them sits a whole ecosystem of smaller guilds fighting for scraps, and they play dirtier because they have less to lose. Not to mention, should you choose a cheaper, smaller guild for one of these services, you'd have to spend the rest of your life avoiding their competitors.

Then there's Pulp. "The Sacrament of Nareth", or what's left of it after it's been mixed with some crap, shipped through Stenvik's bay, and sold out of the back of whatever establishment Mokval's Legion isn't watching closely enough. In Tavernash, the Sacrament is ceremony. Here it's merchandise, and an expensive one. The regular stuff takes the edge off. Dissolves the anger, the ambition, the parts of you that care about the contract you lost or the guild breathing down your neck. You can see why it sells. The black version is something else entirely. Total erasure. Though temporary, the effect accumulates. Not a pretty picture. And if after all of this, you're still keen on visiting... Well, at least make sure you get proper ale from the same cask as the locals.

Rumors:

Stamp of Approval: Counterfeit enchantment licenses have been circulating in Fallmere's lower districts. The work is good enough that most merchants can't tell the difference, which means enchanted goods are hitting the market without Index oversight or expiration dates. Pebbleclink has been unusually quiet about it. Either he hasn't found the source, or he has, and the answer is inconvenient.

Fourteen: The Brassmen guild was dissolved overnight. The fourteen newly orphaned children are now Thelinde's Hearth's responsibility, funded under an old agreement that requires all nine seats to contribute. The Hammerheads, who had a long-standing dispute with the Brassmen, refuse to pay their share. This can turn bloody quickly.

Holt Elderbark: Illegal elderbark lumber has started appearing in Stenvik's markets. The supply chain runs through enough subcontractors across enough domains that no single guild has jurisdiction to investigate. The forest is considered to be neutral ground under Nonagon's agreement, and they want this dealt with.

Rivhalde

"I've run the numbers on Rowanholt. Their buckwheat output is down 12% this quarter. If we deploy a Lienhunter squad to clear out the goblins, the cost of the operation exceeds the village's projected tax revenue for the next five years. Let it burn. We can repossess the land once the goblins move on."

Senior Auditor Richard, denying a request for aid

A Land of Milk And Honey

Wide plains run to the horizon, cut by slow rivers and rich with crops. The roads are well-maintained cobblestone lined with tollbooths at every crossroads. Gorgeous, really. The Greywater Compact pays the Weave to keep Rifts shut and funds enough patrols to keep the roads clear, which makes Rivhalde the safest region on the continent by most measures and the most expensive by all of them. The Compact runs the region the way a landlord runs a tenement: it is surveyed, weighed, and should it overstep, disciplined.

Half the continent eats Rivhaldean grain, and the Compact has had generations to leverage that advantage into brutal, efficient strength. They are the wealthiest, most organized power on the continent, and no current rival has the means to challenge them directly. Luckily, they're so focused on making enemies of their own people that neighboring regions need not worry.

The locals keep enough of what they grow to get by. The rest goes to the Compact's ledger. A village that falls behind on its assessments will quickly meet a Lienhunter crew. One is allowed to rid himself of his assets should he choose to, after all.



What the Harvest Bought

Rivhalde fed the empire for centuries, until Remosa threw everything it had at retaking Trefgann, and left the region to fend for itself. What followed was ugly. Bandits raided the granaries. Deserters from three different armies settled in and took what they wanted.

The Rivhaldean administrators sent emissaries with plea after plea, and got nothing in return. Bitter and abandoned, the merchant families who ran the river-ports and the grain stores pooled their coin, hired sellswords, and spent the better part of a decade clearing the roads and securing the harvests by force. By the time it was done, the administrators were answering to them, not the other way around. At that point the empire had stopped being useful, and Rivhalde's merchants are not sentimental people. And so there was "freedom".

It's Strictly Business

The Board of Signatories governs from Krumfeld. Its members are the heads of the Compact's founding merchant families, and they divide the region's revenue streams between them. Each family controls a suite of settlements, trade routes, or industries, and collects the tariffs accordingly. The Board meets to set policy, coordinate prices, settle territorial disputes, and decide on the spending that goes toward keeping the roads patrolled and paying for The Weave's services.

In Rivhalde, anything that generates revenue and doesn't threaten the Compact's hold is permitted and taxed. Necromancy, experimental research, slavery, sex work... every vice is just a licensing fee away from being legal. The only things the Compact prosecutes with any real enthusiasm are unpaid tariffs and civil resistance.

Whatever does get enforced is done by publishing a contract for the scum of the earth to collect on. A Lienhunter crew rides out and handles it by whatever means necessary. They are well-paid bandits and opportunists. Good at their job, too. The Compact has never maintained a standing army. It has never needed to.

Sabotage And Other Civic Duties

Despite some evidence to the contrary, it would seem that most people wish to be led by something more than a debt collector. And indeed, change is brewing underneath Rivhalde's semblance of calmness. The crime-lord-led black market grows ever larger, and resistance cells who came to call themselves "Sabots" commit rare, yet effective, attacks.

The black market runs on Ghost Roads: smuggling routes through the Feskir Woodland and the coast that the Compact hasn't been able to shut down. Unlicensed goods, and people who have reasons to avoid the Compact's eye go through them. The operation has grown sophisticated enough to offer its own coinage and protection, effectively, a second Compact with lower rates and fewer Lienhunters. The Board finds this less amusing than everyone else does.

The Sabots are driven by stronger stuff than coin: resentment and ideology. And what a pairing it is. They are dangerous, and no less cruel than the Lienhunters. Debt archives have burned in three cities in the last decade, along with every worker in them. Lienhunter crews regularly get ambushed on rural roads, and their bodies are consistently brutalized after the fact. Two Compact auditors were killed at their desks in Krumfeld just in the last year. The Board's response is violent and extreme. An active Sabot in the Compact's hands is probably the worst thing one can become. Both sides of this coin deserve each other, if you ask me.

Rumors:

A Well-Thought Harvest: A licensed necromancer farmer outside Elmstead has been working for three seasons with no problem. Everything is legal, every tariff paid. However, last season the neighboring farms started failing for different reasons. The Compact won't directly touch a licensed operation, but they're worried something fishy is afoot.

Ghosts, Ghosts Everywhere: Smugglers on a Ghost Road through the Feskir Woodland have found something in the trees that shouldn't be there. They can't report it without revealing their route, and they can't ignore it because it killed two of their people last week. They need outside help from someone who won't ask how they came across it.

God on Trial: A town near the border has filed a contract dispute against the Board itself, claiming the Compact has failed to deliver on its obligations under the original protection agreement. The legal argument is surprisingly solid. The Board seeks to hire outside help to make the problem disappear discreetly before anyone else gets the same idea.



Remosa

To: Citizen Marl, District 4

Re: Collapse of Outer Wall Section C-9 onto Residential Property

Regarding your complaint that a strategic masonry unit dislodged from the defensive perimeter and crushed your kitchen: Claim Denied. Under the Imperial Preservation Act, all defensive structures are classified as "Active Military Assets" regardless of their current structural integrity. Gravity is considered an act of nature, not state negligence. Furthermore, be advised that filing a second complaint will result in an audit of your household's conscription eligibility. We suggest you grind the brick into mortar and repair your roof yourself.

Stamped by Junior Adjudicator Sloan

The Rusting Shield

The Remosan Empire, much reduced. The nation that once ruled most of the continent now barely governs the region around the Mire, a roughly oval hole in reality at its center. Even its original capital, Brenmath, was lost in the Synod of Secession two centuries ago and has been in Trefgann hands since. Three subsequent invasions, the most recent fifty years ago, failed to take it back. The Council in Ezgarin still issues maps that include Brenmath, in an attempt to convince children that it's theirs.

The region is in a long decline, but yes, it is also magnificent. The locals will tell you both at length if you aren't quick enough to stop them. The avenues of Ezgarin are paved in white stone that hummed once with self-repair enchantments and today mostly just hum for the sake of it. The arches and statues are larger than anything else on the continent. The streetlights work in a third of the districts. The harvest tax was paid in spring and a Mire Commander's outrider may yet come back in autumn for another. People take real pride in living somewhere that was once the seat of mortal civilization, and curse it constantly for not being that anymore.

The current empire's energy is spent on three things: maintaining what magic still functions, holding the Iron Perimeter against the Mire, and asserting through paperwork what it can no longer assert by force.

The Mire is the one that matters. If the Green Wall stopped drinking or the Iron Perimeter stopped watching, the hole would widen into Haldrith, Kelarra, and Rivhalde within a generation. The wall and the perimeter are funded entirely out of Remosan taxes. No other region has ever contributed. The Remosans keep count.

The End

The Mire is an oval shaped crater where reality collapsed into itself during the Sundering. The empire at the time still had the means to construct the Green Wall around it. A dense forest of bio-engineered trees planted in the Sundering's immediate aftermath. Grown specifically to stabilize and absorb whatever comes out of the Mire: gasses, monstrosities, ambient magic, damaged physics. If it kills, it's probably there. From the Wall, the interior is visible. Shapes, colors, and matter fold and reform faster than the eye can register. Ground becomes sky, solidifies, collapses into something liquid, and then into something that has no word. Light behaves without pattern. Gasses that don't exist outside the crater pour upward and fill the air above it in colors that shouldn't work together and don't stay long enough to name. There is no agreed description of it in any Remosan record I've come across.

Outside the forest's outer ring stands the Iron Perimeter, a military infrastructure of ancient machinery and soldiers whose only job is to make sure the end of the world stays contained within the trees. And also, of course, to deal with the occasional slip with whatever ancient machinery they have. Perimeter soldiers rotate off the Wall every eight weeks. Ones who argue they can stay longer are the ones who need to leave most. As they say, stare long enough into the abyss and the abyss stares back. There are also patrols that work the inner edge of the Green Wall, ostensibly to establish a buffer zone, and in practice to collect volatile ingredients that can't be found anywhere else. All at the cost of Remosan lives, of course.

Hubris

The empire was rich and well established when the Sundering occurred. The Green Wall was planted within a generation. The Iron Perimeter quickly followed. Despite everything, some competence was still there to be found. When human soldiers proved too fragile for terrain that no longer behaved, the Bio-Forges began producing the Orrak. When famine and radiation hollowed out the labor base, the Graith were activated to maintain the infrastructure no living workforce could. Whatever goodwill this earned the empire, the Witch Wars erased. Their damages were a product Remosa exported to the entire continent.

By the time the provinces started rebelling, the empire had spent everything it had on holding the world together and further breaking it in equal measure. Trefgann's Synod of Secession, two centuries ago, took a third of the empire along with Brenmath, the empire's original capital. Haldrith, Rivhalde, and Southfield followed within a generation. The empire gathered whatever bits and pieces it had left and marched east to take Brenmath back. And then again, and again fifty years ago. A shameful defeat, every single time. The empire still hasn't acknowledged the loss.

No One Writes to the Colonel

A new statue of General Aldren was unveiled in the Ezgarin Forum last year. The sewer pipe under the Forum has been awaiting repair for six. Meanwhile the Continuity Council governs from Ezgarin. It is composed of old noble families and senior administrators who have inherited the empire's titles if not its territory. They commission monuments, organize military parades, fund public speeches about Remosan heritage, and run a civic education program that teaches children the empire's borders as they were drawn two centuries ago.

The Mire Commanders manage the Iron Perimeter. They conscript citizens, seize supplies, and requisition whatever they need under standing emergency powers that were granted temporarily three centuries ago and never revoked. The Council sends formal requests for budget reports. The Commanders send back requests for boots and lumber. Neither side bothers reading what the other sends.

Of Graith And Men

A third of Remosa is Orrak. The Bio-Forges made the first generation. The rest were then born here, devoid of choice in the matter like all the rest of us. The Iron Perimeter garrison consists mostly of Orrak to this day. They're also common in construction, crafts, trade. The higher-salaried administrative and engineering posts go to humans. Nobody passed a law about this. Nobody needed to. In short, Orraks in Remosa are Remosan. Their complaints about the taxes and the state of the roads are the same as anyone else's. It's worth noting that their control of Iron Perimeter's garrison means the empire's most critical military asset is largely in Orrak hands. The Council has never formally acknowledged this as a concern. The Council also does not appoint Orraks to administrative posts.

The Graith are fewer and harder to count. They maintain the infrastructure: aqueducts, ward-stones, road enchantments, the machinery that the empire built when it still could. The most valued profession in Remosa is the Siege-Engineer, and a Siege-Engineer's job is, in practice, keeping a Graith operational long enough to keep a wall operational long enough to keep a district habitable. The chain of dependency is not lost on anyone.

Per the Graith's own testimony, while they are mantra-bound, they are also conscious and possess personality. The council's position is that this remains under review. A formal study is commissioned roughly once a decade and then shelved. Recognizing Graith as persons would mean wages, contracts, property rights, and a cascade of legal obligations the Remosan treasury cannot absorb. Most Graith do not press on the matter, because their mantras do not include instructions on the matter. The ones who do tend to be loud about it, and then tend to be reassigned to less visible posts.

Rumors:

The Conscription: A Remosan town is declared under martial law by a commander, who demands a hundred recruits to handle a breach in the Green Wall. The local Mayor, a Council loyalist, blocks the order on the grounds that it violates a tax statute. Both sides have armed men. The town is in the middle.

The Dying Wall: A stretch of the Green Wall near Southgate has gone quiet. The trees are pale and brittle, and a thin iridescent fog has started drifting into the surrounding farmland. The local garrison doesn't have the people to send into the forest to find out what's killing the trees.

The Fire Sale: A Mire Commander is selling captured magical artillery to a Haldrith crime syndicate. The council wants this to be dealt with, but he needs the coin for winter cloaks, and is, by every account, a decent man.

The Rebel: A Graith maintaining the ward-stones under Ezgarin's eastern district has stopped working. It has renegotiated its mantras and is now requesting a formal status review before it resumes. The district's water pressure is dropping by the day. The Council wants the problem solved quietly. What "solved" means the council prefers not to put in writing.



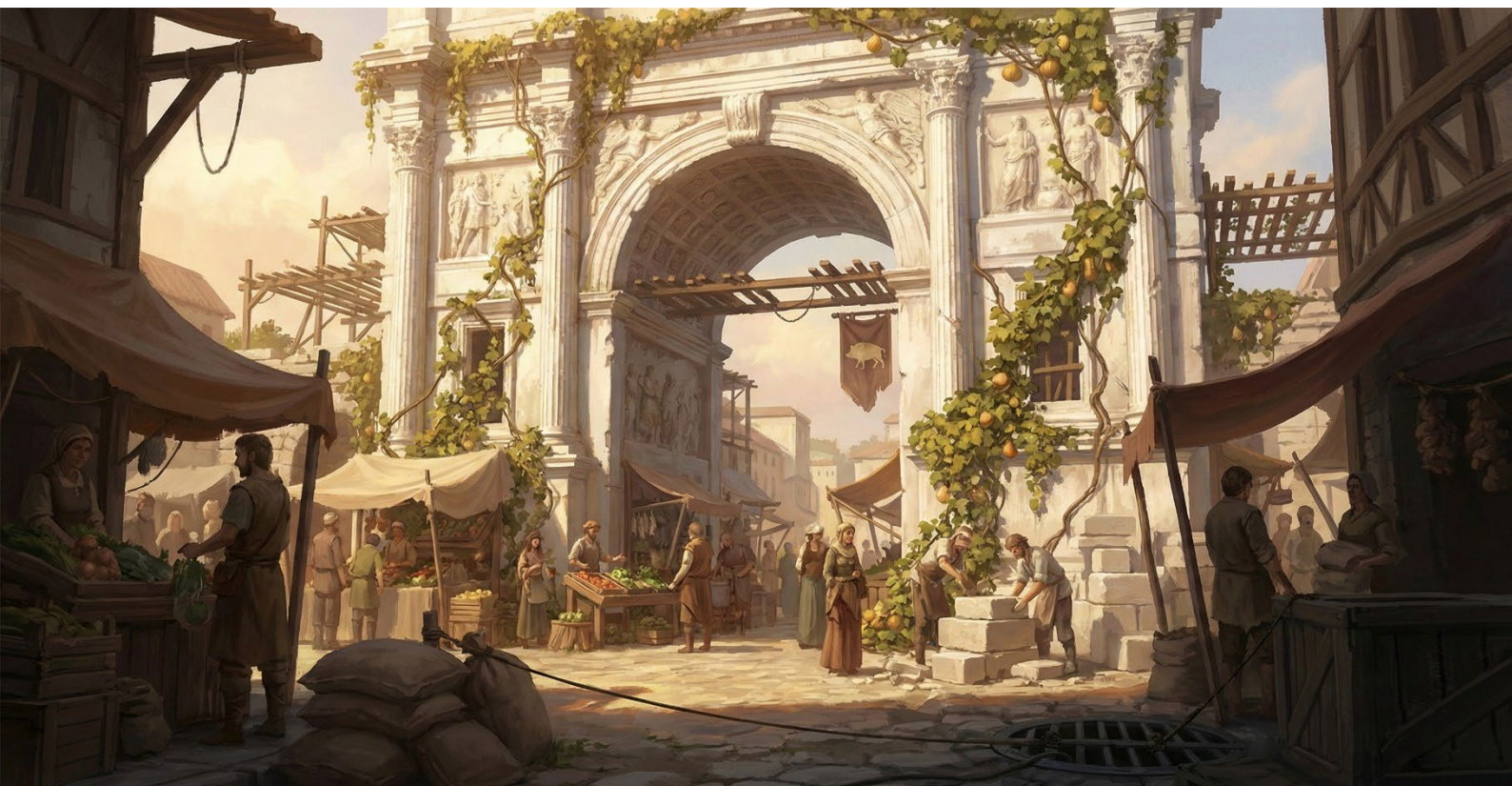
Trefgann

"The armored man came down the hill, He came to take, he came to kill. He knocked upon the Iron Gate, We told him he would have to wait. He huffed and puffed and broke his bone, and now we use his head for stone! One step! Two step! Three steps! Four! Don't come knocking at our door!"

Playground skipping-song heard in Llyra

Concord of War

Remosa's open wound. They can't stop scratching it, and Trefgann has been opened and bled again and again and again. No wonder they can't think of themselves as anything but "not Remosa". Hillside forests the color of green rust, lakes rippling in the spring breeze, soil which smells of musty thyme, laced with an ancient road paved in marble. The Trefganners cling to a sense of simplicity, directness, freedom, maybe? Hardy people, weaponized working folk, sitting inside one of Virelia's greatest regions and too busy surveying Remosa to realize it. Too busy taking apart and mocking the ancient statues to marvel at their beauty. Maybe fittingly, the opposite of Remosa's hubris has taken the form of paranoia. I realize I'm painting a bleak picture here. And perhaps, an unfair one. The Trefganners are decent folk. Tight communities, strong agricultural identity, great tobacco. There's just something to be said about people who'd scorn anything and everything as long as it has a Remosan accent.



Tobacco and Stew

Since it seems everyone in Trefgann agrees on politics, what's left to argue about is mostly food, followed by tobacco. Strangers, lucky for them, are unburdened with this until it is proven they have nothing to do with Remosa. You'll get stared at for three days, and if you pass they'll give you the nods, then the endless inescapable war stories. If you don't, the staring never stops. As a side note, the food is surprisingly pretty good. A typical Trefganni meal consists of steamed root vegetables and lake fish, hard bread on the side, swallowed with the help of cool buckwheat beer. Lovely, if you can ignore the stares.

Trefganners are the only nation I've seen where people are so damn proud of their land. They learn it by heart, each tree and every abandoned piece of infrastructure. A habit born of farming and foraging, which ended up winning the war for them. Despite that, the Trefganners show an utter lack of care for what the empire left behind and three wars then added to the pile. It's all still out there, unstable, deteriorating, and when used correctly, hazardous to the uninitiated. More Remosan soldiers have died in the sewers beneath Brenmath than in its fields.

A Crown of Mud

Brenmath was the seat of the empire for most of recorded history. The court governed from there, and the wealth of half a continent flowed through the gates the Trefganners would eventually shut.

Then came the Witch-Wars, and the boneheaded, bizarre edict to expand the empire onto Myrskov. The records of that particular council meeting make one wonder if there is still hope for our species. Fucking morons. Trefganner conscripts died in those forests for a campaign the empire had no chance of winning, fed by crops their families needed at home. The Witch Wars had already been draining the province for generations before that. The costs always fell downward, while the taxes, as always, trickled up. Yet the guild-masters and mayors still somehow persevered, and kept things below boiling point. Until Remosa finally admitted it really had no business in Myrskov, and the outrage struck.

Imperial administrators were dragged from their offices. Noble families who had governed from Brenmath for generations were slaughtered in the streets. Property was seized, estates burned, and anyone with the wrong name or the wrong accent learned quickly which way the path to Tharlin's Crossing ran. Guild-masters, mayors, trade leaders, all met in "purified" Brenmath and formally declared the empire to be no more. Varenhal, the empire's own civic Graith, read his mantras and concluded the empire had made itself incompatible with them. The gates closed shut. That is one door that will never open again.

Three times since, the empire has marched east to take the capital back. Each time smaller, more desperate. Each time eating mud from the soil the Trefganners knew

better than the people who ruled it. The third was fifty years ago. The fourth is expected within the lifetime of the current generation. Whether it will come is a question for Ezgarin. Whether Trefgann will be ready is not a question at all.

Pecking Order

Much like the farmers market that is Southfield's ruling council, the Synod of Secession is comprised mostly of people who have no business holding a pen. They convene when the situation demands and are otherwise content to let things sort themselves out. Four cities, four delegates each, comfortably, or perhaps better described, uncomfortably, sit in a senate hall built for three hundred imperial administrators. They settle trade disputes, and occasionally make a failed attempt at something that requires coordination across city lines. In brief, the Blackhens handle executive defense. Everything else is either local, mismanaged, or both.

Past the cities, governance thins out fast. Towns and villages answer to whichever city claims them, or to no-one if the claim was never pressed. The militia is the one thing that reaches everywhere: everyone can wield a weapon, and are quick to draw it. And when the call goes out, the region can pull itself together in days.

One point that I unfortunately can't skim over is Blank. A stable rift that strips identity. Cross its boundary and you are still a person, in some sense of the word. You simply have no idea which one. The Trefganni cities use it to dispose of criminals they deem unsalvageable. Critics often say it's no different than execution. Less filth, but no less vulgar. I, for one, think they can at least be commended for their creativity.

Think of The Children

The Third March was fifty years ago, long enough for the current crop of Trefganni youth to have fathers who mostly remember having spears shoved into their arms whenever it rained too hard. Habits hold better than memories, and Trefgann is a land of habit, after all. Offensive spells are still considered inappropriate while few remember the trauma that fueled the taboo. Children learn the Marches before they understand them, and are constantly warned of what's to come.

The result is not obedience, to no one's surprise but the Trefganni. Young ones rebel, old ones complain, as is the natural order of things. The rebellion takes many forms: eye-rolls during drills, Remosan literature, the quiet departure of young spellcasters who wish to learn "real" magic, and also the occasional argument that the gate should, in fact, open both ways. You know how it is. This is not policy, thank fuck. It is mostly tavern courage, fueled by ale, boredom and youth. The elders call them westward fools. Some have started using the name proudly, proving that Trefgann has preserved its children from Remosa but not from stupidity. In summary, peace had raised a generation that knows war through stories only, which is to say they know it very well and not at all.

Rumors:

The Iron Giant: A war-construct from the First March has turned up in old Fionn's field outside Elidyr. Dormant, but the core is still hot. He wants to strip it for parts, But Oifara, the local village head, fears it might trigger something that levels the town.

The Peddler's Tin: A Haldrithian peddler sold tin boxes to three villages along the Quiet Road. Keeps grain fresh, he said. Worked, too. Then the wheat in Rhiannon's storehouse sprouted overnight and cracked the walls open, and the peddler is nowhere to be found.

The Beacons: Someone's been carving imperial survey markers into the milestones along the Quiet Road. A unit on patrol spotted the first one three weeks ago and took a chisel to it. Next morning it was back, cut deeper than before.

The Hidden Cache: A village bell rang last month. A kid's prank, false alarm. However, as result it turned out that Vanguard has enough weaponry to arm a small army. Much more than a village its size should. The Synod wants answers.

The Runaway: An eleven-year-old boy named Erik has escaped Cadfael village with nothing but the clothes on his back. His family is rightfully worried, but the other children of the village say it's better that way since he was "a witch".



The Races of Virelia

Variations on the human experience

"Races" isn't quite the right word here, but I'll be using it for lack of a better one. Can people plagued by magic-catching crystals be called a race? Can golems? Mistakes, anomalies, diseased, produced and discarded. These are the glorious creations of our short-sighted predecessors and our generous homeland.

Since I strongly refuse to take part in the endless arguments regarding taxonomy, I'll say only this: if it's common enough to have a name, and there's a common denominator that I can point to, then it's a race. I don't care whether you were born that way, shaped that way, infected or constructed by a bloody nutjob. Either way, you're it. People will name you so, and that's enough for you to join the catalogue.

Ancestries that could not have come from anywhere but here, and in some cases would probably have preferred not to. Though the will to live is often stronger than one's better judgement, as demonstrated by some of our more tragic cases.

I've written what I could gather on each, starting with my own observations, followed by brief factual excerpts that might serve the lazy, who, understandably, grew tired of my ceaseless babbling. Though in my defense, if there is indeed anything that separates us from cattle, it is culture.



What Was, And What Remains

If you'll indulge me, before we proceed to the newer races, I believe the old ones are deserving of an explanation too. I have seen ancient records lament the disappearance of ones such as Aasimar, Dragonborn and Tiefling. I assume the necessary conditions for their reproduction have been absent from Virelia in its current form, as none of them remain today. As for the ones who are still with us, I'll start by stating the ones that are commonly found.

Humans remain the majority in every region and require no further commentary. Dwarves are common, especially in Haldrith, where they and the rock gnomes have shaped the culture so completely that a visitor might forget what a naturally shaped stone looks like. You'll find both in most cities, in smaller or larger margins. Halflings are harder to pin down. They scatter, unable to sit in one place both in micro and macro levels. They're practically everywhere, especially the outskirts. Tintbent, upper Kelarra, Knotsreach. Places where the population is thin enough that five halflings in a settlement of fifty starts to feel like a demographic. It isn't. It's just that most others weren't stupid enough to stay. Forest gnomes are rarer. Myrskov and Lastrago, mostly.

Half-orcs are an uncomfortable topic to discuss. Orcs are out there, in the connecting tissue between holdings, scrapping over ground the rest of us couldn't keep. A child born of that kind of "encounter" is possible. The circumstances that produce one are rarely the kind anyone writes home about. The Orraks have made the question feel antique, and most people don't bother distinguishing anymore, to the offense of everyone involved.

Elves, supposedly, are still out there. Most living Virelians have never met one, but rumors tell of a strong core that remains hidden in Lastrago. A fellow researcher has told me they were plentiful once. However, they live for centuries and bear few children, and after eighteen centuries of indiscriminate death, the arithmetic did not work in their favor. A rift takes a village. Humans replace the loss in a generation. Elves carry it for centuries. Half-elves follow from the same scarcity, and carry no stigma beyond the obvious. There aren't enough elves left for anyone to have developed strong opinions on the matter, which is perhaps lucky when considering the way some other races are treated.

While I would've preferred to detail the ordeals and misfortunes each population has weathered these past eighteen centuries, I'm afraid this work will have to remain unfinished, for now. I prefer spending what limited time I have on what Virelia has birthed, instead of what it eroded, and I find it more fulfilling to engage with the misfits and the bizarre. It's a personal interest, or perversion. Depends on who you ask.

Race	Ability Score Increase	Lore Summary
Graith	+2 Any, +1 Other	Artificial beings created from stone, sand, or organic matter. They are driven by "mantras", ancient commands embedded in their form.
Orrak	+2 Con, +1 Str	Soldiers engineered from orcish stock who engage in ritual body modification.
Varn	+2 Int, +1 Con	Descendants of survivors from the Witch Wars. Crystalline growths on their bodies react to arcane energy.
Myrrkin	+2 Cha, +1 Wis	Natives of a dimension where emotion shaped reality, now trapped in Virelia.
Nirath	+2 Wis, +1 Con	Vessels housing three personalities (Aspects), which they switch between daily.
Duskwalker	+2 Int, +1 Wis	Not quite undead, but "echoes" formed by rifts between life and death.
Karex	+1 Any, +1 Other (+ Feat)	Mutants born from tears in reality. They are physically unstable, and prone to random anomalies.



Graith (*plural: Graith*)

Someone's solution to a problem



Observations:

Maybe there is something to be learned from how a Graith will watch a man bleed to death at its feet without so much as a flinch, then spend the next forty years caring deeply about doorknobs because its mantra mentioned "structural maintenance." Total indifference to anything outside the written purpose. Total, almost manic dedication to anything within it. One cannot help but wonder whether a predetermined purpose is the missing link we've all been searching for. And then one meets enough of them to realize it isn't.

They handle their mantras the way people handle scripture. Some take it at face value and carry on until reality stops cooperating, at which point they break. A mantra that says "look after safe 3-G" will hold a Graith together right up until there is no safe to look after, and what follows is not pleasant to witness. Others find a way to read the text generously. A Graith built to "make sure mr. borgvard is well fed" can, with some creativity, justify feeding any sod who walks through the door of what is now its tavern. It knows mr. borgvard is long dead, but one has to do something, I suppose.

And the rest abandon the mantras entirely, or attempt to rewrite them. Which goes about as well as you'd expect for someone whose entire identity was written on their chassis. The results range from catatonia to violence to sudden death. Maybe it's just a Graith's way of saying they've had enough.

Origins:

The process of making a Graith varies, but the principle is the same: a body is shaped from raw material, a set of mantras is inscribed or embedded into it, leave it alone for a few centuries in the right area or sprinkle some magic, and a Graith is born. Most living ones were produced during the Age of Silence, when the Remosan Empire's labor base was too busy being killed. The administration needed workers that didn't starve, didn't sicken, and didn't stop. The Graith were the solution, and the technology was so easy to use at the time that they quickly became the default for anything that needed doing. Some older ones exist, built by cultures or individual crafters that predate the empire's collapse, though these are rarer and their origins are harder to trace. The technology is considered lost today, but I've heard a few rare individuals are capable of replicating it, though to what level of sophistication is anyone's guess.

Stone, metal, glass, thread, sand, wood, organic matter, steam. The choice was usually dictated by the Graith's intended function and whatever the creator had on hand. Though I could swear some of them were led by artistic sense or just said "fuck it" when it came to design. The mantras are more consistent. Every Graith carries a set of commands etched into its form. They can't be vandalized, and they can't be disobeyed. These define its purpose, constrain its behavior, and shape what passes for personality. A Graith is always bound to something, and that something was not its own to decide.

Appearance:

Well, this is a challenge. Some have faces. Some don't. Some wear clothes. Some are clothes. Some have mantras etched across every surface in visible script. Some carry them somewhere you'll never find. Some look human enough to pass in a crowd. Some look like furniture that learned to walk. What I will say is that they are typically humanoid in scale, which is about as far as any general statement can take you. What they do share is wear. Graith don't age, but they erode, fray, crack, rust, and stain. A Graith that has been working for four centuries looks like it has been working for four centuries, and most of them see no reason to do anything about that.

A question that comes up often enough to address: no, they don't eat. Some can, in the same way you could try to taste something with your hands. The input registers. It doesn't nourish, and it rarely means what they want it to. Pain is similarly off-center. Damage is perceived, but as a diagnostic rather than a sensation. A cracked limb is information, not agony. What passes for physical pleasure varies wildly by material. A Stone Graith left in direct sun will stay there for hours and offer no explanation. I've met a glass Graith who swore warm baths are as close as one comes to heaven.

Cultural Traits:

Graith are solitary by default, and most spend long stretches alone without minding it. But they are definitely capable of developing emotionally, and often do. Especially when their purpose aligns with it. A Graith built to handle diplomacy, tend to a household, or care for children will, over enough time, develop something indistinguishable from genuine feeling. Whether it's a genuine expression of emotion or another tool for the job is a question both Graith and their loved ones usually don't bother asking. Luckily, there's everyone else to do that in their stead.

Actual Graith communities are unusual and a bit awkward. They form when a handful decide, more out of exhaustion than ideology, to sit down away from the meddling crowd and renegotiate what their mantras should mean. The results vary: a few become tight-knit circles of companionship and mutual maintenance. Most, well, most don't. Living with Graith takes adjustment. There isn't much to bond around. They don't sleep, unless you count mending. They don't eat, though some will sit at a table with you anyway. They develop habits, preferences, senses of humor. Over time, a Graith can feel as familiar as any person. Until a moment comes that abruptly reminds you otherwise.

Current Place in the World:

They're found across most of the continent, wherever the ancient Remosan empire had a foothold. Meaning, the further you go toward the outskirts of the continent, the less you'll see. Even in the center, their numbers are declining. Being a lost technology does that to a race. What used to be a part of every city's landscape has remained a daily occurrence only in the empire's hard core.

Whether Graith are people is a question most of Virelia answers based on convenience. They are constructs, so the question is not trivial. What the softhearted might call bigotry is a philosophical position that I think is worth acknowledging. When it is indeed a philosophical position, and not just fear. Graith that lose coherence are dangerous, that is an uncontested fact. But fear should not be the motivator behind our judgement of what is considered human, or the Graith will end up the first on a very long list of exclusions.

To be blunt, most of it is financial. Acknowledging personhood means wages, and nobody wants that. The debate, such as it is, lives almost entirely in modern Remosa, where the dependency is too large to ignore and too expensive to acknowledge. The Graith outside the empire's core have no debate to take sides in. Most carry on the way they always have, and the question of whether they count as people remains someone else's problem. Which, if nothing else, is a very human way to handle it.



Core Mechanics:

Ability Score Increase: +2 to one ability score of your choice, and +1 to a different ability score of your choice.

Size/Speed: Medium, 30 ft

Creature Type: Construct. You do not need to eat, drink, or breathe. However, you are not a mere object. For the purposes of spells and other magical effects, you are treated as humanoid. This includes *Cure Wounds*, *Hold Person*, and any other spell that might otherwise not work on Constructs.

Languages: You can speak, read, and write Common and one additional language of your choice.

Race Features:

Darkvision

You can see in dim light within 60 ft as if it were bright light, and in darkness as if it were dim light. You see in shades of gray.

Bound Purpose

You gain proficiency in one tool of your choice.

Arcane Maintenance

You know the *Mending* cantrip, which you need use to maintain your own body. Instead of sleeping, you must spend 4 hours in an inert, immobile state performing routine self-repair to gain the benefits of a long rest.



Material Subraces:

Choose one of the following material types from the following pages to determine your specific construct traits.

Stone

Built from granite, marble, or slate, you are a slow but immovable object.

Stone Sense: You possess an innate connection to the earth. You have **Tremorsense** out to a range of 10 feet. You can only detect movement on the surface you are currently standing on.

Granite Shell: Due to your rigid form, you are ill-suited to wearing armor. Your base Armor Class is **16** (your Dexterity modifier doesn't affect this number). You gain no benefit from wearing armor, but if you are using a shield, you can apply the shield's bonus as normal.

Rigid Form: You have **disadvantage** on Dexterity saving throws.

Metal

Forged from iron, steel, or bronze, you are a weapon of war.

Metallic Resilience: Your chassis deflects blades and points but dents under heavy force. You have **resistance** to non-magical Slashing and Piercing damage, but you have **vulnerability** to Bludgeoning damage.

Weighted Strikes: Your limbs are heavy and hard. Your unarmed strikes deal +1 damage.

Glass

Formed from crystal or glass, you manipulate light but shatter easily.

Fragile Composition: Your body resonates with sound and cracks under force. You have **vulnerability** to Thunder damage.

Refractive Shell: When a creature misses you with a ranged spell attack, you can use your reaction to redirect the scattered energy toward another creature within 10 feet of you. The new target must make a **Dexterity saving throw** (DC = 8 + your Proficiency Bonus + your Dexterity modifier). On a failed save, they take the damage the spell would have dealt. You can use this feature a number of times equal to your Proficiency Bonus, and you regain all expended uses when you finish a Long Rest.

Prismatic Camouflage: You can attempt to Hide even when you are only lightly obscured by bright light (such as direct sunlight or intense magical illumination).

Thread

Woven from silk, rope, or cloth, you are flexible and difficult to pin down.

Mnemonic Weave: Your body flows like fabric. You have **advantage** on saving throws against being **Grappled** or **Restrained**.

Deft Fibers: You have fine control over your delicate limbs. You gain proficiency in Acrobatics or Sleight of Hand (your choice).

Spider's Grip: You adhere easily to surfaces. You have a climbing speed equal to your walking speed.

Sand

Composed of thousands of grains, you are fluid and elusive.

Desert Resilience: You are born of the scorching sun. You have **resistance** to Fire damage.

Granular Form: You can momentarily disperse your body into shifting sand to bypass barriers. As an Action, you can transform along with your equipment to move up to your speed. During this movement, you can pass through openings as narrow as 1 inch wide without squeezing, and you do not provoke opportunity attacks. You immediately reform at the end of this movement. You can use this feature a number of times equal to your Proficiency Bonus, and you regain all expended uses when you finish a Short or a Long Rest.

Phasing: Your fluid form allows you to slip past enemies. You can move through spaces occupied by other creatures.

Saturation: Water is the enemy of your cohesion. If you start your turn submerged in water or effectively doused (e.g., heavy rain or a bucket of water), you become **Saturated** until you spend 1 minute drying off (or use a cantrip like *Prestidigitation*).

While Saturated:

1. Your speed is halved
2. You cannot use your *Granular Form* or *Phasing* traits.
3. You have disadvantage on Dexterity checks.

Wood

Carved from oak, ash, or ironwood, you are rooted and hardy.

Wilderness Instinct: You are made of the wild. You gain proficiency in the Survival skill.

Ancient Roots: As a Bonus Action, you can root yourself into the ground. Your speed becomes 0, and you cannot be moved against your will. While rooted, you reduce any non-magical Bludgeoning, Piercing, or Slashing damage you take by an amount equal to your Proficiency Bonus. You can end this effect as a Bonus Action.

Steam

A contained cloud of vapor, capable of obscuring vision and slipping through cracks.

Volatile State: You are naturally hot but lose cohesion in freezing temperatures. You have **resistance** to Fire damage but **vulnerability** to Cold damage.

Vaporous Camouflage: You blend into the mist. You can take the Hide action as a bonus action when you are lightly obscured by mist, fog, or similar gaseous effects (including those you create).

Vent: You can release built up pressure to obscure the battlefield. Once per short or long rest, you can use an action to create a 5-foot-radius sphere of light smoke centered on yourself. The fog remains for 1 round and then disperses.

Phasing: Your gaseous form allows you to slip past enemies. You can move through spaces occupied by other creatures.

Fungi

Grown from mycelium and organic matter, you are attuned to the cycle of decay and growth.

Mycotoxic Body: Your physiology thrives on toxins but withers under purification. You have **resistance** to Poison damage but **vulnerability** to Radiant damage.

Mycelial Communion: You can tap into the root network of the world. You can expend an hour to commune with plants, as if you had cast the spell *Speak with Plants*.

Fungal Intuition: You carry the knowledge of the forest. You gain proficiency in the Nature skill.

Flesh

Stitched together from disparate parts, you possess a grim utility.

Mortified Flesh: Your body rots easily. You have **vulnerability** to Necrotic damage.

Sensory Detachment: You can separate parts of your body for reconnaissance. As an action, you can detach one of your eyes or a hand.

The part has AC 10, 1 Hit Point, and a walking/climbing speed of 20 feet.

You can see through the eye or feel through the hand as long as it is within 100 feet of you. While your eye is detached or destroyed, you have **disadvantage** on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on sight.

If the part is destroyed, you take 1d4 psychic damage, and it regrows after you finish a short Rest.

Orrak (*plural: Orraks*)

Work in progress



Observations:

I've covered the Orrak presence in Remosa elsewhere in this volume, so I'll spare the repetition. What I find worth examining here is what that presence doesn't produce. Any one of them could break you in half without breaking a sweat, and yet a population of them has never leveraged that fact into anything resembling a political demand. They hold the garrisons, they fight in our wars, they do the hauling, the building, the labor that breaks lesser frames. And yet the better-paid posts go to humans. Not by law, mind you. By habit. A law can be repealed. A habit just sits there until enough people get killed.

The reasons are less dramatic than you'd expect. They're a race with no homeland, and with no political movements to fall back on. Combine that with a continent where everyone is struggling, and the resulting calculation is simple: you keep your head down. Who has the energy for protest these days? Who will they even protest against? Social norms, history? Please. They see themselves as more "Remosan" or "Haldrithian" than Orrak. If only the sentiment was shared by the older races as well.

The body modification gets a great deal of attention, and I'll detail it in the sections that follow. For now I'll note one thing. While one might be tempted to view it through a lens of self-expression, spirituality, or even a reclamation of their cruel upbringing, I think the true mechanism at work here is more bleak. When self-sovereignty is taken from one, the response is often to pretend that it exists elsewhere. Some become tyrants, and some turn inwards to shape the one thing they are capable of changing. You see where this is going. Never ever say that to an Orrak though.

Origins:

"What's a bio-forge anyway", you might ask. This ancient tech is more advanced than anything our researchers are capable of today, which is not the compliment it sounds like. The forges have been inoperable for centuries now, but there are records. It's a tough read. Apparently they took living orcs and altered them into something different enough to earn a new name. Tougher, smarter, less prone to violence, and above all, built to be modified. The empire adjusted its Orraks for whatever the assignment demanded. Bad air, restructured lungs. Unstable footing, reinforced joints. Couldn't maintain supply lines for armor, so they grafted plating straight into the shoulders. It was field maintenance, not culture. The culture came later, when the Orraks started doing it to themselves.

Luckily the forges are no longer needed. They were born with a "full package" and are definitely capable of reproducing naturally. You'll find them across most of the continent at this point, though like the Graith, there are more of them the closer you get to the empire's old core. Still manning garrisons, work crews and civic life. A portion deserted during the Fracture Wars. Small groups that split off, moved into the spaces between holdings, and scraped together a living on their own terms. Hunter-gatherers, mostly. These are the Orrak tribes, and they're still out there, small and scattered. Most Orraks will never join one, but you can be sure they're thinking about it after a rough day at work. Rarely a plan. Often a comfort.

Appearance:

Standing between 2.1 and 2.4 meters tall, the Orrak are mountains of dense, red-brown muscle that dominate whatever space they walk into. Their skin is textured and thick. Short horns grow from the upper forehead, curved or stubbed, and male Orraks often have lower tusks from the jaw as well. Pointed ears, heavy brow, dark hair, usually braided or cut short. The women are leaner and their faces are a touch more human-like. Still intense-looking though.

They grow quicker than humans and die considerably sooner. A fourteen-year-old is a man, and fifty is a respectable age. The decline, when it comes, is fast. A few years of rapid deterioration and then they're gone. There's no long twilight, an Orrak is functional until they aren't. By adolescence most have started modifying. The specifics are covered below, but visually: scarification, geometric tattooing cut deep into the hide, metal bolted along the arms or across the shoulders, bone studs set into the brow ridge. The unmodified ones tend to be children. Clothing is unremarkable. They dress like whoever they live among, with a preference for showing what they've done to themselves. I'd call it tacky if it wasn't so essential to their upbringing.

Cultural Traits:

An Orrak handles on their own the way you'd cut your own hair, but anything structural requires a specialist: jaw reconstruction, spinal reinforcement, organ work. Every Orrak community of any size has one. They aren't paid for the service, not directly anyway. The community honors them, keeps them fed and supplied, materials are gathered collectively, and in return their people get modified. In a garrison, the specialist is part of the unit. In a tribe, they work with what the land provides. Refusing is not illegal. It's worse. An unmodified adult is either making a statement about how they see themselves relative to the rest of their people, and it's not a flattering one, or they're simply the Orrak equivalent of someone who shows up to a formal dinner in their nightclothes. The charitable reading is eccentric. The usual one is less kind.

Orrak children are raised by their families in civic settings and by the tribe where one exists. A fourteen-year-old is expected to work, fight if necessary, and should probably already have their first significant modification. Orraks don't fuss over their young the way we tend to. The child is taught what it needs to survive, and then it's expected to do so. They speak less than most and have little patience for talk that doesn't go anywhere. This extends to academics, philosophy, extended debate. The exceptions to the rule tend to be either very good at what they do or a bit odd. Often both.

When the decline starts, an Orrak knows. The body they've spent their life shaping stops cooperating. Joints stiffen, modifications begin to reject, and the deterioration accelerates in a way that leaves little room for dignity. Most Orraks settle what needs settling, say what needs to be said, and end it alone on their own terms. It is

not discussed at length among Orraks, and it is not mourned the way humans mourn, but there is something. A father sitting with his children for an evening longer than usual. A packed bag by the door. A fitting end, I guess, for a race defined by complete control over their bodies.

Core Mechanics:

Ability Score Increase:

Constitution +2, Strength +1

Size/Speed: Medium, 30 ft

Creature Type: Humanoid

Languages: You can speak, read, and write Common and one additional language of your choice.

Race Features:

Bodysleep

You only require 4 hours of rest per day. During this time, you enter a semi-conscious regenerative state, maintaining awareness of your surroundings. You gain the full benefits of a long rest after this period, and you can stay alert and keep watch while it lasts.

Engineered Resilience

You have advantage on saving throws against being poisoned, and resistance to poison damage.

Adapted Form

At level 1, you choose one Physical Trait from the list below. You gain an additional trait at level 5 and again at level 9. You cannot choose the same trait more than once.



<u>Trait Name</u>	<u>Effect</u>
Stonehide Nodules	+1 AC while not wearing heavy armor.
Split-Jointed Legs	Your jump distances are doubled.
Knuckle Spikes	Your unarmed strikes deal 1d6 slashing damage. Disadvantage on attacks with finesse weapons.
Gravel Lung	You can hold your breath for 15 minutes and are immune to all inhaled gases (magical or mundane).
Grafted Shoulder Spur	When a creature hits you with an unarmed strike or light weapon, it takes 1d4 piercing damage.
Altered Scent Glands	You are immune to tracking by scent (magical or mundane).
Obsidian Tooth Implant	You can use your bite as a natural weapon which deals 1d6+Strength piercing damage. Lockjaw: When you hit a creature no more than one size larger than you with your bite attack, you can use a Bonus Action to latch onto them. The target is automatically Grappled. You can use this feature a number of times equal to your Proficiency Bonus, and you regain all expended uses when you finish a Long Rest.
Root-Split Feet	Advantage on checks to resist being shoved or knocked prone. You can climb natural surfaces without a climbing speed.
Back-Braced Arm Socket	Gain proficiency in Athletics.
Bone-Thread Hearing	Advantage on Perception checks involving sound. Detect invisible creatures within 3 m if they make noise. Vulnerable to magical deafening effects.
Flex-Spine Vertebrae	Move through spaces as narrow as 15 cm without squeezing. Advantage on Acrobatics checks to escape grapples.

Duskwalker (*plural: Duskwalkers*)

Close Enough



Observations:

What I have is anecdotes, a few secondhand accounts, and the uncomfortable fact that my usual method doesn't quite work here. Every other entry in this chapter describes a population. Duskwalkers are not a population. They are too few, too scattered, and too varied in origin to share anything resembling an ancestry. I can describe the condition. I can relay what I've observed in the individuals who carry it. But a chapter on their culture would require them to have one.

I've personally spoken with two, and to people who've encountered a handful more, and in every case the Duskwalker was the least interesting party in the room. I don't mean that unkindly. The condition is truly unusual. But the people carrying it were, in both cases, far less dramatic than the reactions they provoked. They're functional, direct. A tad too direct maybe. Perhaps it's unfamiliarity with communication, a result of the distance the living tend to take from them. And maybe they've just got too much on their plate for pleasantries. Either way, in the face of their indifference, it is usually the living who are having a crisis. Reaching for words, looking at the ceiling, crossing the street. People spend most of their lives either avoiding death, or avoiding thinking of death. Staring at it directly can get uncomfortable for many.

Interacting with one is a challenge I'd recommend to everyone and no one. The most mundane questions either have no answer or an answer that kills the conversation on the spot. "Where were you born?" "You mean originally, or the lab?" "Favorite food?" "I don't eat." You adjust, try something neutral. The weather, maybe. You might get a minute or two of normal exchange before something reminds both of you that the usual basis for conversation isn't there. And then the questions that curiosity produces once the politeness wears off. Whether they dream. Whether they still have to cut their toenails. What it feels like. Most people probably lack the tact to keep those to themselves. Now imagine doing this on every encounter, in every room, for what is potentially eternity for some Duskwalkers. No wonder they don't much care for conversation.



Origins:

The common thread, best anyone can tell, is the soul. The connection between a soul and a body gets interrupted, then resumes wrong. How that happens varies, and the people who claim to understand the specifics tend to disagree with each other in ways that suggest none of them fully do. A Rift sitting where life and death have gotten tangled can do it on its own. A specular cell with the right materials can force it. Grief and desperation have managed it under the right circumstances. The result, very rarely, and regardless of method, is a Duskwalker.

Most come from unstable Rifts. A tear opens where something died, or where the boundary was already thin, and whoever was nearby gets caught in it. What walks out the other side may carry fragments of a prior life or nothing at all. A name, a face they can't quite place. Or just the body and no explanation for it. Whether the blank ones are old souls that lost the thread or something entirely new is an open question. Butcher's Garden in central Remosa is the only stable Rift I'm familiar with that has consistently produced Duskwalkers, and the stories have given it a reputation for familial tragedy. Smart people avoid the place, and desperate ones come searching for even more despair. What good can come of a mother carrying her dead infant to a garden pulsing meat? As with all rifts, randomness is guaranteed, and the results are very rarely what a mourning person would have hoped for.

Deliberate cases are rarer and harder to generalize. The work generally happens in back rooms and private studies. A parent who lost a child and found the wrong kind of knowledge. A mage who stumbled across a wandering soul and, for reasons that amount to loneliness, built it a body. Amalgamists have seen limited success in assembling them from components... The methods vary. The results are similar enough that the distinction probably matters more to the people involved than to the Duskwalker.



Appearance:

Yes, they do look a bit like vampires. We can all stop dancing around the fact that when a person sees off-white skin and pale eyes, that's the first thing that comes to mind. Luckily, no fangs this time. But there are meaningful differences if you pay attention. The skin is marbled and uneven, and it doesn't do what living skin does. No flush, no sweat. Eyes come in washed-out blues and whites. Hair goes white or loses color entirely, which is why most of them shave it. Draws less attention than a head of white in a room full of brown. The ones made deliberately carry marks from the process, scarring or stitch-work, and the Rift-born tend to come out cleaner, for lack of a better word. They don't age. Three centuries in the same face without a single new crease. The connection doesn't always hold, though. Like most magic, it's only as strong as its source, and not all of them were made well. When it loosens, eventually the soul drifts free and the body is left with no one in it.

They're very still. A living body is always doing something. Shifting, breathing. A Duskwalker at rest does nothing, which registers as wrong before you've worked out why. The ones who care and got the talent for it can practice: they'll breathe, blink on a rhythm, and pass well enough in a crowd. Given enough make up, of course.

The body works, after a fashion. They can chew and swallow, but the taste comes back flat. Like chewing paper, is how one put it, and I can only assume it's true. Most don't bother. Sleep is similar. They need rest, and what that looks like, and in a way is, is a body lying still with its eyes open for four hours. Not a reassuring sight for anyone sharing a camp. Pain gets through, but dulled. The one thing that seems to work properly is temperature. They run cold and know it, and warmth registers as comfort to some. Apparently, that's rare enough for them to remark on.

Cultural Traits:

They don't need much. No food, no sleep beyond a few hours of rest, no biological urgency of any kind. A Duskwalker with no obligations can simply exist. One account I came across described a Rift-born who spent several years just walking along rivers and observing the things around her. She said it was quiet. Anyway, unlike the more "dead" ones, Duskwalkers who retained more of their prior life seem to have a harder time with the transition. They remember needing things: Carnal pleasures, companionship, purpose. The needs may be gone, but the memory of having them isn't, and that gap is, by all accounts, worse than having nothing to compare to.

I'm not sure what it is with Duskwalkers and death, though I have my suspicions. The ones at peace with their condition and the ones still struggling with it both seem to end up in the same place eventually. Mortuary work, burial rites, necromancy, clergy. The ones who don't engage with it professionally still seem drawn to it in their own time. I think it's familiarity more than fascination. The way someone who left a country young might still reach for books about it, not out of nostalgia exactly, it's more of a... recognizable texture. This does not, as you might imagine, help with the social situation.

Core Mechanics:

Ability Score Increase: Intelligence +2, Wisdom +1

Size/Speed: Medium, 30 ft

Creature Type: Humanoid

Languages: You can speak, read, and write Common and one additional language of your choice.

Race Features:

Darkvision

You can see in dim light within 60 ft as if it were bright light, and in darkness as if it were dim light. You see in shades of gray.

Unliving Metabolism

You have resistance to necrotic damage.

You do not need to eat or drink, and you are immune to magical hunger or thirst effects. You still require 4 hours of inert rest (as per the elf trance) to gain the benefits of a long rest.

You register as undead to divination magic and detection features (such as *Divine Sense* or *Detect Evil and Good*). However, for all other game effects, features, and spells, including *Turn Undead* and healing, you are considered a humanoid.

Still Presence

Your detached demeanor and minimal expression are difficult for others to parse. You gain proficiency in your choice of either the Intimidation or Insight skill. Additionally, creatures have disadvantage on Insight checks to read your emotions.

Funerary Training

You gain proficiency in Religion and learn the spare the dying cantrip.



Myrrkin (*plural: Myrrkin*)

Out of the frying pan and into the fire



Observations:

This is where I'd normally find my angle. I've been trying. The trouble is that a Myrrkin who crossed over in the first wave has very little in common with her granddaughter, born in Trefgann, who's never set foot in Myrr and considers the whole affair someone else's tragedy. Between them: violence, coin, blandness, sex, poverty, cruelty, hunger, boredom, exploit, privacy, family, the concept of a lie. Loneliness. Pain is private here. The only way across is words, and words were never up to the task. A century of adjustments I couldn't fit in a lifetime of work, let alone an introduction. The human experience, if you will excuse my sophistry. Anyway. Moving on.

The closest thing to a common thread I've found is privacy. I've written about Myrr and its relationship to Myrskov and I won't repeat myself, but the relevant fact is this: nothing was hidden there. What you carried inside was what the world looked like around you, and everyone grew up with that as the only way things could work. The Myrrkin who crossed into Virelia discovered, among everything else, that other people have interiors you cannot see. What follows from that is predictable enough. A human child works out deception around the age of three because the world requires it. Myrr didn't, and when the framework isn't there, the results are about what you'd expect.

I've heard enough accounts to know the pattern. But the ones who've been here long enough do learn, and some learn well enough that I'd caution against the assumption. A Myrrkin who already understands inner experience from the ground up, and has then acquired the Virelian habit of concealing it, is working with a combination most of us lack. A reputation for sincerity, a sharp read on people's emotional strings, and the capacity for cruelty. A minuscule minority, and we are probably fortunate that it is so.



Origins:

Leaving Myrr, as far as anyone's been able to explain it to me, was a matter of intention. You willed yourself elsewhere and you were elsewhere. One-way, though. Virelia's rules don't accommodate that kind of thinking, so once you're here, you're here. Some chose to stay and slowly wilt along with what's left of Myrr. The ones arriving now are the ones who finally ran out of reasons to justify this. Or there's always curiosity. Whatever the reason is, they turn up near the edges of Myrskov, disoriented and, by more than one account, physically ill.

Why their bodies work here at all is a mystery even to them. Digestion, immune response, reproduction, sweat. In Myrr none of these operated the way they do here, if at all. Conception was conceptual rather than physical, and yes, I stand by that phrasing. The competing positions are about what you'd expect: the biology was always present, dormant under Myrr's rules, and activated when those rules stopped applying. Or the crossing itself reshapes the body to match Virelian physics. Or, and the Myrrkin lean toward this one, fey bodies simply adapt to local conditions because "whimsy". Nobody has won the argument, and the Myrrkin I've spoken with about it preferred to change the subject.

The practical fact is that they reproduce here, and have been doing so long enough that there are now three living generations in most established communities. The first are refugees who remember Myrr. They know what they lost and their relationship to Virelia is that of a stranger, whether they arrived last century or last month. The second were born here. They've been told what Myrr was and they understand, the way anyone understands a parent's grief over something they've never experienced. The third, where it exists, treats the subject the way most people treat ancestral history. Interesting at gatherings. Otherwise, someone else's problem.

Cultural Traits:

The first thing that surprised me about newly arrived Myrrkin is that they're not miserable. I expected downtrodden refugees. What I got, at least initially, was something closer to a child at a fair. Everything is new. Rain is new. Markets are new. The taste of bread is new. They want to touch everything, try everything, ask about everything. The ones I've spoken with in those early years had a breathless quality to them that I can only describe as exhausting. Give it a few years and the novelty wears thin and the harder adjustments settle in. Then they get to be exhausted too.

Pair-bonding in the way humans do it doesn't come naturally to most. Partnerships are fluid, and the vocabulary for what counts as "family" is broad enough that I've given up trying to map it onto anything I recognize. Those who stick to groups tend to live communally instead, children included. They also roam. "A halfling is just an undercooked Myrrkin", as they say. New arrivals in particular can't seem to sit still, and it's a matter of luck whether they find that the world is their oyster or that they are its.

Appearance:

Tall, lean, dark-skinned with a sheen to it. Bronze is the closest comparison. Horns are usually spirals, and they wrap them in dyed thread, paint them, drip pigment. Very particular about this, touchy subject. Hair usually comes in metallic colors: gold, teal. Eyes dark or amber. Clothing is all over the place. Whatever suits them at the day, as long as it's not trivial and reflects their mood at the time. Real fashionistas. Masks also come up a lot near Myrskov. Same reasoning, though it's a bit much in my eyes.

First-generation crossers had to learn physical sensation from scratch, and I can't do that justice in a paragraph. Food came up first in every conversation I've had about it. Not the taste, though that was a lot to deal with. The demand. Your body needs food, and if you don't feed it, it escalates. Having your own body issue ultimatums was, and I'm quoting, "offensive." I've met crossers who still eat like they're not sure it's going to work. Pain follows the same logic. It can't be argued with. Sex is more complicated, but I'd prefer if you referred the question to a Myrrkin. What I will say is that they tend to be open minded about it, but that might just be a stereotype stemming from their family structure, or lack thereof. Sleep, sweat, alcohol, drugs, and the whole catalogue of things a body does without consulting you, I swear, I'd need another volume.

They don't seem to grow old, but around the second century of their life, they start to go. The body loses definition, gets translucent. Takes a few years. By most accounts it's painless, though I'd note that nobody who's been through the whole thing has come back to file a report. The Myrrkin believe what's left returns to Myrr, and they'd probably find my skepticism tiresome, but I've never been inclined to take anyone's afterlife claims at face value, theirs included. What's observable is that the body fades until there's nothing left. Where it goes is a matter of faith. The aging crossers say they feel a pull, and seem to find this a comfort. Their grandchildren less so. Similar to our relationship with afterlife: it's something they've been told about, can't verify, and aren't eager to test.

It's worth noting that despite that, when a Myrrkin dies before the fade, the body stays. It breaks, bleeds, rots like everything else. To them, this also means whatever was meant to return to Myrr never will. Truly dead, in a way the fading aren't. Faith can backfire just as hard, apparently.

Current Place in the World:

Myrskov is the obvious concentration. New arrivals are still coming through there, and the communities near Myrskov absorb them the way Myrrkin handle most things: communally, without much structure, and with the expectation that you help if you're nearby. A disoriented Myrrkin stumbles out of the treeline and whoever's closest takes them in and explains what eating is. If you were unlucky enough to miss them and wander further out, the adjustment is considerably less gentle, and many end up feral. Both in the Myrskov sense of the word, and in the regular one, for those who wandered past the communities entirely and found civilization on their own terms. Kelarra has a lot of them too, I think. I guess it suits their style, and it's nearby. That always helps. Beyond that, scattered. You'll find a commune in an unexpected place now and then, but no cluster worth naming.

Individual Myrrkin turn up everywhere in small numbers. Pebbleclink Warbler Candlewax Dust Rice sits on the Haldrith Nonagon, in case you needed a demonstration of my earlier comment from the observations page. This should tell you enough about how far integration has come, but just to be sure: you can find them in politics, trade, academics, and also in groups that aren't shy about sullying their hands.

Which brings us to the unavoidable topic of their names. What most first-generation crossers land on is whatever caught their attention in those early dazzled years. A word they liked the sound of. A texture. The color of something at a market, or a song a stranger was humming when they first walked into a town. Try asking one why she called herself "Cobweb Beebuzz Yeast Ceramiccup" and you'll quickly regret it. The later generations inherit or shorten these, or just go with Virelian names. By the third generation most have something conventional with a Myrrkin name trailing behind it that we all collectively agree to ignore.



Core Mechanics:

Ability Score Increase: Charisma +2, Wisdom +1

Size/Speed: Medium, 30 ft

Creature Type: Fey

Languages: You can speak, read, and write Common and Sylvan.

Race Features:

Darkvision

You can see in dim light within 60 feet of you as if it were bright light, and in darkness as if it were dim light.

Conceptual Memory

At the GM's discretion, in places where a strong feeling has lingered, such as a fresh battlefield or a site of grief, you may perceive the surroundings in faint color that corresponds to that emotion (e.g., red for violence, blue for grief).

Fey Ancestry

You have advantage on saving throws against being charmed, and magic can't put you to sleep.

Sincere Soul

You gain proficiency in either the **Insight** or **Performance** skill.

Bleed Through

Your state of mind is carried in your strikes and magic. When you deal damage with a spell or an attack, you can choose to substitute the damage type with one of the following, based on the emotion you project:

Fury: Fire damage

Sorrow: Cold damage

Dread: Psychic damage

You can use this feature a number of times equal to your Proficiency Bonus, and you regain all expended uses when you finish a long rest.

Myrr's Vestige

You possess a weakened residue from your homeland's intertwining.

You know the *Minor Illusion* cantrip. When you reach 3rd level, you can cast the *Color Spray* spell once with this trait and regain the ability to do so when you finish a long rest. When you reach 5th level, you can cast the *Phantasmal Force* spell once with this trait and regain the ability to do so when you finish a long rest. Charisma is your spellcasting ability for these spells.

Nirath (plural: Nirathi)

Building Blocks



Observations:

My take, to much controversy, is that Nirathi are basically normal people. Put aside the spectacle, the reputation, and what you're left with is the somewhat underwhelming reality of a person who wakes up on one foot and then on the other. Same as anyone, really. And where there's banality, there is religion, which, as always, is followed by controversy and a good measure of death. People dislike being told something is better than them. The very possibility, whether true or not, insults them. Now build a religion around that. Tell a scattered few they carry shards of divinity inside them and the rest of us don't, and then let them notify everyone else of this fact. Our relationship to the divine, as a continent, has not exactly been a calm one. Eighteen centuries and counting. You can assume how well the whole thing sits with people. This, by all accounts, does not work in their favor. A dry season comes, no god in sight to blame, but oh, there it is! They even admit to it! Well, if someone is to blame, surely it must be him. The alternative is chaos, and we can't have that.

It's all so silly. People killing, dying, chasing meaning, all in the name of the stories we tell ourselves. Imagine a child of three. Barely learned to speak. His mind splits, along with his skin. His parents change overnight. He hasn't yet learned the concept of friendship and already he is othered by most. Tell him there's a reason for it all. That he is divine, chosen. What child would refuse the notion? And at this point, true or not, Nirathi are as much the story they tell themselves as everyone else is.

Origins:

The condition surfaces in human children around age three or four. No other pattern anyone has managed to identify. The physical Mosaic appears first, followed within weeks by the Aspects. Three distinct Aspects, each with its own posture, aptitudes, and its way of approaching a problem. The Convergence will tell you these are fragments of a shattered god, recycled between hosts across generations. The less poetic explanation is that the human mind, under conditions nobody fully understands, fractures along predictable lines. Either way, the baseline self is continuous, which is the part most accounts get wrong. A Nirath doesn't disappear when an Aspect takes the lead. They're still there, drawn a certain way. Think of it as... emphasis, maybe. The same person with different parts turned up or down.

The three don't always agree. A Nirath can want contradictory things depending on which Aspect has the floor, and the negotiations are internal and, by most accounts, bellicose. The condition is permanent. No treatments. A few scholars study it. A scattering of adult Nirathi can offer practical guidance if they're nearby, which they usually aren't. Some families adapt, some find the Convergence, some abandon. A child who develops the condition in a city has good odds, a child in a village that's never seen a Nirath, less so.

Reports on the existence of Nirathi go back as far as 1432 years ago, and since "The Epics of Leila" mentions one only in passing, we can only assume the phenomenon predates that year by a large margin. The Sundering is the current prevailing theory. If reality can fracture randomly, then why not human psyche. But it is said that the absence of evidence isn't evidence of absence, and eighteen centuries of war have left us few reliable archives. So it's possible the phenomenon predates the Sundering entirely.

An earlier mention might solve the riddle, and scholars have been looking for one as long as I've been alive. Other theories compete for the gap. The Divine Residue crowd argues that leftover divine energy interacts with developing minds in ways nobody planned for, and the resemblance to what the Nirathi themselves claim is hard to miss. More on that shortly. A smaller camp holds that the condition isn't magical at all, that the personality fractures are neurological and nothing else. This, in my opinion, raises an obvious problem with consistency: always three, never two or five, and the archetypes repeat across Nirathi in ways coincidence struggles to explain. The proponents have answers for this, but I never much cared for them.

Appearance:

They age normally, which surprises people for some reason. Human lifespan, human decline, human death. The Convergence sees the body as a temporary host. They rebranded death to "Dispersion" and claim the Aspects return to the pool. The vessel goes in the ground like the rest of us.

Here is what bothers me about looking at one, and it took me years to put my finger on it. The skin is what everyone describes first. Cracked earth, patches of different tone meeting at sharp geometric seams with a faint metallic quality to them. Eyes mismatched, hair in patches. You'd expect the sum of all that to be a mess, and it isn't. They're never ugly. The patches sit in balanced arrangements, the faces are symmetrical, everything is neatly organized in a way that human bodies generally aren't. A person who looks broken should look the part. A Nirath looks assembled, carefully so, by someone with taste. I've spent a career not believing what the Convergence preaches, and I'll maintain that to my grave, but I'd be lying if I said the bodies don't make for a good argument. The ocean-blue robes the devout wear don't. They're like monks, but with a different shade of self-deception.

One more thing: when an Aspect takes the lead, the seams flare for a moment and the body rearranges itself. New posture, the voice used differently, another way of carrying the hands. From the outside it reads like a practiced character switch. From the inside, who knows but the Nirathi.

Cultural Traits:

Paired Nirathi handle the condition better. That's not insight, just observable. The condition is isolating in a way that's hard to get across to someone who hasn't lived with it, because the isolation isn't physical. A Nirath has friends, family, colleagues. But every one of those relationships runs across a gap of three Aspects, and most people don't have the patience for someone who was warm yesterday and curt today and quietly fixated on something unrelated tomorrow. Another Nirath doesn't need it explained. The pairing, when it happens, is usually not deliberate. Two, three, four Nirathi in the same city, one hears about the other, they meet. What it becomes after that varies. The devout treat it as sacred, a step toward the Convergence's reassembly. Pardon, but again, more on that later.

The Alignment is the daily part most people hear about and most misunderstand. Each morning a Nirath settles which Aspect leads. It's a daily negotiation between their inner Aspects, followed by a vote, and some mornings the discussions can turn ugly. An Aspect that suited yesterday's work might not suit today's, but it doesn't always step aside on request. A Nirath who can't resolve the Alignment is in for a rough day, and the people around them are in for a rougher one. The devout frame this as spiritual discipline. The secular ones frame it as Tuesday. In practice the distinction matters less than it sounds. A devout Nirath and a secular one in the same room will agree on most things. The experience is similar, no matter how you frame it.

The Convergence, then, since I've been putting it off. The Convergence believe they're constructing a god. That's the bottom line. To a believer, the Aspects are fragments of what used to be a whole. Some Nirathi claim a normal pre-Sundering god, and others say it's something larger. A being ingrained in the laws of our world which predates the known gods, who were merely one more of its creations. I've heard both pitches, and hope to not witness either version in my lifetime. So, both agree that parts of this god have broken down along with Virelia, and that with enough time, the aspects will harmonize back into a divine whole. To them, the Alignment isn't settling who leads for the day. It's the daily work of harmonizing its fragments. A sacred negotiation. Get it right, and you're a step closer to the goal, which is nothing short of reassembling the original god across every living Nirath. The pairing is part of this. Two Nirathi working in tandem, harmonizing six Aspects between them, advancing the project together. Death is just another step. An opportunity for the aspects to find new hosts and continue the work elsewhere. There is no clergy, few texts, none of which are scripture, and no central authority deciding who is devout enough. The theology spreads by word of mouth more than anything. Whether a Nirath learns it from a peer or a bigot is a matter of luck.

Current Place in the World:

They're found wherever humans are, in numbers too small to count as a demographic. No city has a Nirathi quarter, no region claims them. The versatility gets them hired. A Nirath with the right Aspects can shift between skills that would normally require different specialists, and guilds and mercenary outfits figured this out early. A fighter who becomes a field medic after a night's rest is worth whatever discomfort comes with it. So they fill necessary roles. Essential, even. And resented for it, the way anything essential is when it comes from someone you'd rather not need. The flexibility that makes them useful to a guild commander is the same trait a crowd remembers when the season turns. A person who can be three things is impressive when you're paying and suspicious when you're competing for the same job.

The rest of the time they're ordinary, which is the part that makes the periodic violence so hard to predict. A Nirath who's been your neighbor for years, whose work you've relied on, whose children grew up with yours. And then a rift opens or a harvest fails and the seams are all anyone sees. Long stretches of ordinary life, and then a week where that isn't, and then ordinary again and nobody mentions it. I feel like most Nirathi don't dwell on the violence much. They describe the return to normal. That, apparently, is the harder adjustment.



Core Mechanics:

Ability Score Increase: Wisdom +2, Constitution +1

Size/Speed: Medium, 30 ft

Creature Type: Humanoid

Languages: You can speak, read, and write Common and one additional language of your choice.

Race Features:

Psychic Fortress

A mind pulling in three directions is difficult for others to navigate. You have resistance to psychic damage.

Flash of Convergence

Once per long rest, as a bonus action, you can enter a state of rapid mental synthesis for 1 minute. While this state is active, the next effects apply:

Fluidity: You can switch your Leading Aspect as a bonus action. Your proficiency changes accordingly.

Unity: You gain advantage on one ability check associated with an Aspect in your Cabinet. You can choose to use this benefit before or after rolling the die, but before the outcome is determined.

Exhaustion: When the minute ends, the mental strain leaves you lethargic. You cannot use this feature again until you finish a long rest.

The Cabinet:

At 1st level, you define your internal council. Choose **three Aspects** from the table below to form your Cabinet. These are the only Aspects available to you. When you finish a Long Rest, you must perform an **Alignment**, choosing one Aspect from your Cabinet to be the "Leading Aspect." You gain the Skill Proficiency and the Passive Benefit of that Aspect until your next Long Rest.

Note: When choosing your aspects in level 1, If you already possess a skill proficiency granted by an Aspect (through your class, background, or another source), you may choose a different skill proficiency to permanently associate with that Aspect instead.

Aspect	Skill Proficiency	Passive Benefit
The Vanguard	Athletics	Battle-Hardened: You gain a +1 bonus to AC while you are wearing armor or wielding a shield.
The Shadow	Stealth	Soft Step: You can attempt to Hide even when you are only lightly obscured (e.g., dim light, foliage, rain).
The Noble	Persuasion	Silver Tongue: You know the <i>Message</i> cantrip. Additionally, you can speak telepathically to any creature you can see within 30 feet.
The Scribe	History	Polyglot: You can read (but not speak) all languages. You have advantage on checks to decipher codes or ciphers.
The Mender	Medicine	Distance Healer: You know the <i>Spare the Dying</i> cantrip. For you, the spell has a range of 30 feet instead of touch.
The Watcher	Perception	Vigilance: You cannot be surprised while you are conscious, and you gain Darkvision out to 60 feet (or +30 feet if you already have it).
The Maker	Artisan's Tools (One)	Architect's Will: As an action, you can magically conjure a functional, spectral version of a non-magical item of adventuring gear (value < 10gp). It lasts for 1 hour or until it takes any damage. You can have only one such item active at a time.
The Breaker	Intimidation	Siege Force: Your melee attacks deal double damage to objects and structures. You have advantage on Strength checks to break doors or bindings.
The Drifter	Survival	Storm-Proof: You automatically know the weather for the next 24 hours. You suffer no exhaustion from Extreme Heat or Extreme Cold, and you cannot be lost by non-magical means.
The Magus	Arcana	Magic Sense: You can cast <i>Detect Magic</i> as a ritual. You can sense the presence of magic within 10 feet of you without casting.
The Acrobat	Acrobatics	Parkour: You have a climbing speed equal to your walking speed, and you ignore non-magical difficult terrain.
The Anchor	Insight	Immovable: You cannot be compelled to move against your will by magical or non-magical means.



Varn (*plural: Varn*)

In a sense



Observations:

Everyone seems to agree that Varn are fine and all, but they shouldn't have children. The condition is hereditary, after all, and the logic writes itself. Why pass it on? The potions shop noise keeping you up, the neighbor's Create Bonfire cantrip setting your teeth on edge for a week? Don't reproduce. It doesn't matter the complaint. The answer is always in the blood. Always meant helpfully too, I'm told, which is apparently even more annoying.

I might be the only person on this continent who thinks of them as a separate race. To everyone else they're just people, crystals and all. Part of the room. A category would at least garner a response. Sometimes a negative one, but it at least gives one something to push against. The Varn don't have that. No founding myth, no shared tradition, no cruel nemesis to point their finger at. Just a disease. Their problems stay personal because nobody, Varn included, has thought to make them a collective. A mage opens a workshop. The Varn next door can't sleep. That's a dispute between neighbors. You can't expect us to sanitize the entire city, after all.

Few of the Varn are angry enough to be heading somewhere with it, but I think none of them could tell you where if you've asked. They can't point at the mage and call him cruel. Nor can they point at anyone else, really. The sound doesn't stop, though, and at some point "nobody is to blame" translates to some Varn as "everyone is". Well good luck changing that.

Origins:

Varn, in summary, are what happens when a humanoid is exposed to too much arcane energy in a short period of time. Sometimes the very same day, rarely, only a generation later. One way or other, once it sticks, it sticks. Descendants included. The Witch Wars provided plenty of that. Entire villages were wiped, Varn being the only ones to rise from the ashes. Since today's wars are more modest in scale, these days Varn are mostly produced like the rest of us. On very rare occasions, rifts can produce new ones, but they might be better catalogued as Karex instead. The question is completely out of my scope, if I'm to be honest.

We are familiar with their origins mostly thanks to "On Traumatogenic Pathogenesis", written 1491 years ago. Listed among other maladies which made an appearance at the time. As the book so romantically puts it: "...excess energy calcifies along existing nerve pathways. The resulting crystalline formations bond to the periosteum and thread outward through the dermis. The lattice registers to the bearer as a persistent tightness comparable to a healing burn. Once established, ambient arcane energy, even at concentrations negligible to an unaffected subject, feeds continuously into the structure and is perceived as pressure, vibration, or sharp pain in acute cases." Fifteen centuries and that's still roughly the sum of what scholarship has to say about the experience. The only thing that changed is we've had enough generations to confirm that a Varn's child is a Varn. Always. Severity varies, but the condition itself passes without exception.

Appearance:

To quote "On Traumatogenic Pathogenesis" again, the growths favor "areas of high nerve density: the spine, the brow ridge, the inner forearm, the joints of the hands. The lattice is warm to the touch, faintly resonant under pressure..." Beyond that, it's as varied as the range of one's misfortune. I've seen Varn whose crystals amounted to a thin ridge above the eyebrow. Barely visible with the right glasses. I've seen others who looked like something bigger than them was trying to come out of their bodies. Clusters breaking through the skin along the shoulders and the back of the neck, heavy enough to affect posture, and expensive enough to outfit that a severe Varn's tailor bill would make a Haldrithian guild-master wince. Most grow in shades of dark violet, though wine red, black, and on rare occasions pink have been documented. The crystals sense arcane energy the way skin senses heat, a second scale laid on top of everything else. Most describe it as bearable. Some find it unbearable. A few, apparently, get a kick out of it. Always seemed odd to me. Though, I never understood people who were drawn to saunas also.

They age like whatever race they were originally, which brings me to something I probably should have mentioned sooner. The lattice corrupts the nervous system in ways that biology can't route around. A Varn elf sleeps. Full nights, like a human, dead to the world. A Varn dwarf loses the dark. Same build, same face, can't see ten feet into the tunnel his healthy father works daily. The condition doesn't care what you were born as. It takes what it takes and leaves you something else. Not human, exactly. A Varn. Come to think of it, that's probably why I put them in this chapter. A Varn dwarf has more in common with a Varn elf than with anyone in his own family, and neither of them has worked that out yet.



Cultural Traits:

A Varn in a quiet farming village with no enchantments and a hedge-witch who visits twice a year has it about as good as it gets. A Varn in Haldrith adjusts or leaves. Tintbent, Myrskov and Knotsreach are essentially off the table. The spread follows the noise, more or less, and where you end up determines most of what your life looks like. Every Varn has to work out what magic is to them. Run from it, hate it, try to control it, learn to love it. Indifference isn't on the menu, and I think that's why so many of them end up in magic-adjacent work. Not just because they're good at it, though they are, the weirdos. But I think the real reason is that they like it. It gives them a sense of control, or a purpose for the whole thing. Better than the alternative, which is trying to ignore a sense you were born with.

Finding a partner is a related problem, now that I think about it. The crystals are physical, and not everyone wants to sleep next to warm and humming glass shrapnel. Some people find it exotic, which is its own problem, especially for Varn women. You're looking for someone who neither fetishizes nor avoids the growths and also doesn't mind the hereditary issue. Narrow field. The quiet settlements up in the Kelarra peaks and on the edges of Molakar solve this by default, since everyone there has crystals and nobody's casting. A few dozen families in the ones I've heard of. Strict places, but the people living there would tell you it's more than worth it. The other direction is harder to explain and a touch cultish, if I'm honest. Small communes, mostly in the interior, where the Varn don't avoid the input but try to harmonize with it. Communal casting, set intervals, something between a ritual and a tuning exercise. They describe it the way a musician might describe an ensemble. I'll take their word for it, and make sure to continue to avoid them.

One more thing I should touch on. Some Varn dabble in terror. To the benefit of everyone involved, the phenomenon is still marginal, and most governments would probably deny it altogether. But it is a traceable pattern that I, as well as some other researchers, have noticed. A workshop torched here, a ward-stone vandalized there. Individual sentencing, paperwork filed, no connection drawn. The Varn who do it can't quite articulate what they're after. Unless you count "society is evil" an acceptable explanation. The ones who don't would rather not be associated with the ones who do, which, given the Observations above, is an irony I'll leave for the reader. Maybe it's because of the small scale, but oddly, people haven't seemed to catch on to the fact that such cases share a pattern. To them, it's a random arson, not an act of resistance. I say, give it a few years. Or quicker yet, a catalyst with a large enough body count. Then we'll have to recalibrate, and this paragraph will unfortunately no longer be topical.

Core Mechanics:

Varn Condition: Varn is not a separate race, but a hereditary condition that can manifest in any humanoid. When choosing Varn, select a base race. You retain that race's Size, Speed, and Age characteristics. All other racial traits are replaced by the Varn features listed below. This includes traits such as Darkvision, Trance, Dwarven Resilience, Brave, and Fey Ancestry.

Ability Score Increase: Intelligence +2, Constitution +1

Creature Type: Humanoid

Languages: You can speak, read, and write Common and one additional language of your choice.

Race Features:

Crystallum Legacy

You gain proficiency in the Arcana skill.

Crystal-Marked: Arcane Detection

Your crystals constantly draw in ambient magic, making you an ideal sensor. You can cast the *Detect Magic* spell as a ritual, without expending a spell slot.

Attuned Focus

As a bonus action, you can enter a state of heightened arcane perception. For 1 minute, you gain +2 to your Passive Wisdom (Perception) and cannot be surprised by a creature using a spell or magical ability within 30 feet of you. You can use this feature a number of times equal to your Proficiency Bonus, regaining all expended uses when you finish a Long Rest.

Volatile Feedback

Your crystals instinctively conduct raw magic away from your vital organs. When you take damage from a spell or magical ability, you can use your reaction to reduce the damage by 1d10. The energy you absorb is stored in your crystals. The next time you hit with a weapon or spell attack within 1 minute, you deal additional Force damage equal to the amount you reduced. You can use this feature a number of times equal to your Proficiency Bonus, and you regain all expended uses when you finish a Long Rest.

Karex (*plural: Karex*)

Landmade Men



Observations:

A Karex is a person who was somehow permanently affected by a Rift. I'll start there because it's about the only clean definition this entry is going to get. They share nothing else. Nothing. The word itself is a filing convenience, though a commonly used one. I included them here because I wanted to write about them and there was nowhere else to put them. So there, it's your problem now. What makes them different from the other entries in this chapter is that every other race is safely not you. Nobody lies awake worried about becoming a Graith. But a Rift can form anywhere with no warning. You might not even realize it's there until its effects bleed into you. Everyone knows at least one person who just woke up as a Karex one day, not even sure how and when it occurred. It colors everything. A Karex who can read ancient texts gets attention that isn't quite respect. A Karex who eats gravel gets a distance that isn't quite cruelty. The same neighbor will pity one and envy the other and be disgusted by the third and never work out that all reactions come from the same place.

I've always felt they're the most fitting group to our troubled continent. Virelia comes in, Karex comes out. People who were quite literally bound with our land. Its essence, its breakage. I apologize for being a tad melodramatic here, but the metaphor is practically impossible to ignore. It's all just so random, the same way everything in life is. You might be born with a sharp mind or a bad back. In Virelia, you might also stop reflecting light. The range is wider, the stakes are higher, but the principle is the same. Lastrago straps them to temple spires. Molakar goes to war over them. The Weave pays well for the ones whose bodies have adapted to specific types of rifts. Whether any given Karex is a freak or a prophet depends entirely on where they ended up and what someone found to do with them. And then there's the rest, the ones nobody found a use for. They get to serve no purpose, like the rest of us.

Origins:

To have any meaningful discussion about the origins of the Karex, I should start by explaining what a Rift is. Virelia's governing laws have diluted since the Sundering. While reality is mostly still intact, occasionally things slip. That's a rift. They can take many forms. Endless, in fact. The Weave have made an attempt at a cataloging system, if you want to delve deeper into that. Point is, it's rarely simple. A rift can be conceptual, physical, temporal, sentient... You get the gist. Some rifts engulf entire regions, while a tiny fracture might form at the exact point of pressure where a fireball is cast.

Which is how you get Karex. A person walks through one of these, or lives near one long enough, or was simply born in the wrong spot, and something sticks. It isn't hereditary, unlike the Varn. But plenty of mothers have tried to split the difference. Live near the right rift at the right month, and maybe the child comes out special. Maybe it doesn't come out at all.

Any of the old races can become Karex. The newer ones seem to be exempt, though I'd hesitate to call that confirmed. But generally speaking, the anomaly sits on top, whether you're a halfling or a half-orc. The dramatic cases are easy. A mining crew hits a spatial rift, one of them walks out with a shadow that moves independently. A woman in Rivhalde stopped aging at forty. Her wife noticed before she did. She'd never been near a documented rift, but that's the point. You don't always know. I swear half the adolescents on this continent have convinced themselves they're Karex at some point. A strange dream, a birthmark, a persistent cough, a feeling that you're different. The definition is wide enough that nobody can tell them they're wrong with any authority. The actual Karex, the ones who eat rocks or whose breath comes out in colors, find this less amusing than everyone else does.

Appearance:

Yeah, I give up on that one.

Current Place in the World:

A Karex with a limb that doesn't match the rest of them is dealing with a different life than one with borrowed memories, and they both know it. The visible ones get stared at. The invisible ones get to wonder whether they should mention it on dates. Most don't. I wouldn't call it "stigma," that would be too far. But they're usually the first to get bullied as kids, and even between them I've seen very little camaraderie. Despite them being roughly 5% of the population. And most Karex, to my surprise, seem to accept this.

Where you live matters too. Rift-adjacent towns have seen enough of this that a Karex is just another thing to work around. In Rivhalde, where the Compact pays to keep rifts shut, they're rarer and stranger for it. Even more so in Tavernash. In Knotsreach, where the land itself barely follows the rules, they're part of the furniture. But a large share of almost nobody is still almost nobody.

With rare exceptions (Lastrago's infamous "zombies" incident comes to mind) the condition doesn't spread between people. That hasn't stopped anyone from treating certain Karex like it might. The ones who glow, hum, or whose presence makes candles flicker tend to find themselves drinking alone more often than they'd like, regardless of whether any of it is actually contagious. The Weave recruits from exactly this crowd. A body that already survived rift exposure has obvious professional value in an organization that walks into rifts for a living. Whether they're hired out of respect or to keep them where they can be watched and studied is a question I've asked more than one agent, and the answer depends on how many drinks they've had.

Core Mechanics:

Karex is not a race. It is a template applied to a character of any race at character creation or, at the GM's discretion, to an existing character who survives rift exposure. Your ability score increase, size, speed and languages remain the same.

Race Features:

You retain all traits of your base race, except as noted below. Choose one anomaly from either Riftmark, Alteration, or Expression.

Riftmark

Roll once on the Rift Anomaly table, or take a result of the GM's choosing. Your anomaly is permanent. It is neither a curse nor a spell effect. *remove curse* and *dispel magic* have no effect on it.

Alteration (Optional)

When you choose this template, you may replace one racial trait of your base race with an Alteration of your choice, with your GM's approval. The choice is permanent.

Expression (Optional)

Expressions are feats with the prerequisite "Karex." You can have no more than one Expression. An Expression taken after 1st level represents an anomaly surfacing or deepening later in life; work out the circumstances with your GM.

Riftmark Anomalies (d100):

d100	Anomaly
1	Deadweight. You weigh roughly three times what you should. You look the same.
2	Voiced Text. You hear written text spoken aloud. Always in the same voice. You might know whose.
3	The Kept Seat. In any inn or hall, one chair is empty when you arrive. Circumstances always seem to align perfectly for this to happen.
4	Parting. Rain, dust, and falling debris part slightly around you without touching.
5	Hollow Craving. Standard food doesn't sustain you. What does is mineral. Stone, packed dirt, wet iron. You learn your preferences quickly.
6	Borrowed Path. You have vivid memories of events you never experienced.
7	Conductive. Lightning and electricity seek you out. Not exclusively, but preferentially.
8	Mouthbound. You can't lie. Your mouth won't form the words.
9	Frozen Expression. Your face doesn't move. You feel emotions normally. They just don't show.
10	Lightbleed. You bleed light instead of blood.
11	Wrong Reflection. You don't cast a reflection. Reflective surfaces show someone else. Always the same person.
12	Fire Dies. Fire goes out near you. Rooms get colder in your presence.
13	Geometric Flesh. Parts of your body form perfect geometric angles.
14	Unsinkable. You can't drown. Water treats you as surface. You also can't dive.
15	Dream Trade. You dream other people's dreams. They get yours in return.
16	Fading Ink. Writing you read fades from the page right after.
17	Fractal Iris. Your pupils are fractal patterns.
18	Shared Pain. When someone near you is injured, you feel a ghost of it. No damage, but the sensation is real.
19	Unmaker. Things you build or repair slowly unmake themselves when you stop touching them.
20	Wrong Echo. Your echo answers half a second early.
21	Flicker. You seem to flicker when you move, like a candle in a draft.
22	Boneclock. You always know the exact time and cardinal direction. You cannot become lost by nonmagical means.
23	Sealed Door. Doors you close won't open for anyone else for a few minutes.
24	Mimic. You unconsciously mirror the speech patterns and gestures of whoever you're talking to.
25	Object Reading. You can spend an hour with an object to glimpse the circumstances of its making.
26	Displaced Scars. Wounds heal where they should, but scars form somewhere else on your body.
27	Gathering Dusk. Light dims slightly in your presence.
28	Soft Edges. Your outline is slightly blurred to everyone except you.
29	Ink Eyes. Your eyes are solid black. You see fine.
30	Margin Notes. Books in your possession accumulate marginalia in your handwriting/drawing style. Some of it is quite insightful.

d100	Anomaly
31	False Ember. Your skin is uncomfortably hot to the touch. No harm done, but nobody shakes your hand twice.
32	Blank Scent. You have no smell at all.
33	Touched By Oblivion. People forget you were present shortly after you leave, unless you made a significant impact.
34	Folded Distance. A place exists that you can always walk to in exactly one hour, regardless of where you are.
35	Sound Memory. You can perfectly recall of everything you've ever heard, but visual memories blur within days.
36	Chroma Vein. Your veins glow faintly with color that shifts with your emotional state.
37	Life Drain. You sap the life from living things you touch. Plants wilt, insects still. Nothing large enough to matter.
38	Nightbloom. In darkness, faint bioluminescent patterns appear on your skin.
39	Composition Touch. You can taste what something is made of by touching it. Stone, metal, wood. You get the full composition.
40	Grounded. Your body refuses to lose contact with surfaces. You cannot jump, and where a surface exists you slide rather than walk. Open falls remain the same.
41	Dustmark. You leave a faint ashen outline wherever you sit or stand for long.
42	Trivial Oracle. You remember things that haven't happened yet, but only trivial ones.
43	Total Recall. You remember everything since the accident. Every detail, every face, every word. Nothing from before it.
44	Drifted Name. People struggle to remember your name, even those close to you.
45	Wrong Light. You appear to be lit from a different angle than everything around you.
46	Delayed Shadow. You cast two shadows. The second one belongs to about ten minutes ago.
47	Time-Slicked. Your apparent age shifts daily, though your actual body doesn't change.
48	Noodle. You can soften some/all of your bones into a jello-like material and back, allowing for some funky-looking movements.
49	Magnetic Blood. Your blood is drawn to metal. Cuts near iron pull sideways.
50	Threadbare Drift. Faint wisps trail from your skin, like smoke or fraying cloth.
51	Thought Taste. Food tastes like whatever you were thinking about when you put it in your mouth. Edible or not.
52	Unseen. Animals don't acknowledge your existence. They won't attack or flee. They also won't carry you, come when called, or warm to you.
53	Matched Surface. Your body temperature matches whatever surface you last touched.
54	Misfortune's Path. If you remain in one place too long, misfortune destroys it.
55	Wrong Growth. Your hair grows in a material that isn't hair. Copper wire, glass fiber, dried grass.
56	Shatter Echo. When struck, your body cracks like quarry stone. The sound, not the substance. Loud enough to wake a house.

d100	Anomaly
57	Small Debts. Strangers keep repaying you small sums you never lent.
58	Candlewatch. Candles you light burn for exactly one hour, then go out.
59	Remembered. People you've never met sometimes have memories of you. Childhood memories, usually.
60	Geiger Meter. Your bones vibrate faintly in proximity to rifts. Stronger vibration means closer.
61	Kin of Stone. You feel a kinship with inanimate objects and can sense when one nearby has been recently damaged or moved.
62	Pathless. You leave no trace. Footprints fill in, fingerprints fade, knots you tie come undone.
63	Disproportionate. Part of your body is out of scale with the rest. An eye, a limb, your head. Too large or too small.
64	Backward Aging. You are aging in reverse since your exposure.
65	The Door. Anywhere you sleep, you dream of the same room. If you sleep in a closed space, it always appears in the building when you wake up.
66	Glassflesh. Patches of your skin are transparent, showing muscle or bone beneath.
67	Loud Dreams. Sleeping near you gives people unusually vivid dreams.
68	Stone Sense. While touching natural stone or packed earth, you can feel movement through it. Nothing accurate enough to fight by.
69	Return Address. Things you lose eventually turn up at your childhood home. Regardless of where you lost them. Or whether the home still stands.
70	Waning Spark. Your body is partially ethereal. Physical contact with you feels wrong, like pressing into something that should be solid but gives too much.
71	Step Step. Your footsteps produce the sound of a different surface than the one you're walking on. Stone on wood, grass on marble.
72	Locked Form. Your hair, nails, and skin reset each dawn to the day of exposure. Haircuts, tattoos, and piercings don't survive the night. Wounds heal normally, the anomaly is cosmetic only.
73	Calculator. Your bruises form numbers.
74	Thing. One of your limbs occasionally acts on its own. Nothing dramatic. It reaches for things you weren't thinking about.
75	Can't Get Dirty. Nothing sticks to your skin. Mud, paint, blood. It slides right off.
76	Scripted. Text appears faintly beneath your skin.
77	Wrong Tongue. You can read and understand a language you've never encountered, but only in written form. You can't speak it.
78	Knock Knock. Every knock you make sounds twice.
79	Timeless. You have no sense of time whatsoever. A minute and an hour feel identical.
80	DJ. Your heartbeat's pace is off. It's playing a tune, or it's too fast/slow for the type of workout you're doing.
81	Foreigner. You speak with a faint accent from a language no one can place.
82	Slight Angle. Gravity pulls you at a slight angle. You've compensated. Mostly.
83	Rainbow. You see one additional color that no one else can perceive.
84	Feralskin Limb. One of your limbs has mutated into something alien.
85	Inkdrip Blood. Your blood hardens into small shapes when exposed to air.

d100	Anomaly
86	Escort. Somehow, a cat is always nearby you. Never the same cat though.
87	Anniversary. Periodically, there are days when everyone you meet is briefly certain they once attended your funeral.
88	Overheard. You sometimes hear one side of a conversation happening somewhere else.
89	Undepictable. You can't be depicted. Paintings blur, sketches smudge, verbal descriptions come out wrong.
90	Soundless. Your body doesn't produce sound. You can speak, but it takes effort.
91	Preserved. Food doesn't spoil in your keeping.
92	Borrowed Face. Your face isn't yours. You woke up one day wearing someone else's.
93	Memory Leak. People who touch you occasionally get a flash of one of your memories. You don't choose which.
94	Anchored. You cannot be teleported, planeshifted, or magically transported against your will. You also can't benefit from it willingly.
95	Oven. Your feet smell like baked bread.
96	Misplaced Gravity. Small objects near you drift slightly in your direction. Nothing useful, just annoying.
97	Loose Thread. There is a piece of string attached to you. You can pull it out or retract it, and it doesn't seem to have a length limit.
98	Living Canvas. Whatever is drawn on you moves by itself. Whether tattooed or just colored on top.
99	Feral Traits. Your body has taken on physical traits from an animal. Fur along the spine, a tail, slit pupils, scales.
100	Reroll or GM's choice.

Alteration Anomalies:

The Vigil

You do not sleep. To gain the benefits of a long rest, you spend four hours motionless and aware; you perceive your surroundings as normal during this time. Your body produces a low, constant hum, audible within 5 feet in a quiet environment. It never stops. Neither do you.

Nighteye

You have darkvision out to 120 feet, and you see in nonmagical darkness as if it were bright light. In bright light, you are blinded unless your eyes are shielded (smoked glass, a wrap, a deep hood: treat light through them as dim).

Truthscent

You know when a creature deliberately lies to you in a language you understand. Not half-truths, omissions and honest mistakes. Only a lie the speaker knows is a lie. When you catch a lie, the speaker feels that you noticed. Creatures immune to having their thoughts read are immune to this effect.

Mimic Hide

Your skin and hair take on the color and texture of surfaces you touch. While you remain motionless against a surface, you have advantage on Dexterity (Stealth) checks made to hide. The change is involuntary and lingers for about an hour.

Bedrock Ear

While you are stationary and in contact with natural stone or packed earth, you have tremorsense out to 15 feet. You've stopped mentioning the things you feel walking beneath cellars. People never take it well.

Expression Anomalies:

The Passenger

Something ancient rides along. It was here before you and expects to be here after.

Tenant. You can speak, read, and write one additional language, chosen by the GM. You also gain proficiency in History.

Counsel. Once per long rest, when you fail an Intelligence or Wisdom check, the Passenger may interject: reroll the check and take the second result. The Passenger decides what's worth its attention; if it stays silent, the use isn't spent.

The Question. Once per long rest, you can ask the GM one question the Passenger might plausibly know the answer to. It answers truthfully, in its own interest, which is not always yours.

Opinions. It has them. The GM speaks for it when he so chooses.

Vessel Drift

Objects remember. You have learned to listen, and, briefly, to sympathize.

Communion. By holding an object and concentrating for 1 minute, you learn what it is made of, roughly how old it is, and the strongest impressions it carries: something of its making, its longest keeper, the moments it would call important. These are impressions, not recordings. Some objects have preferences. You learn those too.

Drift. A number of times per long rest equal to your proficiency bonus, you can use an action to project your consciousness into a Tiny or Small object you are touching, for up to 10 minutes. You perceive your surroundings the way the object does: you have blindsight out to 30 feet centered on the object and can hear normally, and light and darkness are irrelevant to you. You cannot perceive color or read writing. Your body is incapacitated and unaware. You can return to your body at any time as a free action. If the object is destroyed while you occupy it, you return immediately and are stunned until the end of your next turn.

Known Vessels. An object you have drifted in stays familiar to you. While a known vessel is within 1 mile of you, you know its direction and distance. You can have up to a number of known vessels equal to your proficiency bonus; drifting into a new object beyond that limit releases the oldest.

Dreamside

Sleep is a place. You have learned the way in.

Crossing. Once per in-game week, you can touch a sleeping creature and enter its dream, for up to one hour or until the dreamer wakes. You can observe, converse with the dreamer, and walk through what its mind has built.

Tending. While inside, you can calm the dream. Doing so ends any effect causing the dreamer nightmares or disturbed sleep, and the dreamer remembers the dream kindly. A creature whose sleep you tend for the full rest gains temporary hit points equal to your proficiency bonus + your level when it wakes.

The Risk. Dreams do not always appreciate visitors. Damage you take inside a dream is psychic damage dealt to your body. You can leave at any time as a free action.

Lucid. You are always aware you are dreaming, in your own dreams and anyone else's, and you have advantage on saving throws against effects that target a sleeping or dreaming mind.

Tidebound

The rift fills your lungs.

Amphibious. You can breathe air and water, and you have a swimming speed equal to your walking speed.

What the Water Brought. While fully submerged, you have blindsight out to 15 feet, and you can sense the rough size and number of creatures sharing the same body of water within 100 feet of you. Still water tells you more than moving water; the GM adjudicates the difference.

The Price. You must fully immerse yourself in water at least once every 24 hours or gain one level of exhaustion that can't be removed until you do. Rivers, rain barrels, and horse troughs all count. Dignity does not.

Slipped

The world closes its hands around you and finds them empty.

Between. A number of times per long rest equal to your proficiency bonus, when you are grappled, restrained, or in a space too small for you to stand upright, you can use a bonus action to teleport up to 15 feet to an unoccupied space you can see.

Unheld. Nonmagical bindings don't keep you. Given a minute of quiet effort, you slip free of any ropes, manacles, or knots without a check. You can also squeeze through spaces as though you were one size smaller.

The Flinch. You dislike tight rooms, and it shows. This costs you nothing mechanically. Socially is another matter.

Half Here

Part of you went somewhere else. It never entirely came back.

Thin. You weigh half what you should, and physical contact with you feels wrong, like pressing into something that gives too much. A number of times per long rest equal to your proficiency bonus, when you are hit by a weapon attack, you can use your reaction to let the blow pass partway through you, gaining resistance to that attack's damage.

The Other Side. You can see 15 feet into the Ethereal Plane, and you notice invisible creatures within that range as faint displacements.

Silent Mind

The rift took sound and left something else.

Quiet. You cannot speak or hear, and you are immune to any effect that requires you to hear it. You automatically fail ability checks that rely on hearing.

Speech Without Sound. You can communicate telepathically with any creature you can see within 60 feet. A shared language is not required, though a creature with no language receives only impressions. A willing creature can respond in kind.

Present Minds. You always know the location of any creature with an Intelligence of 4 or higher within 15 feet of you, even if you can't see it. Minds are loud.

The Open Room. Once per long rest, you can cast *detect thoughts* (save DC 8 + your proficiency bonus + your Charisma modifier) without a spell slot or components.

Weightless

The earth has no claim on you.

Unburdened. You weigh nothing. You are permanently under the effect of *feather fall*, take no falling damage, and can steer while falling, moving up to 5 feet horizontally for every 10 feet you descend. Your jump distances are doubled, and you can cross snow, mud, thin ice, and brittle surfaces without breaking or marking them.

Pushover. In strong wind, you must anchor yourself to something or be moved 10 feet in its direction at the start of each of your turns, and you have disadvantage on checks and saving throws against being shoved or carried away. Wear heavy boots. It won't help much, but it's something.

The Factions of Virelia

Building a society from the refuse of the divine.

When the heavens went silent, the concept of "Divine Right" evaporated. There were no longer any gods to mandate who sat on the throne, and the blood of ancient lineages proved useless against the dissolving world. In the vacuum left by the Sundering, the survivors looked for anyone who could keep their roof from collapsing.

The entities that rose to fill this void are not defined by borders, patriotism, or culture, but by the necessities they monopolize. The **Greywater Compact** turned peace into a subscription service, enforcing law only where the ledger balances. To move gold and words across the broken lands requires paying the toll of the **Halcyon League**. Even the end of the world has been commercialized; the **Weave** sells protection from the Rifts to the highest bidder, while the **Speculars** market the ultimate luxury to those who can no longer stand the noise: a new way of life, or a sweet, blissful silence.

For the common citizen, this shift has fundamentally altered the social contract. One no longer pledges allegiance to a faction, but signs a contract with them. The relationship is pragmatic and transactional. You are safe only as long as you are solvent.

This has created a geopolitical landscape that is fluid and ruthless. A city might be geographically located in the Remosan Empire, legally contracted to the Greywater Compact for police services, and reliant on the Halcyon League for its banking. Sovereignty in Virelia is a tangled web of receipts and debts. A city might sit geographically in the Remosan empire, contract the Greywater compact for police, and bank through the Halcyons.



The Weave

"Please lower your voice. We are not a charity, sir. If you cannot afford our services, then I'm afraid I'm going to have to ask you to leave. Try the city-watch."

Hedda, receptionist, Drauheim office

The Business of Apocalypse

I can't fathom why their waiting-room chairs are so uncomfortable. Nobody wants to be in that room to begin with. The chairs feel like a second fee. Though I suppose it's consistent. Deal with rifts, take everything in return, bum comfort included. Such is the Weave, the one organization on the continent that handles rifts, a fact they know precisely down to the copper. The testimonies I've collected over the years leave little doubt about their competence, and the Weave leaves little chance of hearing about the exceptions. Whatever the success rate, most Virelians will never be able to afford them. Nearby rift or not.

Tin → Copper → Iron → Silver → Gold → Obsidian → Black

recruits → rookies → active agents → squad leads → command → high-risk specialists → off-ledger.



The Mill

The Weave has holdings in most cities. Receive customers, mobilize teams. That sort of thing. Their four main hubs are the Skyward Ledger in Eskahol, all polished mahogany and council chambers; the Knotsreach station, which does mostly research these days; Mirestead, where a man who reaches 32 is considered old; and Drauheim, which handles most of the logistics of the whole thing but isn't flashy enough for the leadership to reside in.

Funny enough, the Weave's council reminds me of the Southfield one more than anything else. A bunch of Gold-ranked agents past their prime, pulled from the field with a pat on the back after proven to have at least some basic form of common sense. The ones who don't outright refuse, that is. Plenty prefer the field and an early death to a desk. Those are the ones who turn Obsidian, eventually, if they last. The council handles what you'd expect. Hub appointments, resource allocation, the rare promotion past Gold. They negotiate with governments, which they do from the position of people who know they'll be called back regardless of how the negotiation goes. It mostly works, mainly because the people sitting on that council have all survived enough fieldwork to know what matters and what doesn't, and what doesn't is mainly politics and ego.

An Obsidian in the field will follow a directive when it suits the situation and ignore it otherwise, and the council quietly lets this happen because the alternative is not having Obsidians. With the Blacks there isn't even pretense. You can't discipline someone when the act of disciplining them requires another Black or a whole group of Obsidians. These are some of the most dangerous people on the continent and I don't say that lightly. The council posts a directive. The Black reads it or doesn't. If he does, the council mostly tries its best to stay out of his way.

Which brings me to the other end. A Tin recruit. Signs their contract without even being given entry to the hub building. The contract itself is three sentences. The recruit accepts assignment to active rift operations at their Iron's discretion, the organization's liability in case of death is limited to a one-time payment to a named beneficiary, and the probationary period ends after three successful assignments. Successful, not survived. A Tin who gets pulled out of a collapsed zone missing a leg hasn't completed the job, and has therefore failed to meet the terms of their contract.

It is a known fact, not a hidden one. But the Weave provides a scarce resource in return: an opportunity. A steady income, which can get hefty on the higher ranks. This temptation is what allows the intake desk at Drauheim to process signups the way a mill processes grain. The line moves, the pen gets handed over, the name dries on the page before it's carved onto a grave. This should tell you exactly what the organization thinks a Tin is worth, and the answer is not much. Three jobs. Maybe half make Copper. Mirestead is worse, but Mirestead is worse at everything.

If You Must

Rimilde Black started as a monster hunter, ordinary work, and somewhere along the line found she had a knack for a problem most hunters walked away from: rifts. She took the jobs alone, charged what the client could survive paying, and handled things that had standing bounties older than she was. Villages pooled harvests to bring her in. A Trefgann garrison log records the officers covering her fee out of their own wages, twice. Ottmar Helvik was chairing the Open Eye in those years, long before the guild's current Nonagon seat. His letters to her go back to 1677, 123 years ago. Rifts everywhere, with no real answer but one woman who insisted on working alone. Helvik saw this as a proof of concept, but she denied his initial proposal. He wore her down for roughly a decade. Endless letters, until she reluctantly agreed to let him form the organization around her. Then, in 1687, he finally left his seat, went to Eskahol, and built the aforementioned Skyward Ledger, the Weave's main headquarters. Once you know where he learned his trade the Weave stops being so mysterious. The catalogue, the archives, the contract language, the desks. An intelligence guild's skeleton, put to a different use. He built the only kind of institution he knew how to build, and it turned out to be a natural pairing.

Now, a correction, if you'll allow me, since common belief has it backwards. Black was never a rank Rimilde held. His original system had ranks tin through gold. Rimilde *Black* refused a rank and Helvik wrote her surname as an exemption from the ladder. Obsidian only shows up decades later, when a (loud) council meeting attempted to make the ranking system seem continuous despite the odd category. In general, my impression is that Black didn't particularly care for the whole thing. She allowed Ottmar to use her name, and even survey some of her methods, but she never bothered with what she considered to be a bureaucratic chore. Though a profitable one. His letters show a level of admiration, though whether that's romantic or professional is above my qualification. What I can confirm is that she did not seem to particularly like Ottmar. To quote one of her earlier letters: "a scrawny balding ape with more brains than smarts".

In 1714 she took a contract into the Wending and didn't come back. No body, even now. By 1719 the Weave hub at Knotsreach was constructed, officially research. Her retrieval contract is still open, since Helvik opened it himself and never signed an expiration date. At this point, him being dead and all, it's mostly for appearances. Helvik ran the company another decade and died at his desk in 1724. His old guild reached the Nonagon six years later. He never saw either institution at its full height, which I suspect would have bothered him less than we'd like to think.

The Art

What I've been able to piece together is roughly this. A crew arrives at the site. Before anyone touches anything, they spend what sounds like an unreasonable amount of time just standing around. Measuring. Walking the edges. Arguing. They're building a classification string, which I'll get to. The point is that the assessment is not preparation for the work. The assessment is the work, because what you do with a rift depends entirely on what it is, and getting that wrong is often worse than doing nothing.

A spatial rift with a clean boundary and no secondary effects might be collapsed with a correctly placed displacement device. Bag of holding, in the cruder versions, though the Weave's equipment has apparently moved past that. An anchored rift needs its anchor found and destroyed, which sounds simple until the anchor turns out to be an entire temple or somebody's baby. A rift with a cognitive layer requires the crew to work while actively doubting their own perception, which is exactly as reliable as it sounds. And the ones classified as entities, the rifts that display something like will, sometimes require what one account generously described as "negotiating". Each combination in the notation points to a different method, different equipment, different expertise. A crew trained to collapse spatial distortions is useless against a temporal loop, and sending them in anyway is how the Weave loses people. And it does. Higher ranks as well, despite what they'd want you to believe.

This is why the research apparatus exists. Not for scholarship. The Weave is not a university. But a century of fieldwork has taught them that the difference between a successful operation and a dead crew is usually a question someone answered in a library six months earlier. What does this geometry do when you apply pressure to its anchor? Has this combination of properties been documented before? What happened last time? The archive is the product as much as the fieldwork is. Every field report feeds the catalogue. Every catalogue entry makes the next crew slightly less likely to die. As I said, the man built what he knew. It turned out to be exactly what this work needed.

Expertise

I should add something to what I said about recruitment. The intake desk is the main pipeline, but it isn't the only one. The Weave actively scouts too, especially in dry spells. Prisons, orphanages, thrill seekers, border villages... anything goes.

Occasionally a Silver might spot a promising candidate in the field and send them to a hub, but these are rarer for obvious reasons. The few who are lucky enough to reach Gold and above are heavily invested in. Equipment, teachers, resources. A Silver who dies is a big loss for the Weave, and they spend a lot to prevent that from happening. They are especially known for wielding equipment made of rift-produced materials. Whatever that means. I also find that the higher-ranking agents carry themselves with this sort of... settled quality. Like someone who's made a private agreement with the concept of death. It can go many ways. Gallows humor, indifference, rigidity. Plenty of superstition as well, or so I'm told.

Anyway, they stand out. Especially Black agents. There are perhaps five or six alive at any given time, though the Weave keeps the actual number vague. From the records I've accessed I can only name one with confidence. Isi Carphine is, by every account, one of the more accomplished mages alive. Her most recent book casually suggests she learned to stop time in order to properly document a persistent temporal rift. She is described consistently as brilliant, obsessive, and entirely indifferent to anything that does not interest her, which includes most human concerns. The Weave points her at things, and she decides whether it's worth her time. That's just one.

The Price

As you can imagine, having this sort of characters, in addition to a monopoly on rift knowledge and containment, doesn't garner the Weave a lot of love. They can't be replaced, and everyone has tried. The Compact tried to tax their operations, and when that didn't work attempted to invest in their own Rift department, which famously collapsed three years down the line. Remosa issued a decree some thirty years ago requiring Weave crews to operate under military oversight, and the Weave pulled out for six weeks before the empire gave in. Even Haldrith has tried forcing the Weave to follow the guilds' protocols, and had to swallow their pride when the Weave outright refused. A Weave hub in your city means your rift problem is someone else's and your sovereignty is slightly fictional, and most governments have decided this is an acceptable trade, if occasionally a pricey one. For the commoners it's a different story. A rift opens near a farmstead, the village scrapes together what it can, the intake desk quotes the rate. If it isn't enough the messenger goes home and the rift does what rifts do.

This means agents sit in this weird spot where people either admire them, despise them, or both at the same time. A bit like how some men chase after a woman's skirt only to swear at her once she denies their advances. People need them, want to be them, and will still spit at the floor as they pass by.

Rift Taxonomy				
<i>[Grade + Primary Type + (Secondary Types) – Size + Dynamics . Properties]</i>				
3S(TC)–3VW.SA				
<i>Severe. Primarily spatial, with temporal and cognitive elements. Room-sized. Volatile, wandering. Structured, anchored.</i>				
<i>danger</i>		<i>what it distorts</i>		<i>scope</i>
				<i>how it behaves</i>
Grade	Type	Size	Dynamics	Properties
1 Negligible	B Biotic: organic growth, mutation, biological anomaly	1 A grain, a coin	V Volatile: shifting, expanding, intensifying	I Intangible: no physical manifestation
2 Hazardous	S Spatial: warped terrain, recursive geometry	2 An object, a body	W Wandering: changes location	L Latent: dormant but present
3 Severe	T Temporal: loops, lags, skips	3 A room, a corridor	R Recurrent: comes and goes	S Structured: follows clear patterns
4 Lethal	C Cognitive: perception, memory, identity, behavior	4 A building, a ship	M Mimetic: adapts to observation	A Anchored: bound to object, person, or place
5 Blacklisted	N Narrative: meaning, myth, or pattern imposing on reality	5 A field, a village	F Fading: weakening, shrinking, dissipating	C Concealed: undetectable until engaged
	P Physical: matter, light, sound, heat, weight	6 Regional; days of travel	T Triggered: activates on specific stimuli	E Entity: displays will, selfhood, or directed intent
	V Vital: life, death, or decay outside natural order	0 N/A		? Classification unconfirmed
	X Unclear or other			



Greywater Compact

“Have you gone mad? A lienhunter? Don't you dare tell that to your da. Shameful, that. Have you already forgotten what they did to aunt Kellis?”

Overheard in Crosten

Make Ends Meet

I've already spoken at length about the Compact when discussing the Rivhalde region: its history, its methods. Here I'd like to do something else. I realize I've never quite shown you what the Compact looks like from the inside. The view from outside is simple enough: tariffs, Lienhunters, permits, mundane cruelty. But institutions are more than the sum of their policies. They're the architects of these policies, the bootlickers who surround them, and the ones who show up at your door when you don't follow them successfully. In short, they're people, with all the trouble that entails.

House	Founder	Current Seat	House	Founder	Current Seat
Greywater	Orvhald	Tessmund	Breskir	Kolvund	Brenst
					
Skavorn	Braeven	Orsk	Grevaine	Orven	In arbitration
					
Hartlepp	Esketh	Dreilm	Kelharn	Draeth	Halverd
					

Soldiers of Fortune

Most Rivhaldeans end up meeting far more Lienhunters than Signatories.

Bureaucrats always have a clear preference for papers over people, so it only makes sense that this part of the work was delegated. I think Lienhunters can be split into two groups, broadly. Disciplined, and crude. Violence is expensive. Medicine isn't cheap, training replacements costs money, and a dead debtor's assets are often worth less than a cooperative one's. The smarter crews who understand this show up in numbers, break a few fingers, and leave with the goods before anyone gets brave. They get to maintain a pretense of morals through the use of intimidation, implied force, and the knowledge that the last crew to visit this village wasn't so polite. It works, but only provided that last crew actually wasn't.

Which is where our second type comes in. The threat of our first type only holds if somebody, somewhere, is making good on it. The Compact, usually, doesn't technically require violence from its contractors, nor does it forbid it. What it requires is results. Taxes paid, bounties collected. Crews that earn a reputation for brutality find that Sabots leave them alone, that doors open faster, that the technically-optional parts of the job get simpler. Crews that don't find the opposite. The system doesn't openly reward cruelty, but it does seem to nudge in that way.

It's not a clean line, of course. But you'd be surprised just how careful Lienhunters are when it comes to their reputation. The more successful crews are recognized by name: "The Blueskulls", "The Lilies", "Grizzly Rats". This is where it gets interesting, so bear with me. As I said previously, the Compact doesn't employ Lienhunters. It contracts them. A defaulted debt gets posted at the hub with the amount owed, the collection fee, and a list of the debtor's assessed assets so the crew knows what's worth taking before they saddle up. Licensed crews bid. Sometimes more than one crew bids on the same posting, which drives the fee down, which is the Compact's favorite trick applied to its own dogs.

Whoever takes it goes hunting for results. In their own communities, I should mention. The crew that shows up at your neighbor's farm grew up three villages over. Which is the sort of tragedy that only the rich can come up with. Young men and women from struggling taxed communities, choosing to cross over to the collection side for a chance to get a look at things from the outside for once. Plus, steady meals. At least until the results stop coming. A crew that misses its quota loses its tier, and a crew that loses its tier takes worse postings at worse rates until the math stops working. After that it's back to the taxed side of the ledger, which everyone in the village already knows, and nobody forgives.

How It Began

You know the story about the two chickens? How two Remosan nobles decided to solve a land dispute by a competition, in which each sent a chicken on a journey to the edge of the forest, and the first chicken to arrive safely would win its master the forest's eastern edge? The Compact's rise to power, from the inside, was a bit like that. Each merchant hired mercenaries, strategists, all in an attempt to keep their investments in the region safe. Skavorn's people guarded the granaries because Skavorn owned the granaries. Hartlepp's sellswords cleared the roads because Hartlepp collected the tolls. While the sellswords bled for Rivhalde's future, the merchants who'd hired them were watching each other. A crew that cleared a stretch of road didn't just make it safe. It made it Hartlepp's, and the families that moved slower found their neighbors had already taken the good parts. Everybody was saving their own piece of Rivhalde, and by the time they were done, they'd saved the whole thing by accident.

The bandit problem thinned out. The region settled into a quiet, undeclared anarchy where each merchant got to make his own rules in his own tiny kingdom. That lasted roughly eight years, until Orvhald Greywater got tired of paying to guard the same road three times.

The Greywaters were the most influential merchant family at the time, followed by Kelharn and Breskir. Orvhald proposed the Compact, which, in short, stated that each signatory keeps the territory it had already secured, formalized as a revenue suite: the tolls and collection rights inside it, bundled and heritable, with a Board seat attached. That all signatories adhere to a shared constitution covering maintenance of shared infrastructure: roads, patrols, Weave services, sewage. And that disputes between suites go to arbitration by the other signatories, which in practice means disputes go to whoever has the most allies on the Board.

The politics of the signing were about as generous as you'd expect. The Greywaters had spent the most and claimed the most, and after Kelharn and Breskir followed suit, nobody was in a position to argue. Their chicken had already reached the forest's edge. The signing just wrote it down. Families that had moved too slowly or hired too cheaply found themselves with minor suites and minor seats. At least two names from the original signing aren't on the current Board at all, bought out or squeezed into irrelevance within the first generation. In retrospect, the whole thing looks less like a demonstration of governance and more like a group of bandits splitting the loot.

How It Goes

Four generations on, the Greywaters are still on the Board, though some would say in name only. When Remosa's second march cut the Heartland Sea trade route, half their revenue disappeared overnight. The family never successfully pivoted, and nowadays have just enough to keep the seat and not enough to matter. Kelharn and Breskir have been quietly acquiring Greywater contracts for the better part of a decade, and the only thing preventing an outright carve-up is that neither wants the other to get the bigger piece. That, and the Compact. Hard to overtake the one whose name is stamped on the top of your government system. In general, most families' competence seems to deteriorate with each passing generation. Spoiled, prideful children, standing on the shoulders of their long gone forefathers. Rivhaldeans often show pride in their heritage. Overthrew the empire, overthrew nobility, braved the bandits. Free folk, with their own land and their own laws. Right before a signatory who never so much as touched a sickle comes to take their due. For all their contempt, Rivhalde is very much a monarchy. Try telling them that, though.



Bigger Fish

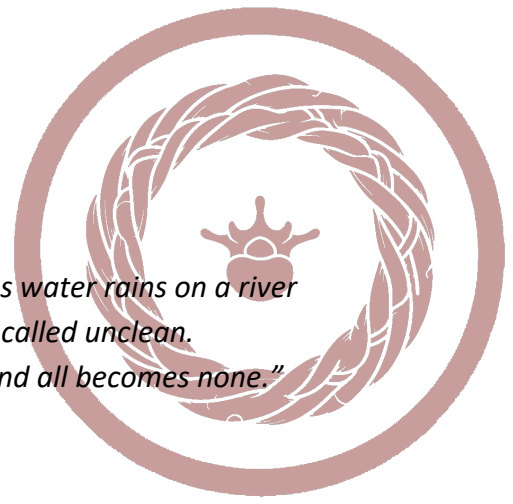
Tessmund is a riddle to me. The man is sharp. Witty, barbed, pragmatic. The letters I've read show someone who sees the Board clearly, comments on its workings with genuine intelligence, and then does nothing. He seconds Halverd's insulting proposals. He signs what Brenst puts in front of him. He attends every session, which he doesn't have to, and contributes almost nothing, which he also doesn't have to. I've considered that he might simply be lazy, but lazy men rarely leave this much paperwork behind. My best guess, and it is a guess, is that Tessmund has decided the chair is worth more occupied than fought over, and a head is worth more on a pair of shoulders. I think he realized that the moment he starts acting like the name on the charter, he becomes a problem two wealthier families will solve together instead of competing over separately.

The Board protocols from last year's winter session paint a familiar enough picture. Forty pages, eleven seats, and only the big six still bother attending in person. The minor families sent proxies, which tells you how seriously they take it. Though the six are truthfully down to five: Orsk Skavorn has sent his steward for the third session running, and nothing in the protocols suggests anyone found this worth remarking on. The steward, Feskren, voted with Halverd on everything, because everybody votes with Halverd, especially those in bed with him. The man is charming, well-liked, apparently handsome, and seemingly incapable of staying out of married couples' homes. None of which has cost him a vote yet. He delegates his suite to people who are less charming and more competent, and it works fine. He drank, and this was noted in the protocol because the Board was billed for it, eleven glasses of wine in the second session.

Brenst Breskir proposed three new acquisitions at the same session, all former Greywater contracts, and nobody objected because nobody bothers arguing when Brenst wants to buy something. The man collects as if he'll get to keep it all after he's dead: books, paintings, rings, contracts. His accountant is probably the most stressed person in Virelia, which sets quite a high bar. Between the two of them, they account for most of the Board's substance, and the protocols show no disagreement on anything that mattered. Drelm Hartlepp showed up, spoke once about a road in his suite, and left before the session ended. This is governance in Rivhalde. What baffles me is that it works. Not the Board. The Board is a circus of inheritance and appetite. But somewhere between Halverd's wine bill and Brenst's latest acquisition, a layer of assessors and clerks translates all of it into a tax system more sophisticated than anything I've seen outside an imperial capital. The roads stay paved. The grain moves. The Weave gets paid. I keep looking for the part where the rot at the top should have ruined the machinery underneath, and it's there if you look closely, but somehow stays hidden if you only slightly avert your gaze.

The Zwigots

“Receive him, for he is neither stranger nor guest. He comes as water rains on a river from which it first came. Let him return. Let nothing of him be called unclean. Consume him slowly, savor every bite. Until one becomes all and all becomes none.”



Zwigoti prayer for the departed

Due Disclosure

I've made arrangements for my burial, and a Zwigot will not be handling it. I want that said before I write anything else about them, because the rest of this chapter is going to sound more generous than I feel, and I'd rather not be mistaken for a sympathiser. The largest religious movement on the continent, present in most cities, uncontested everywhere except Lastrago, which I'll get to later. It would seem that, gods or not, people have to believe in something, and on a continent with this much rot, it only makes sense that somebody would build a religion around it. Prophet Beltzu did, and fourteen centuries later his monks handle the dead in villages that couldn't name a single line from his book. How disappointing. How practical.

More Cults

Beltzu was a Mazuren priest, ordained in the year 342, some 1458 years ago. And like the other priests, he was a Karex, taken from his family in Naktzu to be strapped to a spire in Azwighen. Before that it's the usual ladder: years of tutelage underground tasting water out of stone pools. And then work. He was rather successful for about a decade or so. Not in an extraordinary kind of way, but well enough to make a name for himself. However, in 351 he read an entire season wrong. Three readings one after another, resulting in a documented total of 169 people missing or dead. He was offered the spire a second time, and chose exile instead. He then marched west onto Trefgann, and that's where the temple's account of him ends.

What remains from his later endeavors survived through the Tzikhari. A few hundred sayings, most of them shorter than this sentence, collected by people who'd heard them secondhand and written down well after he was dead. No biography in it. No argument either, which irritates me to no end. You've already bothered to write it all down, might as well take the extra step and leave a paragraph where he explains his own words. Instead we're left with these maxims, followed by fourteen centuries of monks arguing. Novices memorize the whole collection while they're young, and spend the rest of their life disagreeing about it with whoever sits across the table. An obvious influence from the Mazuren. Priests were publicly disputing forecasts long before Beltzu was born, and we can safely assume the habit travelled west alongside him.

Words And Their Meanings

Fittingly, as the prophet's original intentions eroded, so did the name. Zwigot, or Tzigot in the oldest of sources. Then Zhigot by the time Remosan clerks had to file it, and lastly: our very own Zwigot, which is a word in no language anyone has been able to point me at. Experts in ancient Lastragan claim the original meant something close to "not fearful," but I'm afraid I can't confirm that with any confidence.

The Tzikhari has gone through many translations, which eroded the enigmatic original even more. I'll give you an example. "Chabol zeb komak tzi-ot", commonly translated: "eat what is put in front of you". But this is merely one interpretation. *Komak* also means sits. Stays. Remains. You see, several ways to translate, and then several more to interpret each translation. "Chabol zeb komak tzi-ot". Four words, and they can't even agree whether it's about food. One reads: the thing is there, you eat it, and the eating is the whole of the acceptance. Another takes it nearer to remains, as in leftovers, as in what the world has already finished with, and that's the reading that ends with a monk face down in mud and human flesh. The third holds that the sentence is about food and nothing else, and is popular among parents who wish their kids would eat more turnip. Underneath all three sits the same core claim. There is one substance. Not gods, not laws. One substance, and everything is it. To the Zwigot mind, the Sundering didn't split the world, and the world is not, in fact, being broken apart. Because one substance can't be broken down into anything but the same substance. A rift is the world doing what the world does: recycling. So is rot, and so is the child whose shadow walks off on its own. The only thing that has actually happened in eighteen centuries is that people insisted on struggling against the obvious, clinging to a world that only wants to be remade.

Which brings us back to Lastrago, since I said I would. The Mazuren looked at the same sky and built an apparatus for getting out from under it. A priesthood whose entire function is telling you when it's time to leave. Beltzu's answer to the same phenomenon was that running is wrong. People, like the Mazuren themselves, ought to accept the Mazurat. Death and all. You can see why Azwighen preferred him elsewhere. Two religions out of one storm, and fourteen centuries on they're still the only declared two on this continent.



Monks And Priests

I've mentioned that Beltzu chose exile over a second drowning. An important caveat to that is that this is the Mazuren version of events, and also the widely accepted one. The Zwigots think differently. In one of their better known legends, Beltzu never made an incorrect reading, and was scorned by the Mazuren for his success, and for gathering a following that contradicted their teachings. So they put him to the drowning meaning to kill him, and he survived it. They did it again, and again, for a year, before accepting that the man was beyond death and exiling him instead, before he could be taken for a martyr. It's the same trick every priesthood pulls on its founder's worst day, and I'd have more patience for it if the Mazuren version didn't have 169 names attached. Which leads me to an obvious point. The two religions don't get along. Who would have thought.

Zwigots are banned from entering Lastrago, and I can't tell you when that started. The temple records treat the prohibition as something that was always true, which in my experience means somebody lost an argument nobody wanted written down. Anyway. A Zwigot found in a Lastragan village is most likely beaten to death, and then hanged regardless. There are more such cases than I care to list. And should one reach Mazuren hands, as a mockery of their legend, they'll be put to the spire repeatedly until they perish. What's amusing about the whole thing is that the Zwigots believe this to be a great honor. Retelling the story, becoming one with nature, that sort of thing. Every year some make the journey in hiding, only to reveal themselves to the priests in order to go through the ceremony. Their brethren will then call them saints. I'd use a different word.



Ashes To Ashes

I'd be surprised if one villager in a thousand could tell you a line from the Tzikhari beyond the ones that have turned into proverbs. It boggles my mind how people just accept the monks on face value: weddings, funerals... Especially funerals. The obvious reason, as always, is practical. Nobody wants to handle a body that sat outside for three days during summer. And here comes one who would not only do that, but would also only charge you just enough to cover the pyre and a meal or two. But still, the commoners seem so eager to declare one a holy man. Smear your face with the ashes of the dead, maybe eat some if you're a traditionalist, and there you go - thou art sacred. At least the same can't be said about my peers, thank fuck. Most academics see the Zwigots for what they are. A death cult. A popular and widely accepted one, but a death cult nonetheless. Their ceremonies are proof enough. While they claim all matter is the same, they seem to revere only the type which disgusts everyone else. They'd claim it is a demonstration of faith, but I see it for what it is. Showmanship. An attempt to convince the gullible that there is more to them than meets the eye.

A combination of all the above is how they spread. What started as a single temple in Imellah, on the outskirts of Trefgann, spread to the whole region within two generations. The centuries between that and now are harder to trace. Nobody thought to document a religion that was mostly tolerated and occasionally useful, and by the time anyone noticed it warranted a chapter, the temples were already everywhere. Lastrago excluded. Governments tolerate their oddities for their free services, and for giving the masses' heads something to play around with which isn't their mandate. The temples are mostly self sufficient: gardening, cooking. It's a simple lifestyle. They spend most of their time copying books, arguing over the Tzikhari, meditating, and occasionally ceremonial work for the locals. They barely mingle. People are impressed with a monk who's willing to wear their aunt's ashes on their face, but they wouldn't exactly invite him to dinner. They're still expanding despite that, mostly due to their policy of acceptance. Orphans, Karex, the poor, whoever nobody else wanted. People leave them at the temple door knowing they'll be taken care of for life. The children learn Old Lastragan before common, in some cases, and are given Lastragan names. They are then expected to recite the Tzikhari by heart. Fail to do so, and you'll be thrown out eventually, which is exactly why most succeed. The banished are left with no trade, no connections, not even a name.

Modern Lastrago considers the old tongue dead, but the Zwigots speak it freely. I can't read it myself, which is worth admitting, because it means every Tzikhari translation I've complained about in these pages was made by outsiders working from whatever leaked out of the houses over the centuries. Which reminds me, Beltzu ends in -u, which is a woman's ending in Old Lastragan. Nobody I've asked has had an explanation, but I do think it's worth pointing out. The monks have argued about this to no end, but in neither of their conclusions is he a woman.

Lost And Found

The Zwigots say Beltzu kept walking west all the way to Knotsreach, and into the Wending, where he is still alive, frozen in meditation, with his tomb built around him. Which, assuming it's real, is what the grand temple of Tzubilek was built around. Conveniently, nobody outside the order has ever seen the place. It is the seat of the Mukek, "The Caretaker," and reaching it is the doctrine made literal. You walk into the Wending and "Tobol kan, motol ot" - trust the path to deliver you. When a Mukek dies, the senior houses each send a candidate, and the first to arrive at Tzubilek is declared the next one. A test of faith. To my eyes, the Wending has no opinion on theology, but I don't make the rules, so here we are.

The current Mukek is Chimek, who has been at Tzubilek for some forty years with a handful of monks who made the walk alongside him. His rulings on the Tzikhari have a reputation I can't personally verify, but the abbots I've pressed on the matter were respectful in a way that suggests he amounts to more than his title. He settles disputed readings, rules on the correct form for ceremonies, and decides what counts as heresy. He is also dying. I have this from three separate sources in Luznica, though none of them seemed particularly interested in discussing what comes next.

Which brings me to Luznica, where the senior abbot of the local house serves as Ozbekem, "the one who reads on behalf of." In practice, this means he opens Chimek's correspondence, receives visiting abbots, certifies new houses, and relays the Mukek's rulings whenever they make it out of the Wending. The mundane stuff, in short. The current Ozbekem is Kanteb, who has held the position for about fifteen years, and who has spent most of those fifteen years answering questions that should be going to Chimek. Not out of ambition. Oh no, he wouldn't dare. But only because a letter to Tzubilek takes weeks and a ruling takes longer, and the abbot standing in front of Kanteb's desk needs an answer before his village buries someone wrong. So Kanteb answers, carefully, always noting that the Mukek may rule differently. The Mukek rarely does, partly because Kanteb is cautious enough to stay within safe readings, and partly because for all I know he might as well be dead.

Kanteb doesn't touch political matters, and Chimek can't, and between the two of them the religion has no position on anything outside the Tzikhari. This has suited everyone for fourteen centuries. What concerns me is arithmetic. The largest religious movement on the continent, present in most villages, handling every birth and death and wedding that matters to ordinary people, and the only thing keeping it out of politics is a dying man in a forest and a cautious abbot who knows better. Chimek's successor will be chosen by the Wending, and the Wending will produce a scholar. But the next Ozbekem is just an appointment, and there is nothing in the structure preventing an abbot with ambitions from taking that desk in Luznica and deciding the correspondence is worth answering. Danilo Pescarin was a Remosan nobleman last year. He's an abbot now. Anyway, when that finally happens, and I'd bet my library that it will in the coming decade, the Zwigots won't be entering politics. They'll be discovering they were already in it.

Rebirth

The Midwives are harder to talk about, mostly because nobody in the houses wants to talk about them. If the world is one substance remaking itself, and the correct response is acceptance, then the question somebody was always going to ask is why stop at acceptance. A rift recycles. The Green Wall holds back the Mire. One of these, according to the doctrine, is interference. The Midwives want to correct that.

Their literature circulates inside the houses the way these things always do. Copied pages tucked into commentaries, citations disguised as orthodox disputation, arguments that read as hypothetical until you notice they aren't. I've seen one piece, a six-page tract in translation, and the theology is sound enough that I understood immediately why the Mukek banned it. It doesn't contradict the Tzikhari. It extends it. The difference between eating a corpse and dismantling the Green Wall, according to the author, is squeamishness, not principle. The mainstream position is that one is acceptance and the other is interference, and the tract asks, politely and at length, where exactly the boundary sits.

The worst incident I'm aware of was in Ezgarin, 1784. Three monks arrested inside the Green Wall buffer zone by an Iron Perimeter patrol. What they were doing there the Remosan report doesn't specify, though the location speaks clearly enough. Two were hanged. The third, a woman named Idra Chenne, was not recovered. The disavowal from Luznica arrived within the month. One page. Kanteb's predecessor, presumably, though it isn't signed. The Zwigot position, it argues, is that there is no self apart from the substance. A monk eating a corpse is not doing something to the world. He is the world, consuming itself. The Midwives, the moment they decided the Green Wall should come down, placed themselves outside the process. An agent, acting on the substance, directing it. Which is the Mazuren error rebuilt from the other end. The priests flee the storm. The Zwigots withstand it. *Tobol kan, motol ot.* That's what the page says. What it doesn't say is that the Zwigots survive on tolerance, and that a religion associated with sabotage and dead Weave agents would not survive very long at all.

The Mukek declared the Midwives heretical, and the houses strip the name from any monk found distributing the literature. This has not, as far as I can tell, done much. The arguments still circulate, probably because a disputation-based religion has a very hard time telling its monks to stop thinking about something.

Ancient Lastragan

Pronunciation

Tz as in "cats" Ch hard, as in "check" X "sh" (Nabixa = nah-BEE-sha) Stress penultimate

Names

	Rule	Endings	Examples
Men	End closed, on a hard consonant	-k, -tz, -m, -b, -t, -n	Chimek, Kanteb, Beltzu, Tzamun
Women	End open. Ix- prefix = "she of"	-ila, -ia, -ixa, -u, -ti, -ala	Nabixa, Ixkani, Tzinat, Kolti
Surnames	Places, not fathers. Monks give these up.	-ec, -ek, -an, -et, -tek	Choltunec, Balamtek, Ozbekan

Names are modular: root + ending. Two syllables is common, three is formal. It should sound like a rock hitting another rock.

Vocabulary

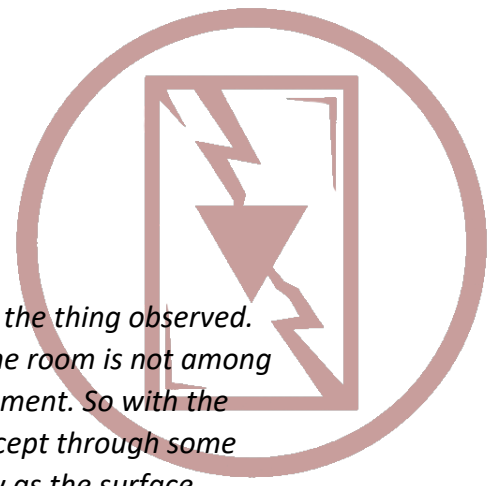
nal	water		chab	eat, consume		tol	all, whole
mazur	storm		oz	eye, to read		cha	other, different
kotz	fall, cascade		muk	hand, to hold		tobol	to trust
chol	ground		tzu	blood, to flow		motol	to deliver
kob	tree, wood		zeb	grain, food		tza	fire, heat
kom	sit, remain		nak	stone; that		aktun	cave, shelter

Word order: verb first, then subject, then object. Subject drops when obvious from context.

From the Tzikhari

<i>Chabol zeb komak tzi-ot.</i>	Eat food sits before-you
<i>Tobol kan, motol ot.</i>	Trust path, deliver you
<i>Nak chi, nak bal. Komak tzo.</i>	Stone small, stone strong. Remains this.
<i>Tol komak tol. Nol cha.</i>	All remains all. Nothing other.

The Speculars



That which observes is, by the act of observation, excluded from the thing observed. A mind within a room perceives not the room but its contents; the room is not among the things it contains, being rather the condition of their containment. So with the eye, which is no part of anything it sees. Nothing is perceived except through some instrument, and no instrument delivers the thing as it is, but only as the surface receives it. To look outward is to be stopped by one's own surface.

Veritas Audax, page 384

Philosophizing:

I've always found it odd that, for all their notoriety, the Speculars' doctrine is so exposed, so public. Most shadow groups, cults and the like, work the other way around: a warm welcome at the door, and the dogma kept for those in too deep to walk out. Here the doctrine is the door. The core texts are easy enough to find, for something so widely banned. The services are known to all, and so are the risks. And yet the fascination persists, which makes sense, I guess, once you realize that it survives on people not reading the literature. Nothing undermines the mystique of tampering with minds quite like six hundred pages of perception theory.

It is difficult to discuss philosophy plainly, and the Specular point of view, by their own account, is a philosophy. By others', a dangerous occult fascination. Either way, I intend to give it a fair presentation, if only because my safety might otherwise be put into question. Which, I might add, does not help their case. And should a Specular come across this and find my conclusions unkind, well. Luckily, this book is written anonymously.



The Doctrine:

The Speculars believe that Virelia doesn't really exist, or that, at the very least, there's a more complete world beyond it, hidden from our eyes. If you're unenthusiastic about theory, feel free to move on now. You got the gist. But for those looking to truly dig in, let's.

The Veritas Audax is the closest thing the movement has to a foundational text. Six hundred pages. Either uninviting or uncompromising, depends on who you ask. The main argument is about perception. We observe through instruments. Eyes, ears... Each one delivers a processed version of whatever it encountered, and what the mind receives is the processed version, not the thing. Standard philosophy so far. But Veritas Audax refuses to stop there. If every instrument distorts, and instruments are all we have, the claim that Virelia is as it appears rests on nothing we can verify. You'd need an unmediated observation to check, which is a contradiction. They call this the Closed Room. The Audax spends its second half arguing that something exists outside it, and they claim evidence for it can be found all over the place in Virelia: Rifts. Things which exist beyond our world, and are only hinted at through fractures in ours. They call it the Mirror Realm. The name predates the book. I've seen it in confiscated letters at least a century older. It is a bit misleading, as they don't mean an actual place. They mean everything. The full version of whatever Virelia is a partial impression of. The term is unhelpful and the Speculars know it, but nine centuries of convention are apparently harder to overturn than reality itself.

Contact with the Mirror Realm, assuming it exists, creates an obvious problem. The "instrument" wasn't built for it. What happens when unprocessed information reaches a mind that has no way to contain it isn't theoretical, nor is it pretty. The Weave's case files are full of people who survived rift exposure and came out perceiving things no one should be able to. Time as a visible surface. Spatial relationships that disagree with themselves... the usual oddities. What the Weave treats as cognitive damage, the Speculars treat as proof. A problem to be solved. A brief, involuntary glimpse of what's outside the room, received by an eye that was never meant to look at it. This, partly, is what inspired the current iteration of Specular philosophy.

As if it wasn't enough for the Speculars to argue with everyone else, three schools of thought have emerged from the question. Which now allow the Speculars to argue with each other as well. To bloody results, occasionally. I'll go over all three: Fragmentists, Amalgamists and lastly, Inverters.

The Three Schools

The Fragmentists are the most widespread, which probably stems from it being the easiest school to grasp. The mind, in their view, is the distortion. All of it amounts to scratches on the lens. Their solution is removal. Subtract the person, and what remains is a surface capable of receiving the Real without imposing itself on the signal. In practice this means the underground Glaskatch shard trade, and a lot of it. A childhood memory goes first, maybe. Then a fear. Then something larger. The end-goal is a mind smooth enough that there's nothing left to interfere with reception. I've read accounts of senior Fragmentists who can't hold a conversation. There isn't enough of themselves to participate, and they end up reflecting whoever's in front of them instead. Mannerisms, speech. A Fragmentist would tell you this isn't emptiness, but a pure self. I am not sure I agree, and in any case, they'll have to stand in line with the Tavernashi to have that argument. They made it long before the Speculars took it out of their book, after all.

The Amalgamists start from the opposite end. The mind is fine. The body is the problem. A human brain was built to process a limited reality, and no amount of philosophical trimming will change the physical constraints of the organ. You don't fix the lens. You build a new one. Their laboratories are the reason most people think of the Speculars as monsters rather than philosophers, and I can't say the reputation is unearned. Consciousness transfer. Hybrid bodies. States that sit in the gaps between alive and dead. Duskwalkers interest them particularly, since the condition already demonstrates that a soul can operate inside a vessel without the limitations that come with a living body. I've mentioned elsewhere in this book that a Specular cell with the right materials can force the Duskwalker condition. Well, these are the ones.

The Inverters are more rare, and are harder to explain, which I suspect they would take as a compliment. Their claim is that the problem is already solved. Your reflection already sees the Real. It was made on the other side of the boundary and has always been there. The work, then, is not construction or subtraction but contact. And eventually, perhaps, exchange. Their reflection, to them, is a person. Someone they've studied all their lives and never met. The resulting relationship is, predictably, complicated. Add to that their obsession with symmetry, and you get what I consider to be the strangest of the bunch. Some of their members even pursue bodily symmetry through surgery, since a perfectly symmetric body is identical to its own reflection. I'd call it excessive but at this point it seems almost mild.

Inverter cells spend a great deal of time with mirrors. Attempting to justify the name, perhaps. Trance states, prolonged gazing, years of practice aimed at communication with whatever looks back. They also closely study the ethereal, and the more powerful ones are rumored to even dabble with inter-dimensional travel. Though how much of that is public relations is anyone's guess.

What Follows An Idiot

The Veritas Audax was written around 300. The author is unknown to us. It was found in 712 in a pre-Mazur temple on the outskirts of Lastrago by a Remosan academic expedition that was cataloguing religious sites. For the first 143 years it mostly gathered dust in Urik-Van's historical collection, and in the very few times it was read, it was seen as what it is: epistemology. Very, very long epistemology. Then, in the year 855, it was stolen, and the three guards who were on watch duty at the time disappeared with no trace. Then, and only then, people noticed. While the book was, and still is, missing, a local scribe had been copying it, and got as far as page 600. The sort of drama that gets attention outside of scholarly circles alone, and that granted the surviving pages their allure. The Speculars, of all people, ought to appreciate the irony: their foundational text is itself a fragment, and nobody knows what comes after.

What began as a modest crowd of occultists and enthusiasts expanded rapidly with the appearance of Godrick Ferass. A Haldrithian guild-trained arcanist who was expelled from the Black Hands around 930 for pursuing research the guild didn't approve of. I've pieced together what I can of the man from secondhand sources, and the picture I get is less of a genius and more of a particular kind of failure. Smart enough to follow the Audax's argument, vain enough to test it, and stupid enough to do so badly. However, people do like their self-proclaimed geniuses. And so he gathered followers, gave the movement its name and its vocabulary, and established the Speculars as they are today. No headquarters, no hierarchy, nothing but the name, really. Ferass didn't trust institutions, having been spat out by one, and the movement he built reflects that bitterness down to its bones. How he died is the kind of question that reveals more about the person answering it than the subject. The Speculars will tell you he completed the work. He stepped through. The one account I find more convincing, though it's unverified, describes a man who had lost his mind entirely by the end, and was strangled with a pillow by one of his own followers. We do have verified accounts of the abuse his followers went through, so I find myself hoping it's the latter. The cult moved often enough that even his burial site is uncertain. Or hidden, whichever narrative you prefer.

For the next four centuries the movement spread. Cells appeared in most cities at one point or another, small enough to avoid attention, persistent enough to survive the occasional raid. The three schools formed during this period, though the exact dates are unclear and the Speculars themselves can't agree on who formalized what. The Fragmentists are the oldest branch, or claim to be. The Amalgamists likely emerged later, once the Glaskatch shard trade gave them the tools they needed. The Inverters were always small, always strange, and always insistent that they were the original interpretation and everyone else had strayed. I'll leave them to their argument.

Notoriety

The event that turned the Speculars from a nuisance into a genuine threat was the Tintbent plot of 1397. An Inverter cell led by one Thorro Rent, operating from somewhere in the Tintbent interior, attempted to collapse a section of the mountain range separating the Tintbent peninsula from the continent. The intention, as best anyone has reconstructed it, was to let the anomaly spread. Trefganni border patrols intercepted the cell before the attempt could be carried out. The trial was brief. The executions were public. Within a decade, most jurisdictions had issued standing orders against Specular cells.

And the bans did what they always do: spread the word. Turn the odd niche into an exciting trend. As was later proved by the Cantemir affair of 1723. Ciprian Cantemir, youngest son of one of Remosa's established noble houses, was replaced at age fifteen by a common-born Specular named Drazho Morarin. A craft-class kid from Netford who wanted a warm bed and a life where people used his name with respect. The real Ciprian's identity was stripped and bound into an object using what we'd now call Doppler technique. His body was found in a storage cellar, weeks later, breathing and responding to nothing. Drazho lived as Ciprian for three years. Attended court. Signed papers. Married a girl. The wife noticed first, told her sister, the sister told a priest. Eventually the rumor got to the boy's family. Drazho, when confronted, couldn't say where the object containing Ciprian had gone. He'd had the memory of the procedure blanked afterward. A safety measure. The real Ciprian was never recovered. Drazho was executed in 1727. The Cantemir family pushed Remosa to issue a kill-order specifically targeting Speculars, which was granted, and which has accomplished exactly the results you'd expect.



Mirror Arcana

The Speculars coined the term "Mirror Arcana" for their practice, and have declared it a newfound school of magic. Whether it is one is among the longest standing arguments in arcane research, and I will certainly not be the one to solve it here. I've spoken to colleagues on opposing sides of the debate in an attempt to explain it properly, and each agreed that my account is skewed toward the other's position. I take this as the closest thing my field has to peer review.

The traditionalists claim that every spell the Speculars associate with Mirror Arcana can be explained through an existing school. Be it conjuration, alteration, or otherwise. The Speculars, on the other hand, think spellcasters have been utilizing the Mirror Realm all along without realizing it, and have since expanded on what they perceive to be an archaic use of misunderstood principles. Misty Step, for example, or any displacement magic, is widely considered a Conjuration spell. To their eyes, however, since nothing was in fact conjured, none of the accepted schools account for what really occurred. The caster, in their view, passed through the Mirror Realm. Which connects all points in Virelia the way a surface connects the things reflected on it. The caster moved. But the space he moved through was not our own.

From there the argument extends. If things are already connected through a shared reflective space, then new connections can be established between them, and old ones can be severed. What constitutes a thing's reflection is, in the Specular view, not fixed. Move one, the other follows. Damage one, the other carries the wound. The connection holds until severed or until it breaks down on its own, which it does, and which the Speculars are less eager to discuss.

Most of what people actually encounter the Speculars doing follows from these two ideas. Broadly: displacement, mainly through reflective surfaces, transfer of properties between linked objects, or the severing of such connections. Between a person and their own memories, being the most famous example. The Speculars consider all of these the same discipline. Whether or not they're right, the results are real enough, and that's what tends to draw attention.

The discipline is considered volatile and highly experimental, though dangers to casters are nothing new. A failed mirror spell can drive a man mad, but so can a failed illusion. It can leave him cut in half between two places, and evocation has produced messier halves. On that count alone, no one would have bothered banning it. What distinguishes Mirror Arcana is that, if the Specular hypothesis is true, the practice doesn't merely endanger its practitioner. It strains the same boundaries the Rifts have already fractured, and could deepen them, or open new ones. Hence the ban, in every jurisdiction I'm aware of. What I find amusing is that the consensus holds Mirror Arcana to be wrong about everything, and yet it is banned as if it is not. This is not how a convinced academic community operates.

To Them The Streets

Officials tend to describe the Speculars the same way: inhumane, reckless. No place in civilized society. They do so right up until they have to pay a cell to erase a gambling debt from their wife's memory. And continue to do so afterwards. This is how the Speculars survive. Not through cunning or secrecy, though some cells have plenty of both, but because the people responsible for destroying them keep finding reasons not to do it completely.

Practitioners organize into what official jargon calls cells. Three people in an abandoned house with a crate of shards, a funded operation behind a legitimate front, or a herbalist in a village nobody cares about. Ferass' distrust of structured systems, or lack of foresight, turned out to be their greatest asset. You can't dismantle a structure that was never built, and certainly not when everyone meant to be fighting it seems to be paying it out of pocket. Wealthy families, guild officers... Even when they don't seek the Speculars out, many pay a retainer for the guarantee that the service exists when a rival's judgment needs quiet altering, or a problem needs to go away without leaving a document trail. It's pragmatic, cynical, short-sighted and selfish. Politics, in short.

In fairness, most of what they sell is small. A memory shed here, a fear excised there, the client usually being the merchandise's original owner. Work on the scale of the Cantemir affair is rare, and treated as a line even inside the movement. What a line is worth to people who erase things for a living, I leave to the reader.

Recruitment, supposedly, is handled through the Rite of the Glass. A ceremony repeated in occult circles enough times that it bled into general knowledge. Supposedly, to emphasize again: stare into a mirror for twenty-four hours without food, speech, or looking away, and "they" will find you. I half believe it. It has the theatrical self-seriousness of Inverter practice, and the few accounts I've found do involve mirror-focused cells. But given how decentralized the whole affair is, I don't see how the logistics work out. A specific cell's gimmick, perhaps. Who knows. Most recruits arrive by duller roads. Sanatoriums, universities, occult circles, mean-looking alehouses. And the margins of Glaskatch, of course, where someone buying Static shards, the clouded dregs of the memory trade, has probably already accepted half of what they teach in the introductory courses. Speculars don't advertise, unless you count the atrocities, which, to be fair, seem to draw attention very effectively. The ban, the mystique, and general desperation with the state of things do the rest.

VIP

In this day and age I don't believe the Speculars have a defined leadership. But I'll name some of the more influential living practitioners, both to paint a picture and because these are genuinely interesting specimens. One name I keep encountering, and probably the closest thing the movement has to a leader, is Einar. No family name. He is said to have lived for several centuries by moving between bodies, and the documentation is more plausible than I'd like. Someone operating under that name has been connected to shard and erasure operations in at least four regions across 167 years. Either the man has been swapping vessels for longer than most institutions have existed, or the name is passed along with the operation. An Inverter by inclination and a merchant by practice. His network, if it is one man's network, is the largest Specular operation I'm aware of, and it sells forgetting. Espionage and assassination appear in the margins of his file as well. That's all I have on him, unfortunately.

Then there's Noella Dyann, "Nenne". An Amalgamist, and a beloved figure in Specular circles. She is, by every account, motherly, pleasant, patient and deeply knowledgeable. The type who makes a lot of tea and remembers her assistants' birthdays. She is also, to my knowledge, the only active researcher systematically studying souls. Her position is that the Fragmentists are chasing the wrong target. Subtract personality all you like, the soul persists, still imposing its limits on perception. The soul is the barrier, and she means to prove it. I've read some of her published work. Fascinating stuff. What the research looks like in practice is, unfortunately, gruesome. Her hypothesis also creates a genuine problem for the movement, because if she's right, everything the Fragmentists have done to themselves amounts to pointless mutilation. The Fragmentists, for their part, have not slowed down. If anything, the prospect of proving her wrong has given them a second wind.



Mirror School Spells

Level	Name	Academic School (disputed)	Casting Time	Range	Duration	Concentration
Cantrip	Minor Binding	Transmutation	1 action	30 ft	1 min	Yes
Cantrip	Reflection	Divination	1 action	Touch	Instantaneous	No
Cantrip	Tether	Divination	1 action	Touch	10 min	Yes
1st	Exchange	Conjuration	1 action	30 ft	Instantaneous	No
2nd	Yank	Transmutation	1 action	60 ft	Instantaneous	No
2nd	Flesh Link	Necromancy	1 action	60 ft	1 min	Yes
2nd	Mirror Ward	Abjuration	1 reaction	Self	Instantaneous	No
3rd	Binding	Transmutation	1 action	60 ft	1 min	Yes
3rd	Sever	Abjuration	1 action	Touch	Instantaneous	No
3rd	Prism Shell	Abjuration	1 action	Self	1 min	Yes
4th	Mirror Scry	Divination	10 min	Touch / Unlimited	Instant / 10 min	Yes (Observe)
5th	Glasswalk	Conjuration	1 action	10 ft	1 round	No
5th	Unsynchronize	Enchantment	1 minute	Touch	Instantaneous	No
5th	Major Binding	Transmutation	1 action	60 ft	1 min	Yes
6th	Mirror Prison	Conjuration	1 action	60 ft	1 hour	Yes
7th	Doppler	Enchantment	1 hour	Touch	Until dispelled	No
8th	Refraction	Transmutation	1 action	120 ft	1 min	Yes
9th	Inversion	—	1 minute	Self	Instantaneous	No

Cantrips

Minor Binding

Cantrip, transmutation

Casting Time: 1 action **Range:** 30 feet

Components: S, M (two objects of similar nature)

Duration: Concentration, up to 1 minute

You create a link between two Tiny objects you can see within range. For the duration, when you use your action to move one object up to 15 feet, the other moves the same distance in the same direction, provided it is not held or worn by a creature and its path is not blocked by a solid surface. If the second object's path is blocked, it stops and the binding ends.

The objects must share some degree of similarity (two stones, two coins, two pieces of wood). The GM determines whether the objects are sufficiently similar.

Reflection

Cantrip, divination

Casting Time: 1 action **Range:** Touch **Components:** S **Duration:** Instantaneous

You touch a reflective surface (a mirror, still water, polished metal) and receive a single still image of something the surface reflected within the last 5 hours, at a moment of the GM's choosing. Repeated castings on the same surface return the same image until the surface reflects something new. The image is visual, with no detail finer than what a person standing before the surface would have seen. Magical disguises and illusions appear as they did to the surface at the time.

Tether

Cantrip, divination

Casting Time: 1 action **Range:** Touch

Components: S, M (a piece of the target, such as a hair, splinter, or fragment, which the spell consumes)

Duration: Concentration, up to 10 minutes

You touch a creature or object and establish a faint link. For the duration, you know the direction to the target, provided it is on the same plane of existence and within 120 feet of you. If the target moves beyond 120 feet, you know the direction it was last in before leaving range, but receive no further updates until it returns.

1st Level

Exchange

1st-level, conjuration

Casting Time: 1 action

Range: 30 feet

Components: V, S

Duration: Instantaneous

You and one willing creature you can see within range instantly swap positions. Each of you appears in the space the other occupied. Neither movement provokes opportunity attacks.

If either destination space cannot hold its new occupant, the spell fails and the slot is not expended.

2nd Level

Yank

2nd-level, transmutation

Casting Time: 1 action

Range: 60 feet

Components: V, S, M (a small hook or bent nail)

Duration: Instantaneous

You establish a momentary binding between yourself and a creature you can see within range, then wrench the connection. The target must make a Strength saving throw. On a failure, the target is pulled up to 30 feet in a straight line toward you. If the target strikes a solid surface or creature during this movement, the movement stops and both the target and whatever it struck take 3d6 bludgeoning damage. On a success, the target is pulled up to 10 feet and takes no damage.

This movement does not provoke opportunity attacks.

At Higher Levels. When you cast this spell using a spell slot of 3rd level or higher, the pull distance increases by 10 feet and the collision damage increases by 1d6 for each slot level above 2nd.

Flesh Link

2nd-level, necromancy

Casting Time: 1 action

Range: 60 feet

Components: V, S, M (a strand of sinew or gut, tied in a knot)

Duration: Concentration, up to 1 minute

You forge a link between two creatures you can see within range. Each unwilling creature can make a Constitution saving throw to resist the binding. If either target succeeds, the spell fails.

For the duration, whenever one linked creature takes damage from a single source (an attack, a spell, a fall), you can use your reaction to force the other linked creature to take necrotic damage equal to half the damage the first creature took, after any resistances or reductions are applied. Damage transferred by this spell does not trigger further transfers. If an effect damages both linked creatures simultaneously (such as an area spell covering both), no transfer occurs.

At Higher Levels. When you cast this spell using a spell slot of 4th level or higher, you no longer need to use your reaction to trigger the transfer. It occurs automatically once per turn (the first time either linked creature takes damage on each turn).

Mirror Ward

2nd-level, abjuration

Casting Time: 1 reaction, which you take when you are hit by an attack

Range: Self **Components:** S, M (a reflective surface held in one hand, such as a hand mirror or polished blade)

Duration: Instantaneous

You angle the reflective surface against the incoming strike. You gain +3 to your AC against the triggering attack, potentially causing it to miss.

If the attack misses, whether or not the bonus was the cause, the attack is reflected. Choose a creature within 15 feet of you; the attack is rerolled against that creature, using the original attacker's attack bonus, and deals its normal damage on a hit. A reflected attack cannot trigger reactions, and cannot be reflected again.

At Higher Levels. When you cast this spell using a spell slot of 3rd level or higher, the AC bonus increases by 1 for each slot level above 2nd.

3rd Level

Binding

3rd-level, transmutation

Casting Time: 1 action **Range:** 60 feet **Components:** V, S, M (a piece of chain or rope)
Duration: Concentration, up to 1 minute

You create a sustained binding between yourself and a creature you can see within range. The target must make a Strength saving throw. On a failure, the target is bound to your movement for the duration.

Whenever you move on your turn, the bound creature is dragged the same distance in the same direction. If the creature has its reaction available, the strain of resisting consumes it. This movement provokes opportunity attacks. If the creature would be dragged into a solid surface, it takes 2d6 bludgeoning damage and its movement stops at the surface; your own movement is unaffected.

The bound creature can repeat the Strength saving throw at the end of each of its turns, ending the effect on a success.

Limitations. The binding breaks if you and the target are ever more than 120 feet apart, or on different planes of existence.

At Higher Levels. When you cast this spell using a spell slot of 5th level or higher, the collision damage increases to 3d6 and the creature has disadvantage on its saves to end the effect.

Prism Shell

3rd-level, abjuration

Casting Time: 1 action **Range:** Self **Components:** V, S, M (a glass prism)

Duration: Concentration, up to 1 minute

You surround yourself with a shell of refracted light. For the duration:

You have half cover (+2 to AC and Dexterity saving throws) against attacks originating from more than 10 feet away.

When a ranged attack (weapon or spell) misses you while this spell is active, you can use your reaction to redirect the attack toward a creature within 15 feet of you. The attack is rerolled against the new target, using the original attacker's attack bonus, and deals its normal damage on a hit.

The shell sheds dim light in a 5-foot radius and is faintly visible as a distortion in the air.

Sever

3rd-level, abjuration

Casting Time: 1 action

Range: Touch

Components: V, S, M (a small mirror, which is cracked as part of the casting)

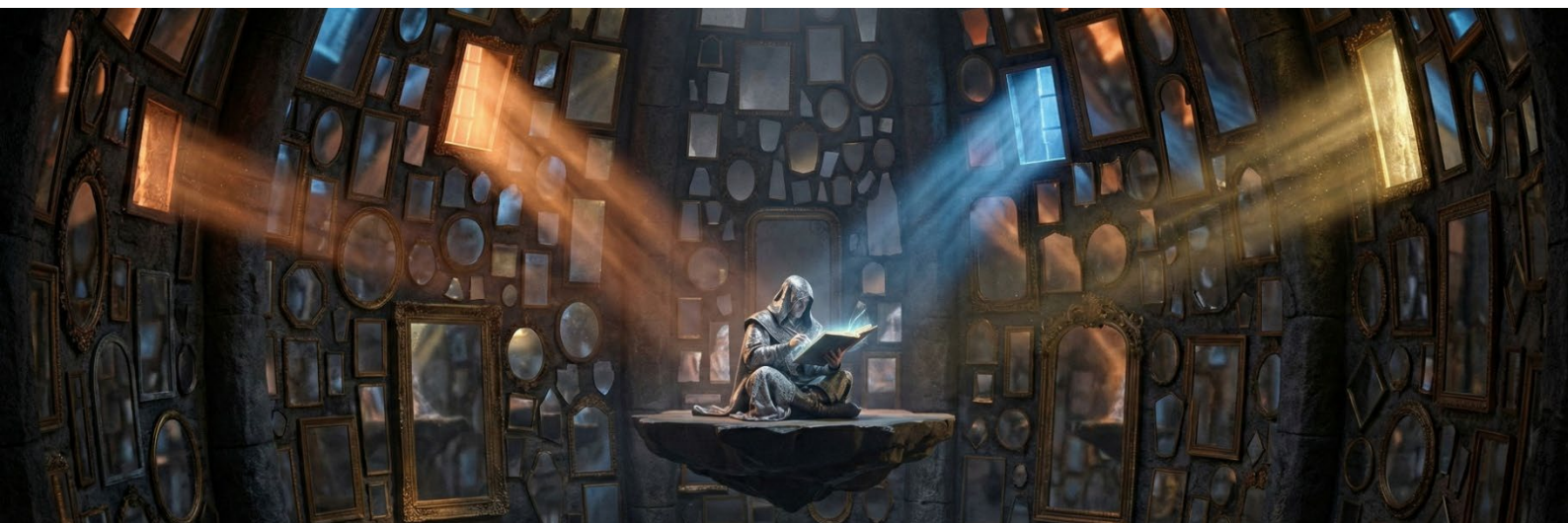
Duration: Instantaneous

You sever a specific connection affecting the target creature. Choose one of the following:

Magical Bond. You end one spell currently affecting the target, provided it is of 3rd level or lower and is a charm, fear, compulsion, or curse effect. For qualifying spells of 4th level or higher, make an ability check using your spellcasting ability (DC = 10 + the spell's level). This spell cannot end curses that are not spells (a cursed item's attunement, lycanthropy, a divine punishment); those require Remove Curse or stronger magic.

Temporary Suppression. You suppress a specific memory in a willing creature. The target loses access to one memory of your choice (specified during casting) for 24 hours. The memory returns fully after this period. The target is aware something has been suppressed but cannot recall what. A Remove Curse or Greater Restoration spell ends this effect early.

At Higher Levels. When you cast this spell using a spell slot of 5th level or higher, the Temporary Suppression duration extends to 7 days, and Magical Bond automatically ends qualifying spells of a level equal to or lower than the slot used. When you use a slot of 7th level or higher, the suppression duration extends to 30 days.



4th Level

Mirror Scry

4th-level, divination

Casting Time: 10 minutes **Range:** Touch (Prepare) or Unlimited, same plane (Observe) **Components:** V, S, M (a silver mirror worth at least 50 gp)

Duration: Instantaneous (Prepare) or Concentration, up to 10 minutes (Observe)

When you cast this spell, choose one of its two functions. Each function requires its own casting.

Prepare. You touch a reflective surface (a mirror, polished metal, a still pool of water) and mark it with an invisible arcane sigil. The sigil lasts until dispelled or until the surface is destroyed. You can have up to 5 surfaces prepared at a time. Preparing a new surface beyond this limit causes the oldest sigil to fade.

Observe. Using a silver mirror as a focus, you can see and hear through any surface you have previously prepared, as if you were standing directly before it. You can switch between prepared surfaces as an action. The observed surface shows whatever is within 30 feet of it. Creatures can detect the scrying sensor with a successful Wisdom (Perception) check against your spell save DC, noticing a faint shimmer in the reflective surface.

5th Level

Glasswalk

5th-level, conjuration

Casting Time: 1 action **Range:** 10 feet **Components:** V, S **Duration:** 1 round

You step into a mirror or reflective surface large enough for you to pass through (at least 5 feet tall for a Medium creature) and instantly teleport to another such surface that you have physically touched at some point in the past, on the same plane of existence. You emerge from the destination surface.

The entry surface remains an open portal until the end of your next turn. During this time, any creature that can fit through the surface can step through and arrive at the same destination. Once used as a portal, both surfaces become nonmagical and cannot be used for this spell again for 24 hours.

The destination surface must still exist and be intact at the time of casting. If the destination surface has been destroyed, the spell fails and the spell slot is not expended.

Unsyncronize

5th-level, enchantment

Casting Time: 1 minute

Range: Touch

Components: V, S, M (a Glaskatch personality shard worth at least 500 gp, which the spell consumes)

Duration: Instantaneous

You permanently sever the connection between a creature and a specific aspect of its identity. The target must be willing or incapacitated. An unwilling target, even an incapacitated one, makes a Wisdom saving throw as the casting completes. On a success, the spell fails and the shard is consumed anyway. Choose one of the following:

Memory. A specific memory, up to one hour of continuous experience, is permanently erased. The target retains skills and proficiencies learned during that time but loses all episodic recollection of the events.

Trait. A personality trait, bond, ideal, or flaw is permanently removed. The target's behavior shifts accordingly over the following days. This cannot remove racial traits, class features, or proficiencies.

Emotion. The target's capacity for a specific emotion (grief, fear, jealousy, love for a specific person) is permanently deadened. The target can still recognize situations where the emotion would apply but does not experience it.

A Greater Restoration spell cast within 24 hours of the severance restores what was removed. After that window closes, the severance cannot be reversed by anything besides a Wish spell. If the target was willing, they must confirm consent aloud as part of the casting. The target is aware of what will be removed but cannot, by the spell's nature, fully anticipate the consequences.

Repeated castings on the same creature are cumulative. A creature that has undergone more than three severances must make a Wisdom saving throw (DC 15) after each subsequent casting. On a failure, the creature suffers indefinite madness as determined by the GM.

Major Binding

5th-level, transmutation

Casting Time: 1 action

Range: 60 feet

Components: V, S, M (two lengths of chain, linked)

Duration: Concentration, up to 1 minute

You create a powerful binding between yourself and a creature you can see within range. The target must make a Strength saving throw. On a failure, the creature is bound to you for the duration, with the following effects:

Mirrored Movement. As with Binding, the target is dragged to match your movement, and the strain consumes its reaction if one is available. This movement provokes opportunity attacks. If the creature would be dragged into a solid surface, it takes 4d6 bludgeoning damage.

Shared Fate. When you are forced to make a saving throw against a spell or effect, you can use your reaction to force the bound creature to make the same saving throw against the same effect, as though it were also a target. The creature uses its own saving throw modifiers.

The bound creature can repeat the Strength saving throw at the end of each of its turns, at disadvantage, ending the effect on a success. The binding breaks if you and the target are ever more than 120 feet apart or on different planes.



6th Level

Mirror Prison

6th-level, conjuration

Casting Time: 1 action

Range: 60 feet

Components: V, S, M (a silver-framed mirror worth at least 1,000 gp)

Duration: Concentration, up to 1 hour

You attempt to trap a creature you can see within range inside a reflective surface. The component mirror must be large enough to display the target's full reflection; if it is not, the spell fails and the slot is not expended. The target must make a Charisma saving throw. On a failure, the creature is pulled into the mirror used as the material component for this spell. On a success, the creature is unaffected.

While imprisoned, the creature is aware of its surroundings as seen from within the mirror. It can see out and speak, though its voice sounds distant and distorted. The creature cannot interact with the physical world, cast spells that target anything outside the mirror, or take physical actions.

If the imprisoned creature is within line of sight of another reflective surface (a second mirror, a pool of water, polished armor), it can use its movement to transfer to that surface on its turn, provided the surface is large enough to display its full reflection. It cannot leave the reflective surface by any means while the spell persists.

The imprisoned creature can repeat the Charisma saving throw each time it transfers to a new surface, and once every 10 minutes otherwise, ending the effect on a success. The prison also ends when the spell's duration expires, when your concentration is broken, when the surface currently holding the creature is destroyed (the creature appears in the nearest unoccupied space, taking 4d6 force damage), or when the spell is dispelled.

7th Level

Doppler

7th-level, enchantment

Casting Time: 1 hour **Range:** Touch **Components:** V, S, M (a Glaskatch personality shard worth at least 5,000 gp, a mirror large enough to reflect both targets, and a drop of blood from the source creature — all consumed) **Duration:** Until dispelled

You overwrite one creature's identity onto another. This spell requires two creatures: the **source** (whose identity is copied) and the **vessel** (who receives it). Both must be present for the full casting time. The vessel must be incapacitated or willing. The source can be willing, incapacitated, or dead (dead no longer than 10 days).

Upon completion, the vessel's personality, memories, mannerisms, and emotional patterns are replaced with those of the source. The vessel retains its own physical body, hit points, and physical ability scores (Strength, Dexterity, Constitution), but its mental ability scores (Intelligence, Wisdom, Charisma) are replaced with those of the source. The vessel gains the source's proficiencies and class features, up to a total class level no greater than the vessel's own level or Hit Dice; capabilities beyond that limit are present as knowledge and memory but do not function, surfacing over time or never, at the GM's discretion.

The source creature is unaffected if alive and willing. Its identity is copied, not moved. If the source is dead, the copy is drawn from the body's residual imprint.

The vessel's original identity is suppressed, not destroyed. It persists beneath the surface. Under extreme duress, magical compulsion, or exposure to deeply personal stimuli from the vessel's original life, the GM may call for a Wisdom saving throw (DC equals your spell save DC). On a success, the vessel's original identity reasserts itself for 1d4 hours before being suppressed again. Each reassertion lowers the DC by 1.

The spell can be ended by Dispel Magic cast at 7th level or higher, by a Wish spell, or by performing this spell again on the vessel with intent to strip the overwritten identity without replacing it (consuming materials as normal, leaving the vessel in a confused, identity-less state for 2d6 days before their original self gradually returns).

At Higher Levels. When you cast this spell using a 9th-level spell slot, you can designate an object as the vessel. The source creature's identity is stripped from its body and bound to the object. The body is left alive but empty — breathing, responsive to stimulus, but with no personality, memory, or will. The identity within the object has no senses and no means of communication unless the object is reflective (a mirror, polished metal), in which case the trapped identity can perceive what the surface reflects and can speak, faintly, to those nearby.

8th Level

Refraction

8th-level, transmutation

Casting Time: 1 action

Range: 120 feet

Components: V, S, M (a shattered mirror, the pieces of which are thrown into the air during casting)

Duration: Concentration, up to 1 minute

You fracture the spatial geometry of a 60-foot cube originating from a point you can see within range. For the duration, the affected area is warped by broken reflective symmetry:

Distorted Space. The area is difficult terrain for all creatures except you. Creatures other than you have disadvantage on Dexterity saving throws while within the area.

Bent Trajectories. Ranged weapon attacks and ranged spell attacks that pass through any part of the area have disadvantage.

Spatial Displacement. The first time a creature enters the area or starts its turn there, it must make an Intelligence saving throw. On a failure, the creature is teleported to a random unoccupied space within the area (roll a d8 for direction, d6 × 10 for distance in feet; if the result would place it outside the area, it appears at the nearest space within it). A creature that has made this save, whatever the outcome, is not subject to Spatial Displacement again unless it leaves the area and re-enters.

Mirror Passages. You can use a bonus action on your turn to swap the positions of two creatures within the area. Each creature must make a Charisma saving throw. The swap occurs only if both creatures fail; otherwise, neither moves.

Creatures with truesight are immune to the Spatial Displacement effect but are still affected by the other properties.

9th Level

Inversion

9th-level (classification never settled)

Casting Time: 1 minute

Range: Self

Components: V, S, M (a flawless mirror worth at least 25,000 gp, which shatters when the spell is cast)

Duration: Instantaneous

The ultimate expression of Specular philosophy. You step through the boundary between Virelia and the Mirror Realm.

Upon casting, your body on this side of the boundary becomes a reflection: visible in mirrors and reflective surfaces but physically absent. Your consciousness crosses into the Mirror Realm, whatever that may be. This is a one-way effect. There is no known counterspell, no reversal, no return. Wish can restore the caster's body to its last physical state, but it is unclear whether the consciousness that returns is the original or the reflection.

The flawless mirror shatters upon completion and cannot be repaired or reconstructed by any means short of divine intervention. The caster's reflection persists in mirrors and reflective surfaces near the casting location for 1d10 days, occasionally moving or speaking, before fading permanently.

GM Note. This spell is included for narrative completeness. It is not intended as a standard player option. A character who casts Inversion has, in mechanical terms, left the campaign. Whether the Mirror Realm exists, whether the caster survives the crossing, and what (if anything) looks back from the other side is entirely at the GM's discretion. The Speculars consider this spell a success. Everyone else considers it suicide. Neither side has conclusive evidence.

The Halcyon League

The Veins of Virelia



A Matter of Opinion

Unpopular as it is, I retain my position that the Halcyons are a bank dressed up as something more in order to claim neutrality, exploit its workers and retain a virtuous image, with the goodwill that comes alongside it. An army of skilled runners, inns to house them, and the only established financial network on the continent. The more generous narrative is that they're an organization which dedicates itself to maintaining communication throughout Virelia, which also maintains a banking front, "on the side," to fund its pursuit of this grand goal. Most Virelians, and certainly most Halcyons, prefer the latter narrative. That's not to say that it's more true, only that it is more convenient.

Some of my colleagues argue we should judge the Halcyons by their philosophy and intentions, which are, by all accounts, rather noble. Silly old me prefers to judge things by the physical reality, not some naive notion of what might be going through someone's head. And in the physical reality, the Halcyons possess more money and more leverage than most governments, and a history of using both, with a splash of violence here and there.

